

RAFFLES INSTITUTION YEAR 6 GENERAL PAPER 2025 INFORMATION PACKAGE Unit: Global Issues			
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1. Introduction

Global Issues aims to give a broad overview of recent issues that have significance on a global scale. A quick survey of international news media will reveal the prominence of issues such as globalisation, climate change, population growth, poverty and migration due to their wide-ranging global impact that will likely endure for many years to come. Given the sheer breadth of these issues, *Global Issues* has adopted an approach that focuses on facilitating a quick grasp of fundamental concepts needed for active participation in class discussions and critical evaluation of issues. It is hoped that the factsheets/infosheets and the views and perspectives articulated by notable individuals will give students a broad framework within which they can appreciate the dynamic development of global issues.

What this package is:

This package is meant to supplement your learning in class by spurring independent thinking and facilitating active discussion on questions and key issues. It is also intended for self-study to gain content knowledge, as well as reflection upon key issues raised. The articles in this package are selected and customised to be of the standard of comprehension expected of an A-level candidate. Related examination questions are highlighted beneath each article—these are meant to guide your thinking and focus your learning. For students interested in going further, links and suggested readings are provided where appropriate. For students requiring background information, particularly with regards to specific countries, additional links are also provided beneath the appropriate articles.

What this package is not:

This package is NOT an exercise in memory and regurgitation, nor is it a “model answer”. General Paper is not about thoughtless memorisation of facts and/or essay scaffolds. It is about close reading of sources, critical analysis of issues raised, and the formation and clear expression of your own logically sound opinions, which are substantiated by factual evidence.

Please note that American spelling has been retained for some articles as they are by American writers or from American publications.

2. Enduring Understandings and Essential Questions:

Enduring Understandings: What will students understand as a result of this unit?

EU1: Globalisation is a multi-faceted phenomenon: we see this increased mobility, interconnectivity and exchange economically, politically and socially.

EU2: The particular circumstances of different countries and individuals have a significant bearing on whether they are on the receiving end of the benefits or detriments of globalisation.

Globalisation has brought about progress in various areas. However, this progress brings tensions and consequences, which governments, international organisations and individuals need to address.

EU3: States use the transnational structures and bodies facilitated by globalisation to advance national interests, but these also create global responsibilities that need to be balanced alongside national interests.

EU4: One key trade-off resulting from globalisation is that between economic growth and environmental sustainability.

EU5: Another consequence is that while globalisation has generated wealth, uneven distribution of both resources and growth has contributed to poverty and inequality.

EU6: There are also social and cultural consequences; the renewed interest in cultural preservation and the rise of xenophobia are symptoms of the backlash against globalisation.

EU7: Additionally, there are geopolitical consequences: the nature of conflict has changed, in line with changing social, political, economic factors and technological advances.

EU8: Moreover, there are consequences for health security: perennial health threats are exacerbated through transnational networks of people and goods.

Essential Questions: What are the essential questions of this unit?

- Is globalisation a positive or negative development?
- Does globalisation make the state obsolete? How do global issues and interests influence the development of the state today?
- What forces influence, challenge, resist and/or conciliate and mitigate the processes and consequences of globalisation?
- What causes an issue to become a global issue?
- Is human security 'freedom from fear' or 'freedom from want', or both?

3. For Further Reading and Viewing

Recommended reading:

1. **50 facts that should change the world** by Jessica Williams (2004) [362.9090511 WIL]
2. **Beyond the Age of Innocence: Rebuilding Trust Between America and the World** by Kishore Mahbubani (2005) [327.73 MAH]
3. **Bound Together** by Nayan Chanda (2007)
4. **False Dawn: The Delusions of Global Capitalism** by John Gray (2002) [330.122 GRA]
5. **Journey Into Islam: The Crisis of Globalisation** by Akbar Ahmed (2007) [297.09 AHM]
6. **Globalisation and Its Discontents** (2002) and **Making Globalisation Work** (2006) by Joseph Stiglitz [337 STI]
– *the Nobel Prize-winning economist and former World Banker looks at the flaws of globalisation and suggests ways of making it work for both rich and poor.*
7. **In Defence of Globalisation** by Jagdish Bhagwati (2007) – *response to Stiglitz* [303.482 BHA]
8. **One No, Many Yeses: a journey to the heart of the global resistance movement** by Paul Kingsnorth (2004) – *informal travelogue* [303.484 KIN]
9. **The Borderless World** (1994) & **The End of the Nation State: The Rise of Regional Economies** (1996) by Kenichi Ohmae – *the management guru argues that nations are becoming obsolete from an economic viewpoint* [909.82 OHM/ 337.1 OHM]
10. **The End of Poverty: Economic Possibilities for Our Time** by Jeffrey Sachs (2005) – *analysis and guided tour of the world's poorest regions* 339.46 SAC]
11. **The Future of Globalisation: explorations in the light of recent turbulence** (ed.) by Ernesto Zedillo (2008) [337 FUR]
12. **The Globalisation Myth: Why the Protesters Have Got It Wrong** by Alan Shipman (2002) [338.88 SHI]
13. **The Clash of Civilisations and the Remaking of World Order** by Samuel P. Huntington (2002) [909.829 HUN]
14. **The Lexus and the Olive Tree: Understanding Globalisation** (2000) and **The World is Flat: A Brief History of the Globalised World in the 21st Century** (2005) by Thomas Friedman [337 FRI/ 303.4833 FRI]
15. **The New Asian Hemisphere : The Irresistible Shift of Power to the East** by Kishore Mahbubani (2008) [327.5 MAH]
16. **How To Avoid A Climate Disaster: The Solutions We Have and the Breakthroughs We Need** by Bill Gates (2021)

Recommended documentaries/films:

1. BBC Documentaries: **Masters of Money** and **Why Poverty?** (Available on YouTube)
2. **Illicit: The Dark Trade** (364.135 ILL)
3. **The Corporation (2003)** (Film is available on YouTube)
4. Economist: **Will covid kill globalisation? (2020)** (Available on YouTube)
5. Financial Times: **How the world could change in 2021** (Available on YouTube)

4. Related Cambridge and RI Essay Questions

Global Issues

A. Cambridge Exam Questions

1. Examine the claim that it is the responsibility of wealthier countries to assist in dealing with natural disasters. (Cambridge 2025)
2. 'Fossil fuels should no longer have a part to play in the production of energy.' Discuss. (Cambridge 2023)
3. 'Regret for past actions is vital for progress.' What is your view? (Cambridge 2023)
4. 'Consumerism is more of a curse than a blessing.' How true is this of your society? (Cambridge 2022)
5. Since the extinction of species is a natural phenomenon, is there any point in trying to prevent it? (Cambridge 2022)
6. To what extent can individuals shape their own lives when the world is so unpredictable? (Cambridge 2022)
7. Are global tourism and travel still necessary when everything can be experienced or achieved online? (Cambridge 2021)
8. Given greater levels of international cooperation, how necessary is it for countries to engage in the arms trade? (Cambridge 2020)
9. Should politicians pursue the popular viewpoint or their own convictions, if they conflict? (Cambridge 2020)
10. How far can prosperity and uncontrolled population growth go hand in hand? (Cambridge 2020)
11. Is globalisation to be welcomed or feared today? (Cambridge 2019)
12. 'A leader's responsibility should always be to his or her own country, not other nations.' Discuss. (Cambridge 2019)
13. How far should countries have relations with others whose human rights record is poor? (Cambridge 2019)
14. 'Science is the only answer to global hunger.' Discuss. (Cambridge 2019)
15. 'In the global village we inhabit, there is no justification for national boundaries.' How far do you agree? (Cambridge 2018)
16. Discuss the view that all countries have an equal responsibility to counter terrorism. (Cambridge 2018)
17. 'Works of art which have been removed from their country of origin should be returned.' Discuss. (Cambridge 2018)
18. 'Foreign aid does not solve long-term problems.' To what extent is this a fair viewpoint? (Cambridge 2018)
19. 'Countries experiencing conflict should be left to sort out their own problems.' How far do you agree? (Cambridge 2016)
20. 'No cause is ever worth dying for.' Discuss. (Cambridge 2015)
21. How far is it possible for one country to forgive another for its past actions? (Cambridge 2015)
22. How far should firms be allowed to limit their worker's rights when profits are at stake? (Cambridge 2014)
23. How far is it important for people to be aware of current events in countries other than their own? (Cambridge 2014)
24. Is there any point in trying to predict future trends? (Cambridge 2013)
25. 'The world would be a better place if more political leaders were women.' What is your view? (Cambridge 2013)
26. Discuss the claim that in the modern world people should care more about international than national issues. (Cambridge 2013)
27. Why should we be concerned with current affairs when most of them will soon be forgotten? (Cambridge 2013)
28. Is there any value in preserving minority languages in the world? (Cambridge 2012)

B. RI Exam Questions

1. Is foreign aid ultimately more damaging than beneficial to the countries it aims to support? (RI 2025 Y6 Prelim)

2. Is it right for a leader to place national interests above global responsibilities? (RI Y6 Prelim 2025)
3. 'Only powerful nations have a significant voice in global affairs.' Discuss. (RI Y6 Prelim 2024)
4. Is it still wise to put our hopes in international organisations? (RI Y6 TP 2024)
5. 'The world would be a better place if everyone spoke the same language.' Do you agree? (RI Y6 Prelim 2023)
6. 'The wars of the future will not be fought on the battlefield.' How far do you agree? (RI Y6 CT 2023)
7. To what extent is diplomacy effective in dealing with conflicts today? (RI Y6 Timed Practice 2023)
8. Big companies are concerned only with profits.' Is this a fair assessment? (RI Y6 Prelims 2022)
9. 'Workers today have never had it better.' Is this an accurate view? (RI Y6 Prelims 2022)
10. Is conflict inevitable in today's volatile world? (RI Y6 Prelims 2022)
11. Consider the value of travelling for leisure in the world today. (RI Y6 Timed Practice 2022)
12. Consider the view that only the developed world can afford to be concerned about animal welfare. (RI Y6 CT 2021)
13. 'We have paid too high a price for globalisation.' Do you agree? (RI Y6 CT 2021)
14. 'International organisations are ineffective at resolving conflict.' To what extent do you agree? (RI Y6 Timed Practice 2021)
15. In view of the global health threats today, should international travel still be encouraged? (RI Y6 Timed Practice 2021)
16. Should international sporting events be used to highlight issues unrelated to sport? (RI Y5 Common Essay Assignment 2021)
17. 'International organisations are ineffective at resolving conflict.' To what extent do you agree? (RI Y6 Timed Practice 2021)
18. In view of the global health threats today, should international travel still be encouraged? (RI Y6 Timed Practice 2021)
19. Should a country still be concerned with national boundaries in today's interconnected world? (RI Y6 CT2 2020)
20. Why is it that, in spite of international efforts, world peace remains unattainable? (RI Y6 CT1 2020)
21. How effective have global efforts been in addressing the spread of diseases? (RI Y6 CT1 2020)
22. To what extent are young people in your society prepared for a world that is constantly changing? (RI Y6 Prelim 2019)
23. In the light of increasing security threats, should countries still embrace the notion of a borderless world? (RI Y6 CT2 2019)
24. Assess the view that international organisations are mostly ineffective. (RI Y6 Prelim 2018)
25. To what extent is the idea of a world with no national boundaries a realistic one? (RI Y6 CT2 2018)
26. 'The provision of financial or material aid to countries in need does more harm than good.' Discuss. (RI Y6 CT2 2018)
27. 'The surge of global tourism is starting to feel overwhelming.' Is this reflective of tourism today? (RI Y5 Promo 2018)
28. Should refugees be viewed as a burden in modern society? (RI Y5 Promo 2018)
29. Should international sporting events be used to highlight issues unrelated to sport? (RI Y5 CT 2018)
30. How far can scientific or technological developments be a solution to global problems? (RI Y5 CT 2018)
31. Is harmony possible in a diverse world? (RI Y6 CT2 2017)
32. 'In an increasingly uncertain world, there is little point in predicting the future.' Discuss. (RI Y6 Prelim 2017)
33. 'If you have not left your borders, you have not learnt much.' How true is this? (RI Y5 CT1 2017)
34. 'Migration should be encouraged in today's world.' How far do you agree? (RI Y6 CT1 2017)
35. Discuss the view that countries should always take in refugees. (RI Y6 CT1 2016)
36. 'The use of violence inevitably leads to more problems.' What is your view? (RI Y6 CT1 2016)
37. 'The strong do what they want, the weak suffer what they must.' To what extent is this true of the world today? (RI Y6 CT2 2016)
38. 'We care for the developed world at the expense of the developing world.' Discuss. (RI Y6 CT2 2016)

39. To what extent should the movement of people across borders be restricted in the modern world? (RI Y6 Prelim 2016)
40. Examine the extent to which one country's intervention in another country's problems is justified. (RI Y6 Prelim 2016)
41. Should international aid only be given to others during times of economic prosperity? (RI Y6 Prelim 2015)
42. Migration creates more problems than it provides solutions. Discuss. (RI Y6 CT2 2015)
43. Can the trade in weapons ever be justified? (RI Y6 CT2 2015)
44. 'All talk but no action.' Discuss this in relation to global response to acts of aggression today. (RI Y6 CT1 2015)
45. 'Migration is a necessity, not an option.' What do you think? (RI Y5 Promo 2015)
46. 'Human trafficking can never be abolished.' Discuss. (RI Y6 CT1 2014)
47. 'Multiculturalism has failed utterly.' Is this an accurate assessment of societies today? (RI Y6 CT1 2014)
48. 'International cooperation has not solved the global problems of today.' Do you agree? (RI Y6 CT2 2014)
49. With reference to the developments in the world today, to what extent would you agree that the future holds much promise for young people? (RI Y6 CT1 2013)
50. 'Globalisation has made us more vulnerable.' To what extent is this true? (RI Y6 CT1 2013)
51. Can we ever eliminate terrorism? (RI Y6 CT2 2013)
52. How important is it for an individual to be aware of international events and issues? (RI Y6 CT2 2013)
53. 'Foreign intervention in a developing nation does more harm than good.' Comment. (RI Y6 Prelims 2013)
54. "Developing countries can only benefit from tourism." Discuss. (RI Y5 CT 2012)
55. Consider the importance of global trends in your society. (RI Y5 CT 2012)
56. To what extent can a world that is increasingly multicultural be stable? (RI Y6 CT2 2012)
57. "Global businesses today have lost sight of their moral compass." Do you agree? (RI Y6 CT2 2012)
58. "The rise of the East and fall of the West are inevitable." Do you agree? (RI Year 6 CT2 2012)
59. Consider the view that globalisation destroys culture. (RI Y5 CT 2011)
60. 'The prospect of a global village is a depressing one.' Discuss. (RI Y6 Prelims 2011)

Environment

A. Cambridge Exam Questions

1. Assess the view that attempts to control climate change can never be truly effective. (Cambridge 2017)
2. Assess the view that most natural disasters are the result of human activity. (Cambridge 2016)
3. In your society, how well are the demands of the economy and the environment balanced? (Cambridge 2015)
4. Should there be any controls over the production of energy when the need for it is so great? (Cambridge 2015)
5. Discuss the view that, with an increasing global need for energy, every possible source should be exploited to the full. (Cambridge 2014)
6. How important is it to save plant and animal species which are in danger of extinction? (Cambridge 2013)

B. RI Exam Questions

1. 'Developed nations should shoulder a greater burden in addressing climate change.' To what extent do you agree? (RI Y6 Prelim 2025)
2. 'The solution to climate change is not to be found in technology but by having a simpler lifestyle.' How far do you agree? (RI Y6 Prelims 2023)
3. Should plastic be banned? (RI Y6 Common Test 2023)
4. Given its environmental impact, is global tourism still desirable today? (RI Y6 Common Test 2023)
5. Consider the view that a more sustainable future lies in the way we eat, not in renewable energy. (RI Y6 Prelims 2022)
6. 'Sustainable development is not sustainable.' Comment. (RI Y6 Timed Practice 2022)

7. How far do you agree that good governance is key to the protection of the environment? (RI Y6 Prelim 2021)
8. 'Saving the environment is all talk and no action.' Do you agree? (RI Y5 CT 2021)
9. 'As long as economic goals remain a priority, the environment is a lost cause.' Comment. (RI Y6 Prelim 2020)
10. 'All countries should have an equal responsibility in tackling climate change.' How far do you agree? (RI Y6 CT2 2020)
11. 'The effects of environmental degradation impact the poor the hardest.' Discuss. (RI Y6 CT2 2018)
12. 'The best way to combat climate change is through education.' Discuss. (RI Y6 CT1 2018)
13. 'Consumerism is a curse on the environment.' Discuss. (RI Y5 Promo 2018)
14. 'All talk and no action.' How accurately does this describe environmental conservation today? (RI Y6 CT1 2017)
15. 'The greatest obstacle to environment conservations is human apathy.' Discuss. (RI Y6 CT2 2016)
16. In times of economic difficulty, should a country still be concerned with environmental conservation? (RI Y6 Prelim 2016)
17. Examine the claim that not enough has been done for the environment in your society. (RI Y5 Promo 2016)
18. 'The developed world should bear the burden of climate change.' Discuss. (RI Y6 Prelim 2015)
19. 'Not enough is being done to protect endangered animals.' Do you agree? (RI Y5 CT1 2015)
20. 'The environment should be the responsibility of the individual, not the government.' Comment. (RI Y6 Prelim 2014)
21. 'Everyone should be involved.' How practical is this approach in tackling environmental issues? (RI Y5 Promo 2013)
22. Consider the view that economic growth always brings environmental damage. (RI Y6 CT1 2013)
23. "Protecting the environment is a futile pursuit." Discuss (RI Y5 Promo 2012)
24. Discuss the view that the environment can only be saved through the efforts of developed nations. (RI Y6 Prelims 2011)
25. Are concerns about the need for us to conserve the environment exaggerated? (RI Y5 Promo 2011)

World Poverty and Health

A. Cambridge Exam Questions

1. How far can prosperity and uncontrolled population growth go hand in hand? (Cambridge 2020)
2. 'Science is the only answer to global hunger.' Discuss. (Cambridge 2019)
3. In times of economic hardship, should a country still be expected to provide financial or material aid to others? (Cambridge 2014)

B. RI Exam Questions

1. Assess the view that poor nations are more vulnerable than ever in today's world. (RI Y6 Common Test 2023)
2. 'The solution to global hunger is simply about providing more food.' How far do you agree? (RI Y6 Timed Practice 2022)
3. Consider the impact of technology on world hunger today. (RI Y6 CT2 2019)
4. Assess the impact of technology on health in today's world. (RI Y5 Promo 2018)
5. 'The effects of environmental degradation impact the poor the hardest.' Discuss. (RI Y6 CT2 2018)
6. 'To what extent is education an effective way to combat poverty?' (RI Y5 CT1 2017)
7. 'Eradicating poverty is a battle we have no chance of winning.' Do you agree? (RI Y5 Promo 2016)
8. 'Disease is the greatest threat facing mankind today.' To what extent do you agree with this statement? (RI Y6 Prelim 2015)
9. Is it possible to do more to protect the children of the world? (RI Y6 CT2 2013)
10. 'Make poverty history.' Is this a realistic goal? (RI Y5 CT 2013)
11. 'The problem of global food shortage can never be resolved.' Do you agree? (RI Y6 Prelim 2013)
12. Consider the view that modern technology is the only answer to world hunger. (RI Y6 Prelim 2012)

SECTION A: FOUNDATIONAL KNOWLEDGE

Reading 1: Globalisation – An Explainer

EU 1-5

This reading helps you understand:

- What globalisation really is
- How it is best conceptualised and defined
- How globalisation contributes to the emergence of a distorted global politics which is highly skewed in favour of a global political elite
- Some ethical challenges posed by the realities of this distorted global politics
- How a hyper-connected world has changed the face of globalisation

Globalisation has become one of the defining buzzwords of our time - a term that describes a variety of complex economic, political, cultural, ideological, and environmental forces that are rapidly altering our experience of the world.

A. What is globalisation? Is it simply inter-connectedness?

It is a process characterised by:

1. A **stretching** of social, political, and economic activities across political frontiers so that events, decisions and activities in one region of the world come to have significance for individuals and communities in distant regions of the globe. Civil wars and conflicts in the world's poorest regions, for instance, increase the flow of asylum seekers and illegal migrants into the world's affluent countries.
2. The intensification, or the **growing magnitude**, of inter-connectedness, in almost every sphere of social existence from the economic to the ecological, from the activities of Microsoft to the harmful spread of microbes, such as the SARS virus, from the intensification of world trade to the spread of weapons of mass destruction.
3. The **accelerating pace** of global interactions and process as the evolution of worldwide systems of transport and communication increases the rapidity and velocity with which ideas, news, goods, information, capital, and technology move around the world. Routine telephone banking interactions in the UK are handled by call centres in India in real time, while the 2008 financial crisis displayed a synchronised collapse of stock markets within hours rather than in weeks as in the Great Crash of 1929. Look at how Covid-19 is spreading across the world.
4. The **growing extensity, intensity, and velocity** of global interactions is associated with a deepening enmeshment of the local and global in so far as local events may come to have global consequences and global events can have serious local consequences, creating a growing collective awareness or consciousness of the world as a shared social space, that is **globalism**. Clearly, there is more to globalisation than simply inter-connectedness.

B. What are the engines of globalisation?

1. **Technology:** central to any account of globalisation since it is a truism that without a modern communications infrastructure, a global system or worldwide economy would not be possible
2. **Economics:** as crucial as technology; capitalism's insatiable demand for new markets and profits inevitably leads to the globalisation of economic activity
3. **Politics:** shorthand here for ideas, interests, and power; if technology provides the physical infrastructure of globalisation, politics provides its normative structure.
4. **Culture:** Cultural consumption, which is the sharing of ideas, meanings, hobbies, and values around the world intensifies social relations. This process has been diffused by the Internet, popular culture, the media, and international travel.

C. What are the patterns of contemporary globalisation?

Globalisation, to varying degrees, is evident in all the principal sectors of social interaction:

1. Economic:

- In the economic sphere, patterns of worldwide trade, finance and production are creating global markets, and in the process, a single global capitalist economy.
- MNCs organise production and marketing on a global basis while the operation of global financial markets determines which countries get credit and upon what terms.

2. Military:

- In the military domain, the global arms trade, the proliferation of WMDs, the growth of transnational terrorism, the growing significance of military corporations, and the discourse of global insecurity point to the existence of a global military order.

3. Legal:

- The expansion of transnational and international law from trade to human rights alongside the creation of new world legal institutions such as the International Criminal Court is indicative of an emerging global legal order.

4. Ecological:

- A shared ecology involves shared environmental problems, from global warming to species protection, alongside the creation of multilateral responses and regimes of global environmental governance.

5. Cultural:

- This involves a complex mix of homogenisation and increased heterogeneity given the global diffusion of popular culture, global media corporations, communications networks, etc. simultaneously with the reassertion of nationalism, ethnicity, and difference. Few cultures are hermetically sealed off from cultural interaction.

6. Social:

- Shifting patterns of migration from South to North and East to West have turned migration into a major global issue as movements come close to the record levels of the great 19th century movements of people.

7. Health:

- Globalisation and surging trade and travel within countries and across national borders has lifted billions out of poverty but has also spread infectious diseases.
 - o E.g. The epicentre of Covid-19, Wuhan, is typical of many mid-size Chinese cities. In 30 years it has grown from 2 million to over 11 million people, and average incomes have shot up. As in other mushrooming cities, poor hygiene and lax enforcement of regulations co-exist with people and animals living in proximity, near airports from which a virus can spread anywhere in 36 hours.
- Pandemics are unlike other global risks in that they can originate anywhere. In the case of threats posed by financial systems, climate change, antibiotic resistance or in cyber space, a few actors can reduce the risk. Not so with pandemics, where capacity to monitor and intervene to isolate outbreaks everywhere is vital, especially in the poorest countries. A global effort to develop vaccines is needed. Sharing information and resources is essential.

D. Globalisation and Ethical Challenges

Globalisation is a powerful force, but because by definition it extends across political and social boundaries, the traditional mechanisms which shape and control human behaviour and decision making may prove ineffective in maintaining ethical behaviour and decision making.

There is nothing wrong with greater manifestations of social interdependence that emerge as a result of globalisation. However, these transformative social processes must have a moral compass and an ethical

polestar guiding our collective efforts: the building of a truly egalitarian global order that protects universal human rights without destroying the cultural diversity that is the lifeblood of human evolution.

Focus: TNCs/Global Businesses and Ethical Dilemmas

Since the 1970s, globalisation, deregulation and technological change triggered a rapid expansion of multinational corporations (MNCs) to every corner of the planet. By the year 2000, some 63,000 multinational companies with more than 690,000 foreign affiliates accounted for 25% of world production. These “new Leviathans” became increasingly powerful and regulating them became more challenging. Corporations took advantage of regulatory arbitrage, relocating to low tax jurisdictions and lax regulations on labour and environment. Multinationals structured global value chains by relocating purchase, sales, support and product development activities to locations where they could be done better, faster or cheaper. These are major ethical dilemmas facing TNCs.

1. Labour standards

When companies started offshoring in the 1960s and 1970s, they wanted to take advantage of lower costs available overseas, especially in less developed economies. Offshoring raised a number moral dilemmas ranging from sweatshops, child labour, differences in worker safety standards, etc.

2. Environmental standards:

Technological progress triggered exponential growth in human ability to alter the environment. While this has countless benefits, it also raises a number of dilemmas about the use of natural resources in societies with poor environmental regulations.

3. Human rights

Global businesses linked to operations with governments accused of violating human rights

4. Cultural diversity

Principles of international law hold that corporations ought to respect the customs and culture of the communities where they operate. Traditional values can be lost to the homogenising trends introduced by globally integrated production processes. Some amount of change is inevitable and certain local practices may not deserve protection if they violate important minimum global norms.

5. Corruption

Corruption is a concept that agglomerates practices ranging from multi-million dollar payments to high government officials to a few dollars bribe to a low-level bureaucrat. It is estimated that over \$1 trillion are paid in bribes annually, which squanders public resources and deprives millions of food, education and other government services to which they are entitled.

However, when should a norm be respected because of cultural diversity considerations and when should it be ignored because it violates a global minimum?

Case Study: Global production networks: Apple’s iPhone and iPad

- How should a company behave when the standards followed in the host country are lower than those followed in the home country?
- Do global production networks have ethical implications for consumers? Why or why not?

Across the world there are literally hundreds of millions of Apple product users, from the iPhone to the iPad. You may be one yourself. Have you ever thought about where these products are designed, manufactured, and assembled? Certainly many politicians do, as the practice of outsourcing production has become highly politicised given its impact on jobs and economic welfare. Such consequences are complex as there are both winners and losers, locally and globally. As consumers, we are often unaware of the extensive webs of global production and distribution

networks behind the products we purchase or the mobile devices that we hold in the palms of our hands.

These devices involve an extensive global production and distribution network, from design teams at Apple headquarters in the US to assembly plants in China and Brazil and over 700 suppliers across the world from Malaysia to Malta. To this must be added the global raw material supplier networks, for instance, cobalt for batteries, which are essential to the manufacture of every single component. There is no simple response to the question: where are iPhones and iPads made? The most accurate but least illuminating response might be: everywhere.

Global production networks are integral to our daily lives whether as consumers, workers, or producers. They raise novel and profound ethical, social, and political questions for us both as individuals and citizens. **In an economically interdependent world, we now have a shared responsibility for the fate and well-being of workers and communities in distant parts of the world.**

Read:

The Guardian: Life and Death in Apple's Forbidden City

<https://www.theguardian.com/technology/2017/jun/18/foxconn-life-death-forbidden-city-longhua-suicide-apple-iphone-brian-merchant-one-device-extract>

Research:

What are some major ethical dilemmas that Apple faces in the 21st century?

E. Opposing Opinions: Is globalisation a source of order or disorder in world politics?

For	Against
<i>Globalisation contributes to order by promoting interdependence and prosperity</i> - deepening interdependence and the spread of prosperity reinforce global stability and the diffusion of democracy	<i>Globalisation is a source of great power competition</i> - globalisation is an instrument of great power politics and control such that it is a source of inter-state rivalry and therefore global instability
<i>Interdependence promotes peaceful relations among great powers</i> - globalisation has been associated with the 'long peace' between the superpowers during the Cold War and the decline of inter-state war	<i>Globalisation creates an increasingly divided and fractious world order</i> - Ipso facto capitalist globalisation is responsible for intensifying worldwide inequalities, economic rivalry, competition for resources, environmental degradation, and economic insecurity, producing a highly unstable world order primed for recurrent crises and conflict
<i>Globalisation enhances human security</i> - Economic globalisation has contributed to an unprecedented reduction in people living in poverty and an expanding global middle class, both of which are associated with the conditions for global stability, security, and peace.	<i>Globalisation is a source of conflict and insecurity</i> - Globalisation is sometimes viewed as neo-imperialism in many parts of the world - This has provoked cultural, political, and sometimes violent backlashes, followed by Western counter-responses which all make for an increasingly unruly and disordered world
<i>Globalisation creates the conditions for a more stable world order</i>	<i>Globalisation generates the conditions for a more unruly world</i>

- Globalisation has contributed to the emergence of new power centres and thereby to a multipolar world order limiting the likelihood of any single power becoming a dominant or a global hegemon	- The same infrastructure that enables globalisation also facilitates transnational criminal activity, human trafficking, the drugs trade, transnational terrorism, and other forces that contribute to societal insecurity and an unruly world
<i>Globalisation requires shared rules, thereby promoting the international rule of law</i> - With globalisation has come a growing rule of law in international relations and the emergence of a global civil society, both of which contribute to stability and world order	<i>Globalisation is a source of crisis</i> - In a more inter-connected world, the everyday functioning of societies is increasingly vulnerable to distant threats or systemic crises, from cyber disruption to terror attacks, from the global financial crisis to health pandemics, generating new insecurities and instabilities that make for a disorderly world

F. How does globalisation affect our everyday life?

1. Globalisation also influences everyday life as much as it does events happening on a world scale. Globalisation isn't only about what is 'out there', remote and far away from the individual. It is an 'in here' phenomenon too, influencing intimate and personal aspects of our lives.
2. The debate about family values (sexuality, marriage, and family values), for example, that is going on in many countries might seem far removed from globalising influences. It isn't. Traditional family systems are becoming transformed, or are under strain, in many parts of the world, particularly as women stake claim to greater equality. There has never before been a society, so far as we know from the historical record, in which women have been even approximately equal to men. In most parts of the world, women are staking claim to greater autonomy than in the past and are entering the labour force in large numbers. This is a truly global revolution in everyday life, whose consequences are being felt around the world in spheres from work to politics.
3. Such aspects of globalisation are at least as important as those happening in the global market-place. They contribute to the stresses and strains affecting traditional ways of life and cultures in most regions of the world. The traditional family is under threat, is changing, and will change much further. Other traditions, such as those connected with religion, are also experiencing major transformations.
4. An emerging consequence of the above is that the battleground of the twenty-first century will pit fundamentalism against cosmopolitan tolerance. In a globalising world, where information and images are routinely transmitted across the globe, we are all regularly in contact with others who think differently, and live differently, from ourselves. Cosmopolitans welcome and embrace this cultural complexity. Fundamentalists find it disturbing and dangerous. Whether in the areas of religion, ethnic identity or nationalism, they take refuge in a renewed and purified tradition – and, quite often, violence.

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SECTION A: FOUNDATIONAL KNOWLEDGE

Reading 2: World Order and Challenges to It - Understanding the State of the World Today

EU 3, 7

This set of FAQs helps you:

- Understand the state of the world today
- The evolving power dynamics between nation-states, in particular, the superpowers
- The role of international organisations and non-state actors in shifting the geopolitical balance of power

1) What is the world order and why do we want to understand it?

The world order refers to a global system recognised by most countries, especially a set of arrangements established internationally for preserving global political stability. It is an international relations term describing the distribution of power amongst world powers.

Particularly today, as the balance of power shifts from a **unipolar world order to a multipolar world order**, it is important for us to understand this evolving and dynamic polarity. As nations shift and re-align themselves in the geopolitical balance of power, it affects every aspect of our lives, from large-scale multi-lateral intervention into wars, to economic disruptions in global and national trade, to local policy-making that affects the lives of everyone in society.

2) Wait, what is polarity?

This refers to how power is distributed amongst the world powers. For instance, in a *unipolar* world order (the world, since the collapse of the USSR, which left America as the sole superpower), there is only *one* superpower¹, who sets out the rules of international engagement, and acts as the arbiter in conflict situations.

This has both strengths as well as flaws, as with only one dominant power in the world, there can be stability and peace. However, the assumption is that the sole superpower acts *in the best interests of the world*. We can pause here to consider: to what extent has America in the past decades acted for the betterment of all nations?

In a bi- or multi-polar world order, there are more than one superpower. This can be beneficial for other countries, as the power of a dominant nation can be checked. However, it can also be a source of greater conflict and tension, as with more than one superpower, other nations can be drawn into unnecessary conflict, and are forced to choose sides.

This is more or less the state of the current world: we are changing **from a unipolar world order to an unknown world order**. America is waning in might economically, financially and technologically, in addition to Trump's isolationist approach which deliberately withdraws America from international engagements ranging from climate change pacts to trade deals and beyond. Meanwhile, China is rising fast, in particular, in the economic arena. With its stipulated globalist approach (evident in projects such as the One Belt One Road initiative), China is concertedly building diplomatic ties with other nations and investing heavily into them. Then there is Russia as well, with Vladimir Putin as a strongman, often allied with China.

This sets up much global tension, as a waning superpower (the U.S.) is confronted with an emergent superpower (China) as well as a resurgent one (Russia). The current US-China trade war is one manifestation

¹ *Superpowers refer to nations which dominate the world in terms of wealth, economy & trade, science & technology, military might and even soft cultural power.

of this conflict: it has affected many other nations apart from just the superpowers themselves, as global supply chains are hit and countries forced to choose sides.

In addition, proxy wars—such as that in Syria (with the US supporting anti-government rebels, and China and Russia supporting the government of Bashar al-Assad)—lead to protracted conflict in other nations, which are dragged into this battle for world supremacy². It also lends itself to the emergence of phenomena such as terrorism and international criminal cartels, who take the opportunity to run operations in weak nations where a power vacuum exists, due to lack of government. For instance, the conflict in Syria led to a power vacuum which resulted in the emergence of ISIS, just as the overthrow of Gaddafi in Libya in 2011 (direct intervention by NATO to support the rebels) led to human trafficking rings operating openly in Libya, where the current government is powerless to stop such crime³.

3) Okay, given this current battle for global dominance amongst superpowers, what are the challenges we may see in the coming years?

There are many challenges on multiple fronts. Three of the most pressing ones are:

(i) The return of geopolitical competition and the risk of superpower conflict (otherwise known as Great Power conflict)

Since 1991, the world has enjoyed a great power peace where war between the major states was highly unlikely. Unfortunately, this period appears to be ending. Several major powers are engaged in a robust security competition. The greatest risk stems from the rivalry between China and Japan in the East China Sea but rivalry also exists in Southeast Asia, between the United States and China, and to a lesser degree in Eastern Europe. In the Middle East, old enemies Iran and Saudi Arabia consistently destabilise the region through covert and overt means. The return of great power security competition not only threatens global peace—it might also complicate international cooperation to tackle common challenges.

(ii) Contagion effect in the global economic order

Many funds invest globally now as compared with the past. As well, global supply chains are now interlinked: an Apple iPhone for instance, could have its parts coming from factories in at least 5 different countries⁴. This means that when a trade war occurs, or if there is disruption in one country (due to natural disasters, epidemics economic sanctions, etc.), global supplies of goods and services could be badly affected. We see this in the Covid-19 situation happening in 2020: with countries in lockdown, trade freezes almost instantly, and countries will almost certainly be in recession. In addition, there is the complex new reality of the two top economies of U.S and China having very different structural dimensions and levels of per capita development: how they approach trade and allow for investments are different, and multi-national corporations need to be equipped to handle this.

(iii) The emergence of non-state actors

With the advancement of technology, in particular in weaponry and communications technology, there are new challenges to world order from an unconventional source: non-state actors.

Non-state actors refer to non-governmental parties, who have the power to influence events globally. Their influence could be beneficial or disruptive. From your ordinary man-in-the-street, who may launch a global campaign via social media activism—commonly referred to as the Fifth Estate—to international organisations, multi-national corporations, terrorist groups as well crime cartels, there are many players now who can work to stabilise or destabilise world order.

² <https://time.com/5162409/syria-civil-war-proxy-battles/>

³ <https://www.reuters.com/article/us-libya-trafficking-migrants-trfn/trafficking-risk-high-for-hundreds-of-migrants-sent-back-to-libya-idUSKBN1ZE15G>

⁴ <https://www.lifewire.com/where-is-the-iphone-made-1999503>

For instance, the Arab Spring which began in 2010 and the “Liberate Hong Kong” movement (slogan first popularised in 2016) were mostly started by citizens, who organised themselves via social media. The former resulted in the overthrow of many Middle Eastern dictators, while the latter poses one of the trickiest challenges to China’s paramount leader, Xi Jinping. Social media also lays claim to many hashtag activism movements which have raised global awareness of a number of causes, such as #MeToo to #BlackLivesMatter, and even to nation-specific issues, such as #BringBackOurGirls.

Terror groups now operate internationally as well, with cells in multiple countries: while Al-Qaeda is no longer as it was under Osama bin Laden, the group today has splintered into many different cells, which operate from countries as diverse as Pakistan, Algeria, Yemen and more. The power vacuums in weak nations such as Syria, Libya, and Yemen provide hotbeds and breeding grounds in which these groups can operate. In addition, with terror groups utilising the Internet, extremist ideology and propaganda spread beyond national borders now, and people who are discontented and disenfranchised within their own countries can become radicalised online, even without leaving their homes. The list of terror groups is endless: al-shabab, ISIS, Boko Haram... All of these groups cause problems for governments in the spectres of protracted conflict zones with multiple warlords and terror groups fighting for power, and lone wolf attacks, which occur in developed nations.

For further reading:

- <https://www.brookings.edu/research/the-state-of-the-international-order/>
- <https://www.weforum.org/agenda/2018/01/five-facts-you-need-to-understand-the-new-global-order/>

4) If this is world order, then where do international organisations (IOs) come in? What are IOs?

International organisations can be either governmental or non-governmental. International governmental organisations (IGOs) comprise of member states, who agree together on standards, protocols and conventions, which are then carried out in individual states. They provide a platform for collaboration and decision-making, as well as enable pooling of resources and coordination of efforts in the resolution of globalised or localised crises. The U.N is one such example, as are the International Monetary Fund, the World Bank and the World Trade Organisation.

International non-governmental organisations (INGOs) are essentially NGOs which have extended their operations to a global scale. These are mostly non-partisan, and have clearly stated aims and missions. For instance, the International Committee of the Red Cross’ mission is to ensure humanitarian protection of civilians affected by armed conflict and violence, and it is neutral⁵. Similarly, Médecins Sans Frontières (MSF, or Doctors without Borders) is guided by its principles of adherence to medical ethics, impartiality, independence and neutrality⁶. These INGOs can play a critical role, particularly in relief operations in conflict zones due to their neutrality.

5) Are these IOs important in a globalised world?

IOs can be highly important, as they provide a way for the world to work together in the resolution of issues. With the ability to collaborate and cooperate, the international community thus can pool resources and information more efficiently and act in a clear, standardised manner, than if every country were to act on its own haphazardly.

This is evident in the current Covid-19 crisis—with WHO coordination and member states sharing information as well as scientific research, nations can rapidly learn from each other as well as share information on the movement of people across borders, such that the pandemic can be (hopefully) stopped. It is also evident in

⁵ <https://www.icrc.org/en/who-we-are/mandate>

⁶ <https://www.msf.org/>

natural disasters in particular: with coordinated efforts, it ensures that those affected receive the help needed, while minimising wastage of resources.

International treaties and conventions also provide a way for the world to decide upon clear standards of acceptable behaviour, and form a platform to bring errant nation-states to task. For instance, the Geneva Conventions set out the rules of engagement for armed conflict, and the International Court of Justice (ICJ) as well as the International Criminal Court (ICC) provide platforms for nations and citizens to seek redress for war crimes, which are often beyond the ability of individual nations to arbitrate impartially.

6) Sounds good; but are there any pitfalls and downsides to IOs?

One major negative of IOs is that the treaties signed are non-ratifying. That is to say, while there may be conventions and standards drawn up, they are not legally-binding. Thus, countries do not necessarily have to obey rulings. Rogue nations such as North Korea routinely choose to disregard standards, just as America can, and has, unilaterally decide on military intervention in other nations, even if the UN opposes (See Iraq War of 2003).

Another downside is that IOs are often beholden to powerful member states; as such, they may often do the bidding of their wealthiest sponsors, or end up in a situation of gridlock when powerful member states disagree, which delays necessary action. This can be seen in the WHO's refusal to grant Taiwan observer status in the world body, and its lateness in declaring a pandemic—despite clear indications at least a month earlier, and the WHO's own vision of health for all peoples and to keep the world safe⁷--as China is a powerful sponsor of the WHO. It can also be seen in the gridlock over Syria, and in the annexation of Crimea, where the superpowers are in de facto proxy wars.

Even INGOs are not necessarily better, as there can be mismanagement of funds and lack of transparency in accountability⁸. In 2019, the Associated Press (AP) announced that the WHO had launched an investigation into the U.N. agency, UNICEF, and other international agencies for financial fraud in Yemen. Allegedly, billions of untraceable dollars in aid had been received by the INGO's since 2015.

In all, IOs play a critical role in maintaining global peace and stability, however, they also have downsides to them.

⁷ <https://www.who.int/about/who-we-are/our-values>

⁸ <https://www.theguardian.com/world/2015/jun/05/red-cross-haiti-black-hole-accountability-international-aid>

SECTION A: FOUNDATIONAL KNOWLEDGE

Reading 3: The Global Economy: Issues and Implications

EU 1-2, 5

Adapted from *How does the global economy work?* | www.edology.com | Undated

This reading will help you to:

- Gain a broad understanding of how the global economy functions and also be made aware of the meaning of specific terms used in such contexts.
- Understand the pros and cons of having a global economy and the wider impact that it has on the rest of the world.

The global economy has changed significantly over the past few decades, in the way that it is organised and governed by collaborating nations. These changes have repercussions that not only affect the flow of goods and services between countries, but also the movement of people. As we've seen on occasions over the last century, too great a fluctuation in this international economic system can lead to a global economic crisis.

What is a global economy?

The global economy refers to the interconnected worldwide economic activities that take place between multiple countries. These economic activities can have either a positive or negative impact on the countries involved.

The global economy comprises several characteristics, such as:

Globalisation: Globalisation describes a process by which national and regional economies, societies, and cultures have become integrated through the global network of trade, communication, immigration, and transportation. These developments led to the advent of the global economy. Due to the global economy and globalisation, domestic economies have become cohesive, leading to an improvement in their performances.

International trade: International trade is considered to be an impact of globalisation. It refers to the exchange of goods and services between different countries, and it has also helped countries to specialise in products which they have a comparative advantage in. This is an economic theory that refers to an economy's ability to produce goods and services at a lower opportunity cost than its trade partners.

International finance: Money can be transferred at a faster rate between countries compared to goods, services, and people; making international finance one of the primary features of a global economy. International finance consists of topics like currency exchange rates and monetary policy.

Global investment: This refers to an investment strategy that is not constrained by geographical boundaries. Global investment mainly takes place via foreign direct investment (FDI).

Why is the global economy important?

We can understand the importance of the global economy by looking at it in relation to emerging markets:

Economic importance at a micro and macro level: The increase in the world's population has led to emerging markets growing economically, making them one of the primary engines of world economic growth. The growth and resilience shown by emerging markets is a good sign for the world economy. Before delving into the next point, you need to understand the concept of microeconomics. It refers to the study of the behaviour of households, individuals, and firms with respect to the allocation of resources and decision-making. In simpler terms, this branch of economics studies how people make decisions, what factors affect their decisions, and how these decisions affect the price, demand, and

supply of goods in the market. Therefore, from the perspective of microeconomics, some of the largest firms with high market value and a few of the richest individuals in the world hail from these emerging markets, which has helped in the higher distribution of income in these countries. However, many of these emerging countries are still plagued by poverty, and work still needs to be done to work towards eradicating it.

Long-term world economic outlook: According to financial and economic projections based on demographic trends and capital productivity models, the GDP in emerging market economies in 2019 are likely to keep increasing at a positive rate. According to an emerging markets economic forecast for 2019 conducted by Focus Economics, the economy is set to increase by 7.5% in India, 6.6% in Philippines, 6.3% in China, 5.3% in Indonesia, 5.1% in Egypt, 4.9% in Malaysia, 3.8% in Peru and 3.7% in Morocco.

Who controls the global economy?

Many people think that the global economy is controlled by governments of the largest economies in the world, but this is a common misconception. Although governments do hold power over countries' economies, it is the big banks and large corporations that control and essentially fund these governments. This means that the global economy is dominated by large financial institutions. According to world economic news, US banks participate in many traditional government businesses like power production, oil refining and distribution, and also the operating of public assets such as airports and train stations. This was proven when certain members of the US Congress sent a letter to the Federal Reserve Chairman Ben Bernanke. Here's an excerpt from the letter:

"Here are a few examples. Morgan Stanley imported 4 million barrels of oil and petroleum products into the United States in June, 2012. Goldman Sachs stores aluminium in vast warehouses in Detroit as well as serving as a commodities derivatives dealer. This "bank" is also expanding into the ownership and operation of airports, toll roads, and ports. JP Morgan markets electricity in California. In other words, Goldman Sachs, JP Morgan and Morgan Stanley are no longer just banks – they have effectively become oil companies, port and airport operators, commodities dealers, and electric utilities as well."

How does the global economy work?

The functioning of the global economy can be explained through one word —transactions. International transactions taking place between top economies in the world help in the continuance of the global economy. These transactions mainly comprise trade taking place between different countries. International trade includes the exchange of a variety of products between countries. It ranges all the way from fruits and foods, to natural oil and weapons. Such transactions have a number of benefits including:

- Providing a foundation for worldwide economic growth, with the international economy set to grow by 4% in 2019 (source: World Trade Organisation);
- Encouraging competitiveness between countries in various markets;
- Raising productivity and efficiency across countries;
- Helping in the development of underdeveloped countries by allowing them to import capital goods (machinery and industrial raw materials) and export primary goods (natural resources and raw materials).

What are the effects of global economy?

Nearly every country in the world is in some way affected by things that happen in what may seem at times, like unrelated countries - due to the influence of the global economy. A good example of this is the economic impact that the Brexit vote will have on other countries, not only in Europe, but across the

75 globe. Brexit was referendum decision for the United Kingdom to withdraw from the European Union (EU).

The main cause of these effects is economics — based on the production and exchange of goods and services. Restrictions on the import and export of goods and services can potentially hamper the economic stability of countries who choose to impose too many. The purpose of international trade is similar to that of trading within a country. However, international trade differs from domestic trade in two aspects:

85 The currencies of at least two countries are involved in international trade, so they must be exchanged before goods and services can be exported or imported; occasionally, countries enforce barriers on the international trade of certain goods or services which can disrupt the relations between two countries.

Countries usually specialise in those products that they can produce efficiently, which helps in reducing overall manufacturing costs. Then, countries trade these products with other countries, whose product specialisation is something else altogether. Having greater specialisation helps countries take advantage of economies of scale. Economies of scale refer to the proportionate saving in costs gained by an increased level of production. Manufacturers in these countries can focus all their efforts on building factories for specialised production, instead of spending additional money on the production of various types of goods.

Occasionally countries add barriers to international trade. Some of these barriers include trade tariffs (taxes on imports) and trade quotas (limitation on the number of products that can be imported into a country). Trade barriers often affect the economies of the trading countries, and in the long run, it becomes difficult to keep employing such barriers.

What are the benefits of global economy?

There are numerous benefits of a global economy, which include:

100 **Free trade:** Free trade is an excellent method for countries to exchange goods and services. It also allows countries to specialise in the production of those goods in which they have a comparative advantage.

Movement of labour: Increased migration of the labour force is advantageous for the recipient country as well as for the workers. If a country is going through a phase of high unemployment, workers can look for jobs in other countries. This also helps in reducing geographical inequality.

105 **Increased economies of scale:** The specialisation of goods production in most countries has led to advantageous economic factors such as lower average costs and lower prices for customers.

Increased investment: Due to the presence of global economy, it has become easier for countries to attract short-term and long-term investment. Investments in developing countries go a long way in improving their economies.

Factors affecting the global economy

According to the latest economic news, here are some of the key factors that influence and

affect how well the global economy works:

1. Natural resources;
2. Infrastructure
3. Population
4. Labour
5. Human capital
6. Technology
7. Law

For discussion/reflection:

- The author asserts that in effect, ‘big banks and large corporations’ (line 47) control the global economy, rather than governments. What are some reasons why this might be unacceptable?
- Lines 98 – 108 list the benefits of the global economy. In your opinion, are these benefits accessible to all? Why or why not? Explain why specific groups are more and less able to enjoy these benefits.

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. Is globalisation to be welcomed or feared today? (Cambridge 2019)
2. Is there any point in trying to predict future trends? (Cambridge 2013)
3. ‘We have paid too high a price for globalisation.’ Do you agree? (RI Y6 CT 2021)
4. ‘Globalisation has made us more vulnerable.’ To what extent is this true? (RI Y6 CT1 2013)

SECTION B: THE STATE OF THE WORLD TODAY

Reading 4: The Changing Nature of Globalisation in Our Hyperconnected, Knowledge-Intensive Economy

EU 1

Irving Wladawsky-Berger | *Wall Street Journal* | June 2014

This reading will help you understand:

- How the world has transitioned from a *connected* to an increasingly *hyperconnected* world
- What a hyperconnected economy is
- How digital technologies and growing mobile subscriptions are driving cross-border flows
- How the nature of cross-border flows are changing in a knowledge-intensive economy

In April, 2005, NY Times columnist Tom Friedman published *The World is Flat: A Brief History of the Globalized World in the Twenty-first Century*. Mr. Friedman’s bestseller did much to explain to a wide audience the impact of the Internet and related technologies on the connected, global economy that was rising all around us.

- 5 A few years later, Mr. Friedman was a keynote speaker at a 2011 conference commemorating IBM Corp.’s Centennial. To illustrate the incredibly fast pace of change, Mr. Friedman noted that in the short time-span since *World is Flat* was published, we were already transitioning from a *connected* to an increasingly *hyperconnected* world. Many of the companies and technologies that are now part of our everyday conversations—Facebook Inc., Twitter, the cloud, smartphones, Big Data, LinkedIn Inc.,
- 10 4G, Skype—were not mentioned in the *connected* global economy he wrote about only six years earlier because they had not been born or were in their infancy.

What do we mean by a *hyperconnected* economy? I recently found a really good answer in an excellent study by the McKinsey Global Institute, *Global Flows in the Digital Age*. The study takes an

15 in-depth look at the expansion of cross-borders flows in the economy. It carefully analyzed these flows
in five different categories: goods, services, finance, people and data and communications. It then
developed the MGI Connectedness Index, which measures these five flows in 131 countries, examined
how the flows had changed over the past 10 to 20 years, and predicted how they are likely to evolve
over the next decade.

20 Two major forces have been driving the growth of cross-border flows. First is the continuous advances
in digital technologies, in particular, the spread of Internet access around the world. We've been going
through a kind of digital *perfect storm*, where a number of major IT trends are each gathering speed
while interacting with and amplifying each other: mobile devices, cloud computing, Internet of Things,
social networks and Big Data and analytics.

25 The number of mobile subscriptions around the world is already approaching 7 billion, while close to
3 billion have access to the Internet. Cross-border Internet traffic has been going up by over 50% since
2005. As the cost of smartphones and Internet access keep dropping, data and communications flow—
the enabling foundation for all other digital flows—will continue increasing at a similar torrid pace.

30 Even more dramatic is the expected rise in global prosperity over the next decades.
McKinsey estimates that over the coming decade, up to three billion additional people will connect to
the Internet with mobile devices and wireless networks. They will thus become part of the global
digital economy, and will see significant improvements in their standard of living. "By 2025, 1.8 billion
people around the world will enter the consuming class, nearly all from emerging markets, and
emerging-market consumers will spend \$30 trillion annually, up from \$12 trillion today."

35 What is the impact of technology advances and rising economic prosperity on the global economy?
According to the MGI study, the combined value of trade in goods and services plus financial flows
grew from \$5 trillion or 23% of global GDP in 1990 to \$26 trillion or 36% of world GDP in 2012. If
present trends continue, the value of these flows could triple by 2025, thus having a major impact on
economic growth.

40 The MGI Connectedness Index measures the degree of *connectedness* of 131 countries across all five
flows. For each country, it then calculates an overall *flow intensity*, a single measure that reflects that
country's connectedness across all flows. McKinsey's analysis found an overall positive correlation
between increased flows and GDP growth. Countries with the highest flow intensities can expect up a
40% increase in GDP growth compared to the least connected countries.

45 Not surprisingly, the Index found that developed economies have higher flow intensities, that is, are
more connected than emerging economies. Germany tops the list, followed by Hong Kong, the U.S.,
Singapore, the UK, Netherlands, France and Canada. However, the situation is changing as emerging
economies are rapidly gaining ground, including Brazil, China and India.

50 Besides rising cross-border flows, the study uncovered that the very nature of these flows is changing.
The globalisation that Tom Friedman wrote about a decade ago was primarily based on the
outsourcing of labour-intensive tasks from the developed world to developing countries with lower
labour costs, as well as by commodity-intensive flows, like oil, from the countries with those
resources. But things are different in our emerging knowledge-intensive economy. According to
McKinsey: "Knowledge-intensive goods and services flows (as opposed to labour-, capital- or resource-
intensive ones) include goods and activities that have a high R&D component or utilise highly skilled
labour. As such, they help transmit information, ideas, or expertise among exchanging parties.
Examples include high-tech products such as semiconductors and computers, pharmaceuticals,
automobiles and other machinery, and business services such as accounting, law, and engineering."

60 The study estimates that the value of knowledge-intensive flows was \$12.6 trillion in 2012, nearly half the \$26 trillion total value of cross-border flows. Knowledge-intensive flows are growing at 1.3 times the rate of labour-intensive flows, and so their share will continue to increase.

Moreover, digital technologies are continuing to transform many cross-border flows. Digital flows—with their lower costs of access, transport, and production—are replacing the flow of many physical goods, e.g. e-books, digital music, games, news and entertainment and streaming movies. Digital
65 communications and collaborations of all sorts are substituting for work that previously involved physical travel. 3-D printing holds the promise of revolutionizing the production of physical goods with an increasing portion of such goods being manufactured just-in-time at their point of consumption.

Digital technologies are also playing a major role in improving the production, distribution and operations of physical goods, resulting in a significant improvement to their overall productivity and
70 quality. Examples include tracking shipments of goods, and monitoring and optimizing the performance of all kinds of physical things—i.e., the Internet of Things. In addition, online platforms make it easier to transact goods and services across borders. For example, 90% of eBay sellers export their goods to other countries, compared with an average of 25% for traditional small companies.

In the not too distant past, global flows were concentrated in the more advanced economies, as well
75 as in large, global companies. But, digital technologies and rising prosperity are combining to significantly disperse global flows, making it possible to include a larger number of countries as well as a larger number of participants across all countries. McKinsey notes that:

“The network of global flows is expanding rapidly as emerging economies join in. Rising incomes in the developing world are creating enormous new centers of consumer demand, global
80 production, and commodities trade, as well as sending more people across borders for business and leisure. Existing routes of flows are broadening and deepening and new ones emerging as more countries participate. Developing economies now account for 38 percent of global flows, nearly triple their share in 1990. South–South goods flows between developing countries have grown from roughly \$200 billion (6 percent of goods flows) in 1990 to \$4.2 trillion (24 percent) in
85 2012.”

“Not only more countries but also more players are participating in global flows. Governments and multinational companies were once the only actors involved in cross-border exchanges. But today, digital technologies enable even the smallest company or solo entrepreneur to be
90 a *micromultinational*, selling and sourcing products, services, and ideas across borders. Individuals can work remotely through online platforms, creating a virtual people flow. Microfinance platforms enable entrepreneurs and social innovators to raise money globally in ever-smaller amounts.”

Advances in technology and rising standards of living will continue to accelerate the pace of change in our hyperconnected, knowledge-intensive economy. “For players of all types- whether regions,
95 countries, cities, businesses, or individuals – there are major economic opportunities from participating in global flows. The imperative for policy makers is to fully embrace the new era and ensure that their economies are positioned to benefit from it.”

For discussion/reflection:

- Examine how today's more digital form of globalisation is changing who is participating, how business is done across borders, and where the economic benefits are flowing.
- How has digitisation changed the economics of globalisation? How will this influence and impact the nature of relationships between: State and citizen; Enterprise and consumer; Enterprise and government?
- How can we accelerate the transformation required to keep pace with accelerating technological innovation/disruption? How can we avoid massive social dislocation, or worse?
- Consider how governments, the private sector, civil society, and individuals need to collaborate to forge new common understandings.

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. Is globalisation to be welcomed or feared today? (Cambridge 2019)
2. How far is it important for people to be aware of current events in countries other than their own? (Cambridge 2014)
3. 'We have paid too high a price for globalisation.' Do you agree? (RI Y6 CT 2021)
4. 'The strong do what they want, the weak suffer what they must.' To what extent is this true of the world today? (RI Y6 CT2 2016)

SECTION B: THE STATE OF THE WORLD TODAY

Reading 5: The Decline of the Rules-Based International Order and the Rise of Middle Power Strategic Autonomy

EU 1, 2, 3, 7

This reading will help you to:

- Understand how globalisation is shifting from a rule-based order to great power rivalry.
- Explain the geopolitical and economic consequences of globalisation, including rising tensions, economic coercion, and the weakening of multilateral institutions.
- Examine how middle powers respond to the decline of rules-based international order by pursuing strategic autonomy, diversifying partnerships and forming flexible coalitions.
- Evaluate the benefits and risks of global integration in an increasingly fragmented world, including its role in enabling cooperation while creating vulnerability and instability.

A Rupture in the World Order

Today I will talk about a rupture in the world order, the end of a pleasant fiction and the beginning of a harsh reality, where geopolitics is no longer constrained by clear rules or limits. On the other hand, intermediate powers like Canada, are not powerless. They have the capacity to build a new order that reflects values, such as respect for human rights, sustainable development, solidarity, sovereignty and territorial integrity.

The power of the less powerful starts with honesty. We are in an era of great power rivalry. The rules based order is fading. The strong do what they can, and the weak suffer what they must. And this echoes Thucydides' idea of international relations as inevitable power politics. Faced with this logic, countries tend to accommodate, avoid conflict, and hope compliance brings safety.

The Power of the Powerless: Havel's Warning

In 1978, Václav Havel wrote *The Power of the Powerless*, asking how authoritarian systems sustain themselves. And his answer began with a greengrocer. Every morning, this shopkeeper places a sign

in his window: 'Workers of the world unite'. He doesn't believe it, no-one does, but he places a sign anyway to avoid trouble, to signal compliance, to get along. And because every shopkeeper on every street does the same, the system persists – not through violence alone, but through the participation of ordinary people in rituals they privately know to be false. Havel called this "living within a lie". The system's power comes not from its truth, but from everyone's willingness to perform as if it were true, and its fragility comes from the same source. When even one person stops performing, when the greengrocer removes his sign, the illusion begins to crack. It is time for countries to take their signs down.

The Illusion of the Rules-Based International Order

For decades, countries like Canada prospered under what we called the rules-based international order. We joined its institutions, we praised its principles, we benefited from its predictability. And because of that, we could pursue values-based foreign policies under its protection.

We knew the story of the international rules-based order was partially false, that the strongest would exempt themselves when convenient, that trade rules were enforced asymmetrically. And we knew that international law applied with varying rigour depending on the identity of the accused or the victim.

This fiction was useful, and American hegemony, in particular, helped provide public goods, open sea lanes, a stable financial system, collective security and support for frameworks for resolving disputes.

So, we placed the sign in the window. We participated in the rituals, and we largely avoided calling out the gaps between rhetoric and reality. Unfortunately, this bargain no longer works.

From Global Integration to Strategic Autonomy

Over the past two decades, global crises in finance, health, energy and geopolitics have laid bare the risks of extreme global integration. More recently, great powers have begun using economic integration as weapons, tariffs as leverage, financial infrastructure as coercion, supply chains as vulnerabilities to be exploited. You cannot live within the lie of mutual benefit through integration, when integration becomes the source of your subordination.

The multilateral institutions on which the middle powers have relied – the WTO, the UN, the COP – the architecture, the very architecture of collective problem solving are under threat. And as a result, many countries are drawing the same conclusions that they must develop greater strategic autonomy, in energy, food, critical minerals, in finance and supply chains.

And this impulse is understandable. A country that can't feed, fuel, or defend itself, has few options. When the rules no longer protect you, you must protect yourself. A world of fortresses will be poorer, more fragile and less sustainable. And there is another truth. If great powers abandon even the pretense of rules and values for the unhindered pursuit of their power and interests, the gains from transactionalism will become harder to replicate. Hegemons cannot continually monetize their relationships. Allies will diversify to hedge against uncertainty. They'll buy insurance, increase options in order to rebuild sovereignty – sovereignty that was once grounded in rules, but will increasingly be anchored in the ability to withstand pressure.

This is classic risk management. Risk management comes at a price, but that cost of strategic autonomy, of sovereignty can also be shared. Collective investments in resilience are cheaper than everyone building their own fortresses. Shared standards reduce fragmentations. Complementarities are positive sum. And the question for middle powers like Canada is not whether to adapt to the new reality – we must. The question is whether we adapt by simply building higher walls, or whether we can do something more ambitious.

Building Strength at Home

55 Now Canada was amongst the first to hear the wake-up call, leading us to fundamentally shift our strategic posture. Canadians know that our old comfortable assumptions that our geography and alliance memberships automatically conferred prosperity and security – that assumption is no longer valid. And our new approach rests on what Alexander Stubb, the President of Finland, has termed “values-based realism”. Or, to put another way, we aim to be both principled and pragmatic –
60 principled in our commitment to fundamental values, sovereignty, territorial integrity, the prohibition of the use of force, except when consistent with the UN Charter, and respect for human rights, and pragmatic and recognizing that progress is often incremental, that interests diverge, that not every partner will share all of our values.

So, we're engaging broadly, strategically with open eyes. We actively take on the world as it is, not wait around for a world we wish to be. We are calibrating our relationships, so their depth reflects our values, and we're prioritizing broad engagement to maximize our influence, given the fluidity of the world at the moment, the risks that this poses and the stakes for what comes next. We are no longer just relying on the strength of our values, but also the value of our strength. We are building that strength at home.

70 Since my government took office, we have cut taxes on incomes, on capital gains and business investment. We have removed all federal barriers to interprovincial trade. We are fast tracking a trillion dollars of investments in energy, AI, critical minerals, new trade corridors and beyond. We're doubling our defence spending by the end of this decade, and we're doing so in ways that build our domestic industries.

75 And we are rapidly diversifying abroad. We have agreed a comprehensive strategic partnership with the EU, including joining SAFE, the European defence procurement arrangements. We have signed 12 other trade and security deals on four continents in six months. We're negotiating free trade pacts with India, ASEAN, Thailand, Philippines and Mercosur.

We're doing something else. To help solve global problems, we're pursuing variable geometry, in other words, different coalitions for different issues based on common values and interests. So, on Ukraine, we're a core member of the Coalition of the Willing and one of the largest per capita contributors to its defence and security. On Arctic sovereignty, we stand firmly with Greenland and Denmark, and fully support their unique right to determine Greenland's future. Our commitment to NATO's Article 5 is unwavering, so we're working with our NATO allies, including the Nordic Baltic Gate, to further secure the alliance's northern and western flanks. Canada strongly opposes tariffs over Greenland and calls for focused talks to achieve our shared objectives of security and prosperity in the Arctic.

On plurilateral trade, we're championing efforts to build a bridge between the Trans Pacific Partnership and the European Union, which would create a new trading bloc of 1.5 billion people. On critical minerals, we're forming buyers' clubs anchored in the G7 so the world can diversify away from concentrated supply. And on AI, we're cooperating with like-minded democracies to ensure that we won't ultimately be forced to choose between hegemonies and hyper-scalers. This is not naive multilateralism, nor is it relying on their institutions. It's building coalitions that work – issues by issue, with partners who share enough common ground to act together.

Middle Powers and Coalition Strategy

95 In some cases, this will be the vast majority of nations. What it's doing is creating a dense web of connections across trade, investment, culture, on which we can draw for future challenges and opportunities. Middle powers must act together, because if we're not at the table, we're on the menu. But I'd also say that great powers can afford for now to go it alone. They have the market size, the military capacity and the leverage to dictate terms. Middle powers do not. But when we only negotiate bilaterally with a hegemon, we negotiate from weakness. We accept what's offered. We
100 compete with each other to be the most accommodating.

This is not sovereignty. It's the performance of sovereignty while accepting subordination. In a world of great power rivalry, the countries in between have a choice – compete with each other for favour, or to combine to create a third path with impact. We shouldn't allow the rise of hard power to blind us to the fact that the power of legitimacy, integrity and rules will remain strong, if we choose to wield them together.

Naming Reality and Acting Together

What does it mean for middle powers to live the truth? First, it means naming reality. Stop invoking rules-based international order as though it still functions as advertised. Call it what it is – a system of intensifying great power rivalry, where the most powerful pursue their interests, using economic integration as coercion. It means acting consistently, applying the same standards to allies and rivals. When middle powers criticize economic intimidation from one direction, but stay silent when it comes from another, we are keeping the sign in the window. It means building what we claim to believe in, rather than waiting for the old order to be restored. It means creating institutions and agreements that function as described. And it means reducing the leverage that enables coercion – that's building a strong domestic economy. It should be every government's immediate priority. And diversification internationally is not just economic prudence, it's a material foundation for honest foreign policy, because countries earn the right to principled stands by reducing their vulnerability to retaliation.

Canada's Strategic Position

Canada has what the world wants. We are an energy superpower. We hold vast reserves of critical minerals. We have the most educated population in the world. Our pension funds are amongst the world's largest and most sophisticated investors. In other words, we have capital, talent... we also have a government with immense fiscal capacity to act decisively. And we have the values to which many others aspire. Canada is a pluralistic society that works. Our public square is loud, diverse and free. Canadians remain committed to sustainability. We are a stable and reliable partner in a world that is anything but.. A partner that builds and values relationships for the long term.

And we have something else. We have a recognition of what's happening and a determination to act accordingly. We understand that this rupture calls for more than adaptation. It calls for honesty about the world as it is. This is the task of the middle powers, the countries that have the most to lose from a world of fortresses and most to gain from genuine cooperation.

The powerful have their power. But we have something too – the capacity to stop pretending, to name reality, to build our strength at home and to act together.

For discussion/reflection:

- In what ways does the greengrocer analogy reveal the dependence of global power systems in the middle powers' collective compliance? How feasible is it for states to "take their signs down" (lines 19-20) in today's international order?
- Based on lines 32-54, explain why countries are increasingly choosing to pursue strategic autonomy in response to growing vulnerabilities, coercion, and weakening global institutions in the international system.
- To what extent is Canada's approach of "values-based realism" (line 59)—balancing principles with pragmatism, while strengthening domestic capacity and forming flexible coalitions—a viable strategy for navigating an increasingly fragmented and competitive global order?
- Based on lines 95-106, explain why "[m]iddle powers must act together" (line 96).
- Illustrate what it means for middle powers to "live the truth" (line 106) and "[act] consistently" (line 109) in today's global system. How realistic is it for them to act consistently on their values while reducing their vulnerabilities to powerful states?

- To what extent can a small state like Singapore adopt Canada's values-based realism and coalition strategy? What adaptations or compromises might be necessary?

SECTION B: THE STATE OF THE WORLD TODAY

Reading 6: Global Risks Report 2026

EU 1, 4-5, 7

This reading will help you to:

- Identify five key areas highlighted as main global stress points for 2026 and beyond
- Understand some underlying issues contributing to these stressors

The following is a Primer that summarises the main ideas of the Global Risks Report. To read the Global Risks Report 2026 itself, go to  <https://www.weforum.org/publications/global-risks-report-2026/digest/>

Primer to Global Risks Report 2026 – The Age of Competition

The 2026 outlook is defined by a **shift from global cooperation to a "contested multipolar landscape"**. With 57% of experts anticipating a "stormy" or "turbulent" decade ahead, the report highlights a world where **trust is evaporating** and **systemic competition is the new norm**.

1. Geopolitical Fragmentation: Multilateralism in Retreat

5 The defining shift of 2026 is the **breakdown of international cooperation**. Governments are retreating from shared frameworks in favor of confrontation.

- The Rise of Geoeconomic Confrontation: For the first time, this has become the #1 risk likely to trigger a global crisis. It reflects a world where trade and investment are used as weapons.
- State-Based Conflict: Following closely behind is the risk of armed conflict. As global "police" mechanisms crumble, the propensity for **regional spillovers** and **state fragility** is increasing.

2. Economic Volatility: The Return of Financial Risk

10 After years of secondary concern, **economic risks are surging back to the forefront**, showing the largest climb in ranking compared to previous years.

- The "Economic Reckoning": Risks like Economic Downturn and Inflation both jumped eight positions.
- Debt & Bubbles: There is a growing fear that **mounting sovereign debt** and **asset bubbles**, combined with **geoeconomic friction**, will lead to a new phase of **market instability that disrupts social contracts**.

3. Technological Paradox: Innovation vs. Insecurity

Technology is viewed as a **double-edged sword**: a driver of immense progress in health and climate, but a primary source of systemic instability.

- Information Integrity: **Misinformation and disinformation** remains the #2 risk for the next two years, acting as a **catalyst for societal unrest**.
- The AI Long-Game: While AI risks are ranked lower in the immediate short-term (#30), they skyrocket to #5 on the 10-year horizon, reflecting deep anxiety over **AI's impact on labor markets and global security**.

- 25
- Quantum Rivalry: Advances in quantum computing offer breakthroughs in drug discovery but are also becoming a new frontier for political polarisation and a widening divide between the 'haves' and the 'have-nots'.

4. Societal Cracks: "Streets vs. Elites"

Societies are reaching a breaking point due to inequality and political polarisation, leading to a loss of faith in traditional governance.

- 30
- Inequality as a Catalyst: For the second year, Inequality is cited as the most "interconnected" risk, meaning it worsens almost every other global threat.
 - Drastically divergent rates of recovery between the wealthy and the poor: As wealth concentrates and cost-of-living pressures persist, many feel excluded from the political process, leading to extremist movements and a "dilution of socio-environmental progress."

5. Environmental Outlook: The Dangerous Delay

35 Perhaps the most striking finding is the de-prioritisation of the environment in the short term as immediate economic and geopolitical crises take center stage.

- Short-Term Neglect: Risks like Extreme Weather and Biodiversity Loss dropped in ranking for the two-year outlook as leaders focus on "survival" issues like war and inflation.
 - The 10-Year Threat: Despite the short-term dip, environmental risks remain the most severe long-term threats. Over 75% of respondents are pessimistic about the environment over the next decade, with Extreme Weather remaining the #1 long-term risk.
- 40

The Bottom Line

The 2026 report signals a transition away from the post-WWII era of global stability. We are entering an era of "Multipolarity without Multilateralism," where the lack of a unified global response to shared threats (like climate change and AI) makes the entire system more brittle.

For discussion/reflection:

- The report analyses five risks and explores the range of these risks and their interconnections. Which of these themes is likely to have the greatest impact on your own society? Justify your reasons.
- In a world weakened by rising rivalries, unstable supply chains, prolonged conflicts at risk of regional spillover, how might cooperation look like in today's context?
- How can governments try to strike a balance between leveraging the innovations and opportunities of technological developments with mitigating new risks across domains?

Related Cambridge/RI Essay Questions:

1. 'No country should sacrifice its economic development in favour of preserving the environment.' Discuss. (Cambridge 2025)
2. Examine the claim that it is the responsibility of wealthier countries to assist in dealing with natural disasters. (Cambridge 2025)
3. 'Developed nations should shoulder a greater burden in addressing climate change.' To what extent do you agree? (RI 2025 Y6 Prelim)
4. Is it right for a leader to place national interests above global responsibilities? (RI 2025 Y6 Prelim)
5. To what extent can individuals shape their own lives when the world is so unpredictable? (Cambridge 2022)
6. 'A leader's responsibility should always be to his or her own country, not other nations.' Discuss. (Cambridge 2019)

7. How far is it important for people to be aware of current events in countries other than their own? (Cambridge 2014)
8. How effective have global efforts been in addressing the spread of diseases? (RI Y6 CT1 2020)
9. How far can scientific or technological developments be a solution to global problems? (RI Y5 CT 2018)
10. 'Globalisation has made us more vulnerable.' To what extent is this true? (RI Y6 CT1 2013)

SECTION C: THE GLOBAL POLITICS OF SUSTAINABILITY

Reading 7: Are the SDGs Unsustainable?

EU 4-5

Nigel Howard | Eco-Business | 23 May 2018

This reading will help you:

- Recognise that while sustainable development is desirable, it has to be carefully managed to minimise ramifications and tradeoffs
- Acknowledge the tension between improving the quality of life of people in developing countries (national interest) and addressing the issue of climate change (global obligation)
- Assess conditions needed for successful sustainable development

For a list of all the SDGs, refer to [Population and the Sustainable Development Goals](#)

The Asia Pacific region is failing to meet almost two-thirds of the targets set by the United Nations' Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), according to a recent report by the UN. The report found that the world's most populous region has fallen behind on 37 out of 57 SDGs' targets.

- 5 But how can anyone be surprised? Asia Pacific has the largest population of people clawing their way out of poverty, while the developed world ruthlessly exploits them for our own well-being. Following the developed world models of GDP growth means only part of the population reaps the benefits of development, leaving countries without the luxury of acting on SDG goals such as climate change, life below water, and life on land, as they try to grow wealth to meet the exploitative demands of the developed world.
- 10 Whatever progress might seem to have been made in the short-term, our collective failure on climate change and biodiversity represent an existential threat, and the fault is the SDGs themselves. There seem to be three major problems with the SDGs:

1. Failure to acknowledge the exploitation of the developing world by the developed world

- 15 Although it is comfortable to believe that the rising tide raises all ships, globalisation has shown to increase inequity and exploitation of the poor by the wealthy. Reducing poverty, Goal 1 of the SDGs, requires economic growth and employment (Goal 8), creating a tension between meeting domestic needs and producing for export. Global market competition gives the developed nations access to the cheapest sources of exports, allowing them to exploit developing nations and prolong their poverty.

2. The goals are wide ranging, interconnected and riddled with contradictions

- 20 Production for export requires a density of workers for mass production that promotes urbanisation (Goal 11). This concentrates prosperity within cities and increases inequality between city and rural populations, contradicting the aims of Goal 10, reduced inequality.

25 Reduced poverty leads to greater consumption (Goal 12) - more cars, greater energy use (Goal 7), more land and water exploitation (Goal 6) competing with domestic food production exacerbating hunger for those left behind. This undermines Goals 2 and 3, which are zero hunger and good health & well-being, respectively.

30 Greater consumption and producing goods for export increases waste and pollution, and greatly exacerbates global climate impacts (Goal 13), setting the world back in its professed goals to protect biodiversity, manage the impacts of waste (Goals 14 & 15), and preventing health damage to the population (Goal 3) – think China.

More consumption strains infrastructure to move goods (Goal 9), provide affordable energy (Goal 7), clean water and sewage disposal (Goal 6), and to safely handle waste – think India. The increasing pressure to survive and prosper economically causes conflicted priorities for the poor between time for work and education (Goal 4) or to grow their own food (Goal 2).

35 Gender equality (Goal 5) and peace, justice and strong institutions (Goal 16) are highly shaped by history and culture but will also be affected by development - women becoming more autonomous, but perhaps also more exploitation of women and children.

40 Goal 17, Partnerships for the Goals, is an insidious goal. It undermines critics of the SDGs as non-team-players, but if we are to make the SDGs achieve their potential, we need to critically debate and improve the SDGs.

3. The goals are unprioritised

45 This is probably the most critical problem with the SDGs. Economic and social development goals are listed ahead of environmental sustainability goals (Goals 13, 14 & 15), but if we continue to fail on climate action then we will certainly fail at all SDGs. Climate change may affect the poor first, but it poses an existential threat to all of mankind. The SDGs must not be complacent to these threats.

We already have year-on-year global temperature rises, more extreme weather events, accelerated melting of polar ice, sea level rises, ocean acidification, coral bleaching and death, drought and wildfires, crop failure and the collapse of fisheries (Goals 2 & 3) and the mass extinction of species (Goals 14 & 15).

50 As the “third pole” of Himalayan ice recedes, the river flows feeding the most populated areas on Earth may change dramatically. Conflict over water will almost certainly increase (Goals 6, 2 & 16).

As desertification advances and crops fail and as low lying regions become inundated, migration and conflict (Goal 16) will increase as the haves try to hold onto what they have (Goal 10), and the have nots must fight for their survival.

55 The ecological systems that provide our food are also collapsing. Our insatiable demand to turn wilderness into dollars (Goals 1 & 8), our reckless climate impacts (Goal 13), our intensive agriculture for growing populations and our soil degradation (Goal 15), exacerbated by our pollution and waste is overwhelming nature’s capacity to respond (climate change, ozone layer depletion, acidification, ocean plastics, and so on).

60 The UN Paris Climate Accord and Biodiversity Conventions should cause Goals 13, 14 and 15 to never be compromised to any other goal. Any corporation or government that claims achievements in any of the SDGs is trading in greenwash if they cannot first demonstrate rapid transition to renewable

energy (Goal 7) and emissions reductions commensurate with a 1.5 degrees Celsius climate stabilisation.

- 65 If the SDGs are to fulfil their potential, sustainability must be prioritised over development, because to fail to live within the earth's carrying capacity is not sustainable. You can't breathe, eat or drink money.

Explainer: Why are the SDGs off track?

Progress is happening, but far too slowly

Only a small share of goals are on track, and many are stagnating or regressing.

Global crises keep setting the world back

COVID-19, climate disasters, and conflicts have undone years of progress.

Money is a major bottleneck

Many developing countries lack funding and are burdened by debt, limiting their ability to invest in development.

Progress is uneven and unequal

Some areas (such as energy and health) are improving, but poverty, food security, and gender equality are lagging behind.

Weak global cooperation is slowing action

Countries are prioritising national interests over collective goals, making coordinated progress difficult.

Implementation is the real challenge

Governments around the world largely know what to do but struggle to execute at scale and speed

For discussion/reflection:

- Refer to: Population and the Sustainable Development Goals
- If you could only address debt and financing gaps, climate shocks, weak global cooperation, and domestic government failures, which would you choose and why?
- If you were a leader of a developing country, would you invest heavily in economic growth or climate sustainability? Why?
- Who is the most responsible for the failure of the SDGs? Consider developed countries, developing countries, global institutions (such as UN, World Bank, and IMF), private corporations, and citizens.
- How far do you agree that the primary reason the SDGs are failing is not lack of resources, but lack of political will?
- Should developed countries bear the greatest responsibility for SDGs failure? Do you agree that the SDGs were unrealistic from the start?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. 'No country should sacrifice its economic development in favour of preserving the environment.' Discuss. (Cambridge 2025)
2. Examine the claim that it is the responsibility of wealthier countries to assist in dealing with natural disasters. (Cambridge 2025)
3. 'Science is the only answer to global hunger.' Discuss. (Cambridge 2019)
4. Is globalisation to be welcomed or feared today? (Cambridge 2019)
5. 'Environmental concerns and economic growth cannot co-exist.' What do you think? (Cambridge 2011)
6. 'Developed nations should shoulder a greater burden in addressing climate change.' To what extent do you agree? (RI 2025 Y6 Prelim)

7. Is it right for a leader to place national interests above global responsibilities? (RI 2025 Y6 Prelim)
8. 'Sustainable development is not sustainable.' Comment. (RI Y6 Timed Practice 2022)
9. How far do you agree that good governance is key to the protection of the environment? (RI Y6 Prelim 2021)
10. 'All countries should have an equal responsibility in tackling climate change.' How far do you agree? (RI Y6 CT2 2020)
11. Consider the impact of technology on world hunger today. (RI Y6 CT2 2019)
12. 'The developed world should bear the burden of climate change.' Discuss. (RI Y6 Prelim 2015)
13. Consider the view that economic growth always brings environmental damage. (RI Y6 CT1 2013)

SECTION C: THE GLOBAL POLITICS OF SUSTAINABILITY

Reading 8: Plenty of fish in the sea? Seafood-loving Singapore may not have its fill in the future

William Chen | Channel News Asia | 23 July 2021

EU 1, 3-4

This reading will help you:

- Understand how concerns with food security are influenced by global and local consumption trends
- Recognise how efforts to promote sustainability consumption are promising and problematic at the same time

The Netflix documentary *Seaspiracy* has triggered discussion about the ills of the global seafood industry. While it got blowback for its sensationalism and quoting studies out of context, the film has shone a spotlight on issues such as overfishing and plastic pollution, convincing many viewers to swear off seafood. But is abstaining from seafood consumption really the solution?

- 5 That doesn't sound like an easy task when Singaporeans love seafood. Each person consumes an average of 22kg of seafood per year, above the global average of around 20kg. In 2020, Singapore imported 134,000 tonnes of seafood worth S\$760 million, mostly from countries in the region such as Indonesia and Malaysia. But this rate of seafood imports might give one pause given the finite number of fish in oceans and Singapore's food security goals.

A seafood-loving nation

- 10 A 2016 report by WWF revealed that 75 per cent of the seafood consumed in Singapore is unsustainable, meaning they are irresponsibly fished or farmed. A notorious industrial fishing method is bottom trawling, in which a large fishing net is used to comb the seabed. The net collects everything in its path, including juvenile fish, turtles and marine mammals, and destroys coral reefs in the process. Species that are trawled include ikan kuning (the fish typically served in nasi lemak), silver pomfret
- 15 and swordtip squid. Yet, Singapore is highly dependent on these imports. Over 90 per cent of the food we eat is imported, with only 9 per cent of fish produced in local farms, according to the Singapore Food Agency (SFA).

- 20 This makes Singapore vulnerable to temporary shocks in supply chains. The Jurong Fishery Port, a source of a growing COVID-19 cluster, has been closed for deep cleaning until Jul 31, causing short-term disruptions to the supply of chilled seafood. The Ministry of Health noted on Jul 17 that there was a rush to buy fish and urged visitors to avoid crowds when marketing. It's therefore no surprise that Singapore aims to beef up its food security with its "30 by 30" goal: To produce 30 per cent of its nutritional needs locally by 2030.

The Global Picture

25 But the problem goes beyond Singapore. Worldwide, seafood consumption has reached 156 million tonnes every year. The United Nations' Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO) estimated global fish consumption per capita more than doubled from 9kg in 1961 to 20.5kg in 2018.

30 The annual growth in seafood consumption has outpaced population growth twofold and is higher than the growth in consumption of all other animal proteins. The world's insatiable appetite for seafood has led to overfishing and resulting declining fish populations. In 1974, 90 per cent of the world's fish stocks were at healthy levels. That figure dropped to 65.8 per cent in 2017, according to FAO. Fifty years ago in Thailand, 300kg of seafood could be fished per hour. Today, only 18kg of seafood can be fished per hour.

35 Farming practices such as aquaculture can fill the shortfall in consumer demand for seafood. But aquaculture has also been associated with environmentally harmful practices, including overfishing, ironically, when an unsustainable number of wild fish is caught to feed the farmed fish.

There've been health scares linked to cultivated seafood too. For instance, the US Food and Drug Administration issued an import alert in 2016 on shrimp and prawns from Malaysia, alleging the presence of antibiotics that prevent disease in farmed crustaceans, but are harmful to humans.

40 The ongoing pandemic has added another layer of complexity. According to a recent FAO information paper, the slowdown in consumer demand, disruption to fishing supplies and health measures for crew members have all affected the seafood industry. In the US, fishing catches dropped by 40 per cent at the peak of COVID-19. With all these stresses on the seafood industry, it's time to think about the bigger questions during our trips to the supermarket.

Sustainable Seafood Labels – A Guarantee?

45 One solution to the depletion of fish stocks is to eat responsibly. The big boys know this trend is on the horizon. Marina Bay Sands, for instance, is starting to use more certified sustainable products in their kitchens with Marine Stewardship Council (MSC) being the dominant seafood sustainability certifier. MSC labels caught or farmed seafood as sustainable based on three criteria: Using sustainable fish stocks, minimising environmental impact and effective management. Other certifiers include the Aquaculture Stewardship Council (ASC) and the Global Aquaculture Alliance's Best Aquaculture Practice (BAP).

Still, there's understandable public scepticism over sustainable seafood labels, not to mention the green-washing risk of seafood being wrongfully claimed as sustainable, or simply mislabelled. In 2018, CNA enlisted a laboratory to test eight samples of certified sustainable fish, and found one product did not match its packaging label of Pacific cod.

55 Nonetheless, seafood labels do go some way to raise public awareness about sustainable seafood and guide consumers in making better choices. In a study conducted by consultancy GlobeScan, 75 per cent of people in Singapore felt consumers should protect fish stocks so others can enjoy them in the future. But sustainable seafood is still by far the exception rather than the norm. Walk through the seafood section in a local supermarket and you'll find that only about one in 10 seafood products have any of the three sustainability labels (MSC, ASC, or BAP).

Taking matters into our own hands

How should we as consumers prepare ourselves now for the future that we are aware of global threats to seafood availability? We could get educated, for a start. WWF Singapore published a sustainable seafood guide in 2016, identifying species that are sustainable and those that should be avoided. But

65 the industry too must step up. Food vendors today may have no idea whether their fish is sustainable and where it comes from, or even what is in a product such as fish balls. The good news is that aquaculture using sustainable technology is showing results and gaining support as part of Singapore's "30 by 30" plan.

70 Consumers can now choose from a growing range of seafood products from local farms (like fish, prawns and crabs). Operated and monitored according to the sustainability guidelines by SFA, consumers have less to worry about compared to labels from MSC and the like.

75 Food safety of new local aquaculture products will also receive a boost from NTU's recently launched Future Ready Food Safety Hub (FRESH), which uses data analytics to cut down the risk of food fraud so Singaporeans can feel more confident in these products. Innovations in food science and technology have produced higher nutrient values in familiar seafoods like seabass, groupers and soon hock. For example, the St John's sea bass, a new breed developed by SFA and Temasek Life Science Laboratory, is healthier for consumers and easier for farmers to produce.

80 It's true the current scale and production yield of Singapore's aquaculture are not yet comparable with the economies whose seafood exports we rely on. That's why local innovations should be shared with neighbouring countries, in the hopes that regional collaboration can address the threats to seafood supply. Already, local aquaculture firms Barramundi Asia and Apollo Aquaculture are expanding their operations into Brunei. In the meantime, responsible seafood consumption – such as eating less sambal stingray and steamed red grouper – may be a small way of ensuring that we can continue enjoying these dishes in the years to come.

[See end of Reading 9 for discussion/reflection questions.]

SECTION C: THE GLOBAL POLITICS OF SUSTAINABILITY

Reading 9: Wildlife- The Underreported Illegal Trade

EU 1, 3, 8

Chadwick A. Burges and Niha Wig | Adapted from ACAMS/June 2020

The following reading will help you to:

- Understand the factors that sustain transnational networks in illegal wildlife trade
- Consider the challenges involved in eradicating a global problem

Although anti-money laundering (AML) investigations are ever evolving, one major source of illegal profit internationally remains largely underreported—wildlife trafficking. Wildlife trafficking is a major illegal trade and an environmental crime that is estimated to generate between seven billion US dollars and 23 billion US dollars annually. The number of critically endangered species and the involvement of poachers is well documented. However, the illicit financial trail of this lucrative illegal trade is only sparsely covered. The unfortunate truth is that ignoring the figurative elephant in the room—wildlife trafficking—contributes to the extinction of actual elephants and other critically endangered species.

Wildlife trafficking is defined as the illegal trade, smuggling, poaching, capture or collection of endangered species, protected wildlife, their derivatives or by-products. The illegal wildlife trade threatens the extinction of various animal and plant species. It is a practice that impacts more than 7,000 species worldwide to satisfy the illegal market demands for endangered wildlife and their by-products including leather, food, medicines, exotic pets and more.

The impact goes beyond biodiversity—wildlife trafficking generates billions in revenue annually for criminal networks that often have wide international reach. According to the UN Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC), wildlife trafficking has been referred to as a major trafficking enterprise and it contributes to broader areas of environmental crimes worldwide or ‘green crimes’. Organised crime networks and criminal cartels commit environmental crimes to raise lucrative proceeds and launder illicit funds according to reports by the UN Environment Programme (UNEP) and Interpol. To highlight the potential for illicit profit compared to other trafficking enterprises, the black market value of one kilogram of rhino horn was once comparable to the value for the equivalent weight in gold, heroin or cocaine. Despite these staggering statistics, money laundering investigations related to wildlife trafficking and illicit financial flows have been limited. Criminal investigations tend to focus on the predicate offences such as poaching and illegal possession but beyond poachers, other actors in the cycle—including traders and resellers of endangered species and protected wildlife—also earn illegal proceeds. Historically, this has presented a challenge for international law enforcement agencies in detecting and investigating this crime.

Three Stages of Wildlife Trafficking

Wildlife trafficking is a global crime that impacts different regions across the world. Worldwide, countries can be involved in, or impacted by, one or more of the three stages of wildlife trafficking: source, transit and destination.

Source: The first stage indicates where initial activities occur (ie the jurisdiction where poaching and initial transport takes place). These crimes are often facilitated by bribing corrupt officials or individuals with access to the targeted species. At the source location, the profits generated are often the lowest and source countries are potentially the most impacted by the illegal wildlife trade from a biodiversity and economic standpoint.

Transit: The second stage represents the movement of poached or illegally obtained goods that are disguised and consolidated with other items for transportation. These concealed items clear customs due to known weaknesses in customs controls and/or bribery of corrupt officials.

- 40 Destination: The final stage involves poached, illegally acquired or trafficked goods arriving at their final destination for sale. As the sale of these products may be illegal in some countries, they are often sold at in-person or online black marketplaces where profits for distributors are often the highest.

Wildlife Trafficking in Europe

- Wildlife trafficking has often been addressed as a problem both in and for developing countries. However, Europe, as well as western countries including Canada and the US, may be impacted by all
45 three stages of illegal wildlife trade. European countries have been identified as source regions and exporters of certain endangered species, including the European eel and the illegal caviar from sturgeon. European eels, or glass eels, are often illegally exported from Europe to China, Taiwan, Korea and Japan, where they are used for human consumption or in fashion accessories.¹⁰ Decreasing
50 populations of wild sturgeon (including the critically endangered beluga), have been an ongoing concern as the international demand has fuelled illegal markets and allowed criminals to thrive. Due to its high price and rarity, caviar is often traded illegally.¹¹ Thus ongoing illegal fishing and trade in caviar, specifically in European countries including Romania and Bulgaria, is threatening the survival of sturgeons.

- Interpol cites European countries as major transit regions for wildlife trafficking.¹² For example,
55 European countries have been identified as transit regions for the illicit trafficking of products¹³ such as ivory, rhino horn and pangolins, which primarily flow from Africa to Asia. Nevertheless, transit through Europe is not limited to ivory, rhino horn or pangolins. In 2015 alone, approximately 2,000 live reptiles were seized at European borders together with corals and ivory as well as a long list of mammals and live bird species.

- 60 In addition to the source and transit stages, European countries, Canada and the US have also been identified as destination regions for endangered species and their by-products. This includes purchases of rare reptiles and birds as pets or purchases of elephant ivories, animal furs, claws as well as other parts of protected species for collection.¹⁵ The high demand for rare specimens and illegal
65 wildlife products in destination countries shows that black market values can be very high for certain species. In addition, high demand, limited supply and generally low penalties are all key factors that influence the participation of organised crime syndicates and criminal cartels in illegal wildlife trade at all stages.¹⁶ Therefore, criminal syndicates will continue to benefit from the lucrative trade of illegal wildlife if law enforcement and prosecutors do not improve the abilities to detect, investigate and prosecute these crimes quickly.

Corruption and Organised Crime

- 70 Corruption and organised criminal networks facilitate the illegal trade of endangered species internationally. Such a growing threat demands education and collaboration for the various partners in the public and private sectors that are responsible for identifying, deterring and arresting wildlife traffickers.

- In 2019, a collaborative report by the Wildlife Monitoring Network (TRAFFIC), World Wide Fund for
75 Nature (WWF), Anti-Corruption Resource Centre (U4), Utrecht University and Northumbria University focused specifically on corruption and wildlife crime in relation to the illegal caviar trade. The report also cites corruption as a severe threat to wildlife conservation globally, which has negatively impacted conservation program efforts; weakened laws; reduced law enforcement and political support; undermined current laws and regulations; and been a key indicator of the presence of organised crime

80 groups.¹⁸ Fuelled by the high demand for wild-sourced products and restricted supplies, organised crime groups have notoriously been involved in trafficking caviar.

Corruption is a key enabler for criminals involved in illegal wildlife trade at all stages. Moving illegal contraband across borders involves a high level of corruption in conjunction with crimes such as smuggling; forgery of permits; misdeclaration at the time of export or import; fraudulent invoicing; 85 avoidance of human or animal health quarantine as well as other transportation requirements; illegal immigration and use of false passports or identity documents; the payment of bribes; the establishment of front companies to engage in illicit trade; and equipping gangs and organised criminals to engage in illegal logging, fishing and animal poaching.

Historically, investigations related to the illegal wildlife trade have focused on predicate offences such 90 as poaching or possession of illegal species and their by-products. Despite increasing awareness of the financial component of wildlife trafficking and the lucrative proceeds that fuel criminal involvement at all stages, enforcement and investigations have rarely focused on the financial aspect of the crime. However, due to the nature of this crime, wildlife traffickers need funds to cross multiple jurisdictions and they rely heavily on the financial system to conduct transactions that can be identified in order to 95 trace their activities.

The Role of Law Enforcement and Financial Institutions (Fis) in Combatting Wildlife Trafficking

Illegal wildlife trade is a transnational crime that relies on established trade routes already used by organised criminal networks for other illegal international trades including human, drugs and arms trafficking. To identify, investigate and understand money laundering as it relates to wildlife trafficking, AML professionals may be able to learn from established money laundering typologies and red flags 100 used to detect and investigate other trafficking-related crimes as well as trade-based money laundering. However, effective and ongoing partnership with law enforcement and non-governmental organisations (NGOs) is important for establishing red flags specific to the illegal wildlife trade. If these techniques prove to be successful, AML professionals may be able to help law enforcement move beyond investigating on predicate offences and expose those who are benefiting financially from the 105 illegal trade throughout the cycle. While this technique will help address the supply side of wildlife trafficking, addressing the demand side through increased awareness and collaboration is equally important.

Wildlife trafficking is becoming an increasing priority for AML professionals and organisations worldwide. The Financial Action Task Force (FATF) declared, ‘...wildlife trafficking is estimated to be 110 the fourth largest criminal enterprise, generating billions of dollars in revenues every year. The illegal trade has links to modern slavery, drugs and arms trade while causing catastrophic damage to endangered species.’²² In September 2019, FATF President Xiangmin Liu met with Prince William and Lord William Hague at Kensington Palace to discuss the United for Wildlife Financial Taskforce, spearheaded by Prince William and The Royal Foundation. They discussed how to build this initiative 115 by focusing the governments of the 205 FATF and the FATF-style regional bodies’ member jurisdictions on tackling wildlife trafficking by following the money.

AML professionals play a key role in combatting wildlife trafficking. Criminals exploit formal and informal banking channels at various stages of the illegal trade through payments for bribery, facilitating transport, purchasing and selling poached or trafficked goods, as well as laundering illicit 120 proceeds. It is vital that AML professionals establish red flags and typologies indicative of wildlife trafficking throughout the source, transit and destination stages of this illegal cycle. AML professionals may be able to leverage established AML red flags and typologies related to other trafficking crimes as well as trade-based money laundering to identify potential wildlife trafficking red flags and typologies. However, the unique nature of wildlife trafficking will require additional efforts in

125 establishing red flags and typologies specifically aimed at identifying and investigating money laundering related to this crime.

One way FIs can combat wildlife trafficking is by joining the United for Wildlife Financial Taskforce and signing the Mansion House Declaration. Key commitments from the United for Wildlife Financial Taskforce and the Mansion House Declaration include the following:

- 130 • Utilising current suspicious activity reporting mechanisms to provide intelligence related to potential wildlife trafficking activity to the relevant regulatory body or law enforcement agency, where permitted by law
- Reviewing intelligence alerts received by the United for Wildlife Financial Taskforce and, where relevant, taking appropriate actions including due diligence screening and necessary steps to identify, investigate and report potentially suspicious financial activity related to wildlife trafficking
- 135 • Considering additional actions, including policy amendments that would support the aims of the Taskforce in addition to mechanisms related to financial crime
- Supporting the work of the United for Wildlife Financial Taskforce, promoting the Mansion House Declaration and, where possible, supporting external mechanisms that will enhance the ability of the financial industry to identify potentially suspicious activity related to wildlife trafficking
- 140

Although recent updates provide hope, more work is needed from the public and private sectors to combat wildlife trafficking and eradicate senseless extinction caused by poaching, trading and selling endangered species worldwide. Increasing awareness related to the impacts of wildlife trafficking is needed to further invoke action from governments, law enforcement, border services agencies, NGOs and private sector industries, including but not limited to FIs. Increased awareness of the impacts of wildlife trafficking may also result in a decreased public demand for poached, illegally acquired or trafficked species, reducing illicit profits for those involved in all stages of the illegal trade. Despite increasing awareness on the subject and ongoing initiatives aimed at addressing the illegal wildlife trade, continued efforts are required to ensure endangered species are protected while the illicit funds involved are sufficiently investigated by the private and public sectors.

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For discussion/reflection:

- To what extent are local and international measures sufficient in tackling over-fishing (Reading 8) and the illegal wildlife trade (Reading 9) on a global scale?
- Chen (Reading 8) suggests that Singapore should engage in efforts to address overfishing since '75 per cent of the seafood consumed in Singapore is unsustainable' (lines 10-11) and we are also 'vulnerable to temporary shocks in supply chains' (line 18). Instead of considering this issue in terms of national interest, in what ways might it be more justifiable to tackle overfishing as a matter of global responsibility?
- In your view, how is the concept of sustainable seafood consumption subject to greenwashing⁹, which Chen suggests might be happening, given the 'public scepticism over sustainable seafood labels' (line 51)?
- What is the adverse impact of wildlife trafficking that 'goes beyond biodiversity' (Reading 9, line 14)?
- In Reading 9, how do the authors use the 'value of one kilogram of rhino horn' (line 21) to support their argument that there is a significant 'potential for illicit profit' (line 20) in wildlife trafficking?

⁹ Greenwashing is engaging in behaviour or activities that make people believe that a company is doing more to protect the environment than it really is

- Burges and Wig identify and explain the three stages of wildlife trafficking: 'source, transit and destination' (line 30). In your opinion, which stage is it more feasible for the global community to tackle wildlife trafficking? Which stage is it more effective and why?
- In your own words, explain why '[c]orruption and organised criminal networks' (line 71) are key enablers when it comes to the illegal wildlife trade.
- Both articles list factors such as consumption trends, corruption, organised crime as underlying causes that give rise to food shortages and wildlife trafficking. What role do non-governmental organisations play in combatting these issues? How do their methods differ from state intervention? Why might this be a significant observation?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. Since the extinction of species is a natural phenomenon, is there any point in trying to prevent it? (Cambridge 2022)
2. Consider the view that a more sustainable future lies in the way we eat, not in renewable energy. (RI Y6 Prelims 2022)
3. 'Saving the environment is all talk and no action.' Do you agree? (RI Y5 CT 2021)
4. Examine the claim that not enough has been done for the environment in your society. (RI Y5 Promo 2016)

SECTION C: THE GLOBAL POLITICS OF SUSTAINABILITY

Reading 10: One Planet, Divided under Global Warming

EU 2-4, 7

Adapted from One planet, divided under global warming | Amy Harder | Axios | 14 January 2019

This reading will help you:

- Better understand the factors between countries when it comes to issues of climate change and why particular countries may deviate from what is meant to be a global effort.
- Make links to how politics can influence global efforts for climate change, and similarly, how stances on climate change can influence how countries treat each other.

Sure, we all share this one planet. But the warming Earth is poised to divide — not unite — us.

One cornerstone of the 2015 Paris Climate Agreement is that nations have a shared responsibility to address global warming. But the reality is that climate change won't affect everyone the same way. The impacts, while immense, aren't shared evenly around the world, and the solutions will affect some nations more than others. Two reports out last week show the uneven effects of a warming world and a transition to cleaner energy sources. Certain regions, particularly those with economies based on fossil fuels, are set to lose under the Paris deal while others, particularly China, are poised to gain.

The reality of a warmer world and government policies aiming to slow that warming are no longer a matter for the future. They're both happening now. And the convergence of those two turning points is exacerbating tensions that have been simmering for years.

Two main splits exist

The most well-known division is between developed nations that have emitted the most greenhouse gases in the past and those still developing their economies like China and India, which are increasingly emitting the most today. Those fault lines are well-documented, but others emerged more forcefully at a United Nations climate change conference last month in Poland between nations that produce fossil fuels and those that don't. In an interview at the conference with Carbon Brief, a United

Kingdom-based climate news website, a senior climate-change negotiator for the Saudi Arabian government said:

20 “As a matter of fact, we are impacted by climate change, perhaps more than anybody else. We are a desert country that heavily relies on this single source of income. We have such a vulnerable economy, fragile economy, and with oil, we eat, we feed, we travel, we educated our people, we have medical care and everything.”

— Saudi climate negotiator Ayman Shasly

25 That may seem like an unconvincing thing to say, given that some low-lying island nations are projected to literally disappear beneath rising sea levels within 80 years thanks to emissions from other nations' fossil fuels, including Saudi oil. But actually, Shasly has a point: as a desert nation, Saudi Arabia is set to face the impacts of a warmer world with more intense droughts and heatwaves. But it's also set to face the brunt of the economic pain from transitioning away from fossil fuels — if the world follows through with the Paris deal ambitions (a big if).

30 “You can see their concern is legit,” said Adele Morris, an economist who in her role at the Brookings
Institution co-wrote one of the reports released last week on this topic. That report found two regions
— Australia and the nations in the Organization of Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC) cartel,
including Saudi Arabia — would be worse off under the Paris deal in 2030, in part because they’re big
fossil-fuel exporters. All other regions, including China and even Russia, would be better off. “Even if
35 countries like Australia or the OPEC countries take very modest [climate] targets, they’re still going to
experience the spillover from what everyone else does, and there’s nothing they can do about it,”
Morris said.

40 The report considered economic effects and domestic environmental benefits of reducing emissions, but it excludes the costs of a warming planet itself, both in monetary terms and public health and safety. The latest science from the UN and others suggest those costs are likely to be significant in both Australia (i.e., worsening wildfires) and Saudi Arabia (droughts and heatwaves).

President Trump, who has vowed to withdraw America from the Paris deal, is providing political openings for nations concerned about a shift away from fossil fuels. At an event the Trump administration hosted at the conference in Poland extolling fossil fuels, an Australian government official was a last-minute addition to the panel. Also there, the U.S. joined Saudi Arabia and Russia in refusing to "welcome" a recent landmark UN report on climate change that called for drastic cuts in emissions.

What's next

As the world warms more and the renewable-energy transition increases, other divisions could emerge: several colder-climate nations, including Russia, are set to benefit or already are benefiting from warmer temperatures, such as with better agricultural output, according to a 2018 UN report. Scientists say these benefits are temporary and are offset by negative impacts. Temporary in climatic terms is still a matter of decades, which is a lifetime in politics.

55 Nations with clean-tech manufacturing and patent dominance could have geopolitical leverage over those that don't, according to the other report released last week that was coordinated by the International Renewable Energy Agency. That makes China, a leader in both, a clear winner.

For discussion/reflection:

- What is Harder implying when she observes that 'climate change won't affect everyone the same way' (line 3)?
- The first main division seen in efforts to combat climate change is 'between developed nations that have emitted the most greenhouse gases in the past and those still developing their economies' (lines 14-15). What is the second one? Out of these two divisions, which is more difficult to overcome, in your opinion?
- In what ways was then-US President Trump's intention to 'withdraw America from the Paris deal' (line 43) particularly damaging to the climate change efforts?
- Should countries be obliged to invest in and support efforts to curb climate change even at the cost of their own economic or geographical well-being?
- What issues might arise with some countries having leverage over others in terms of their expertise and production capabilities for green technology?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. 'As long as economic goals remain a priority, the environment is a lost cause.' Comment. (RI Y6 Prelim 2020)
2. 'All countries should have an equal responsibility in tackling climate change.' How far do you agree? (RI Y6 CT2 2020)
3. In times of economic difficulty, should a country still be concerned with environmental conservation? (RI Y6 Prelim 2016)
4. 'The developed world should bear the burden of climate change.' Discuss. (RI Y6 Prelim 2015)

SECTION C: THE GLOBAL POLITICS OF SUSTAINABILITY

Reading 11: Climate refugees – the world's forgotten victims

EU 1-3

Tetsuji Ida | Kyodo News | 18 June 2021

This reading will help you:

- Understand how climate change can affect human communities on a significant scale
- International and local efforts to mitigate issues vary in terms of efficiency and effectiveness

As the global climate crisis worsens, an increasing number of people are being forced to flee their homes due to natural disasters, droughts, and other weather events. These people are sometimes called “climate refugees”. Who are these climate refugees? And how can the international community properly address this issue?

Who are climate refugees?

5 Today, many people in developing countries are suffering from droughts and windstorms on a scale never seen before, depriving them of daily food and basic needs. It is still fresh in our memories that last November many people from the Central American countries of Honduras, Guatemala, and El Salvador, which were hit by two massive hurricanes, poured across the border into Mexico and headed toward the US border.

10 The term “climate refugees” was first coined to describe the increasing large-scale migration and cross-border mass movements of people that were partly caused by such weather-related disasters.

In April, the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) released data showing that the number of people displaced by climate change-related disasters since 2010 has risen to 21.5 million, pointing out that “in addition to sudden disasters, climate change is a complex cause of food and water
15 shortages, as well as difficulties in accessing natural resources.”

Sea-level rise is another threat. Over the past 30 years, the number of people living in coastal areas at high risk of rising sea levels has increased from 160 million to 260 million, 90% of whom are from poor developing countries and small island states. For example, in Bangladesh it is predicted that 17% of the country will be submerged by the rise in sea level by 2050, and 20 million people living there will
20 lose their homes.

The Ecosystem Threat Register (ETR) released in September 2018 by the Institute for Economics and Peace (IEP), an Australian international think tank, points out that at least 1.2 billion people could be displaced by these threats by 2050. In this context, the international response to the problem has gradually begun to progress.

A global response

25 The Global Compact on Safe, Orderly and Regular Migration, adopted by the UN in 2018, clearly states that one of the factors causing large-scale movements of people is “the adverse impacts of climate change and environmental degradation,” which includes natural disasters, desertification, land degradation, drought and rising sea levels. For migrants who are forced to leave their countries of origin due to environmental degradation, the compact clearly states that governments should work
30 to protect climate refugees in the countries of their arrival by devising planned relocation and visa options if adaptation and return is not possible in their countries of origin.

Earlier, in March 2018, the UN Human Rights Council adopted an outcome document that discussed the issue of cross-border movement of people brought about by climate crises from the perspective of human rights protection.

35 The document pointed out that there are many people who do not fit the definition of “refugees” among those who are forced to migrate long distances and cross borders due to climate impacts, and that the legal system to protect their human rights is inadequate, as the “non-refoulement principle”, which states that people who have crossed borders should not be deported or repatriated to their original countries against their will, is not applied. It then urged governments to “incorporate the
40 concept of human rights protection into the planning and implementation of climate change measures,” including preventing large-scale displacement by allowing people to live in conditions that

protect their human rights, and promoting human rights-conscious planned relocation as a means of adapting to climate change.

The decision made by the UN Commission on Human Rights in January 2018 also attracted a great deal of attention from those concerned.

Ioane Teitiota from Kiribati, an island nation in the South Pacific that is in danger of losing its land due to rising sea levels, applied for refugee status as a “climate refugee” with the New Zealand government, but his application was rejected and he was repatriated to Kiribati in 2015. In 2016, he filed a complaint with the UN Covenant on Civil Liberties, claiming that his right to life had been violated by the repatriation.

Although the Committee upheld the New Zealand government's decision, stating that Mr Teitiota was not facing an imminent threat to his life, it acknowledged that “the effects of climate change”, such as rising sea levels, “pose a serious threat to the right to life of people living in countries like Kiribati.” It concluded that national courts and others must take this into account when challenging the repatriation of migrants to their countries of origin. The decision held that people facing climate change impacts that violate their right to life cannot be repatriated to their country of origin. The decision has been hailed as “a decision that opens the door to climate change-related refugee claims.”

Government action

Governments are also becoming more aware of the issue. In 2015, just prior to the adoption of the Paris Agreement, the then-president of the European Union, Jean-Claude Juncker, stated in his policy speech: “Climate change is even one [of] the root causes of a new migration phenomenon. Climate refugees will become a new challenge – if we do not act swiftly,” he said, pointing out the importance of strengthening efforts. Discussions have also begun in the European Parliament.

In February, shortly after taking office, US President Joe Biden issued an executive order asking Jake Sullivan, assistant to the president for national security, to discuss with the relevant federal departments and agencies about formulating a position on how to identify climate refugees who have been displaced by climate change and what kind of protection and support the US government can provide to them. The report is expected to be submitted to the president in August.

However, it is hard to say that the international community and governments are doing enough to deal with climate change refugees, given the seriousness of the problem.

One of the reasons for this is the lack of a clear ‘climate refugee’ definition, and the absence of international organisations and institutions to address and clarify the issue. Climate change refugees are not covered by the 1951 Convention Relating to the Status of Refugees, which protects people who have a well-founded fear of persecution on racial, religious or other grounds, nor are they eligible for protection under the Convention. Official data on climate refugees is virtually non-existent – this is why they are called the “forgotten victims of climate change.”

As the problem of climate change refugees worsens, there is an urgent need to clarify the definition of climate refugees, including comprehensive data on internally displaced persons (IDPs), and create an international mechanism to protect them. It may be desirable to further discuss how to tackle this issue under the UN Framework Convention on Climate Change.

For discussion/reflection:

- Why are some governments and the international community hesitant in following through with the directives listed by the UN Human Rights Council?

- What does this case study reflect about the limitations of international organisations in dealing with global problems?
- Given the “lack of a clear ‘climate refugee’ definition” (line 71) and dearth of ‘international organisations and institutions to address and clarify the issue’ (lines 71-72), how might a collaborative approach be effective in tackling the problem of climate refugees?
- What is the link between environmental issues and social/political concerns?
- What does this reading reveal about the complexities involved in concerns related to climate change?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. Should a country still be concerned with national boundaries in today’s interconnected world? (RI Y6 CT2 2020)
2. In the light of increasing security threats, should countries still embrace the notion of a borderless world? (RI Y6 CT2 2019)
3. Should refugees be viewed as a burden in modern society? (RI Y5 Promo 2018)
4. ‘The effects of environmental degradation impact the poor the hardest.’ Discuss. (RI Y6 CT2 2018)
5. Discuss the view that countries should always take in refugees. (RI Y6 CT1 2016)
6. International cooperation has not solved the global problems of today.’ Do you agree? (RI Y6 CT2 2014)

SECTION D: WORLD POVERTY AND INEQUALITY

Glossary of terms (Reading 12 & supplementary reading at the end)

Core concepts	
Double-edged sword	• Something that has both benefits and harms • Example: Globalisation creates jobs but also widens inequality
Globalisation	• Countries becoming more connected through trade, business, and technology • Example: Apple designs in the US, manufactures in China, sells worldwide
Inequality (Income disparity)	• The gap between rich and poor • Example: CEOs earning 100× more than workers
How globalisation works	
Trust-busting (Antitrust)	• Policies to prevent monopolies and promote competition
Capital flows	• Money moving between countries • Example: Investors funding businesses overseas
Comparative Advantage	• The idea that countries should specialise in producing goods they can make most efficiently and trade for others
Economic Restructuring	• The transformation of an economy from traditional sectors (e.g., agriculture) to modern, export-oriented industries driven by global markets
Foreign Direct Investment (FDI)	• When companies invest in another country (e.g. building factories) • Example: A US company opening a factory in Vietnam
Global Integration	• The process by which local economies become connected to global trade, investment, and production networks

Global Supply Chains	• International networks where production is divided across multiple countries to maximise efficiency and reduce costs
Green Revolution	• Agricultural advancements (technology, seeds, irrigation) that increased food production
International Organisations (IOs)	• A group formed by multiple countries to work together towards shared goals or to solve global issues • Example: United Nations, World Trade Organisation, International Monetary Fund, ASEAN, EU
Multinational Corporations (MNCs)	• Companies operating in many countries • Example: Nike, Amazon
Outsourcing or Offshoring	• Moving jobs to countries where labour is cheaper • Example: Call centres based in India
Trade Liberalisation	• The removal or reduction of trade barriers (like tariffs and quotas)
Effects on jobs & people	
Capital Flight	• Large-scale withdrawal of money from a country due to instability
Job displacement	• People losing jobs due to global changes (e.g. factories moving) • Example: Local factory closes after production shifts overseas
Race to the bottom	• A situation where competing countries try to overcome each other by lowering their standards or rules so much that it ends up doing harm
Sweatshops	• Workplaces with low wages, poor conditions, and long hours
Wage stagnation	• Wages not increasing over time • Example: Salary stays the same despite rising costs
Society & inequality	
Marginalised groups	• People pushed to the edges of society • Example: Low-income workers with limited opportunities
Social mobility	• Ability to move up or down in income/status • Example: A child from a poor family becoming a doctor
Wealth concentration	• Wealth held by a small group of people • Example: Top 1% owning a large share of wealth
Stretch concepts	
Hegemony (Economic/Cultural)	• Dominance of one country (e.g., the U.S.) over others in terms of economic power or cultural influence
Neoliberalism	• Belief in free markets, less government control • Example: Privatising public services
Neoliberal Restructuring	• The reorganisation of an economy based on free-market principles, including privatisation, deregulation, trade liberalisation, and reduced government spending
Political lobbies	• Groups that tries to influence the government in terms of laws, policies, and regulations
Pollution-abatement costs	• The expenses incurred by firms or governments to reduce, control, or eliminate pollution and environmental damage.
Protectionism	• Government policies that restrict imports to protect domestic industries
Structural inequality	• Inequality built into systems, not just individual effort • Example: Weaker schooling (when schools lack good teachers, resources, or support, students receive a weaker education, which limits their chances of getting good jobs or advancing later in life leading to fewer opportunities)

Reading 12: Does globalisation help or hurt the world's poor?

EU 5

Pranab Bardhan | Scientific American | 26 March 2006

This reading will help you to:

- Identify some reasons why economic globalisation may simultaneously reduce and increase global poverty.
- Explain how domestic policies and institutions, together with the effects of economic globalisation, may lift or entrench a nation in poverty.
- Identify some ways in which international organisations and partnerships can reduce the negative impact and accentuate the positive impact of economic globalisation on poverty.

Globalisation and the attendant concerns about poverty and inequality have become a focus of discussion in a way that few other topics, except for international terrorism or global warming, have. Most people I know have a strong opinion on globalisation, and all of them express an interest in the well-being of the world's poor. The financial press and influential international officials confidently assert that global free markets expand the horizons for the poor, whereas activist-protesters hold the opposite belief with equal intensity. Yet the strength of people's conviction is often in inverse proportion to the amount of robust factual evidence they have.

As is common in contentious public debates, different people mean different things by the same word. Some interpret globalisation to mean the global reach of communications technology and capital movements, some think of the **outsourcing** by domestic companies in rich countries, and others see globalisation as a byword for corporate capitalism or American **cultural and economic hegemony**. So it is best to be clear at the outset of this article that I shall primarily refer to economic globalisation--the expansion of foreign trade and investment. How does this process affect the wages, incomes and access to resources for the poorest people in the world? This question is one of the most important in social science today.

For a quarter century after World War II, most developing countries in Africa, Asia and Latin America insulated their economies from the rest of the world. Since then, though, most have opened their markets. For instance, between 1980 and 2000, trade in goods and services expanded from 23 to 46 percent of gross domestic product (GDP) in China and from 19 to 30 percent in India. Such changes have caused many hardships for the poor in developing countries but have also created opportunities that some nations utilise and others do not, largely depending on their *domestic* political and economic institutions. (The same is true for low-wage workers in the U.S., although the effects of globalisation on rich countries are beyond the scope of this article.) The net outcome is often quite complex and almost always context-dependent, belying the glib pronouncements for or against globalisation made in the opposing camps. Understanding the complexities is essential to taking effective action.

Neither Plague nor Panacea

The case for free trade rests on the age-old principle of **comparative advantage**, the idea that countries are better off when they export the things they are best at producing, and import the rest. Most mainstream economists accept the principle, but even they have serious differences of opinion on the balance of potential benefits and actual costs from trade and on the importance of social protection for the poor. Free traders believe that the rising tide of international specialisation and investment lifts all boats. Others point out that many poor people lack the capacity to adjust, retool and relocate with changing market conditions. These scholars argue that the benefits of specialisation materialise in the long run, over which people and resources are assumed to be fully mobile, whereas the adjustments can cause pain in the short run.

The debate among economists is a paragon of civility compared with the one taking place in the streets. Antiglobalisers' central claim is that globalisation is making the rich richer and the poor poorer; proglobalisers assert that it actually helps the poor. But if one looks at the factual evidence, the matter is rather more complicated. On the basis of household survey data collected by different agencies, the World Bank estimates the fraction of the population in developing countries that falls below the 1-a-day poverty line (at 1993 prices)--an admittedly crude but internationally comparable level. By this measure, extreme poverty is declining in the aggregate.

The trend is particularly pronounced in East, South and Southeast Asia. Poverty has declined sharply in China, India and Indonesia--countries that have long been characterised by massive rural poverty and that together account for about half the total population of developing countries. Between 1981 and 2001 the percentage of rural people living on less than 1 a day decreased from 79 to 27 percent in China, 63 to 42 percent in India, and 55 to 11 percent in Indonesia.

But although the poorest are not, on the whole, getting poorer, no one has yet convincingly demonstrated that improvements in their condition are mainly the result of globalisation. In China the poverty trend could instead be attributed to internal factors such as the expansion of infrastructure, the massive 1978 land reforms (in which the Mao-era communes were disbanded), changes in grain procurement prices, and the relaxation of restrictions on rural-to-urban migration. In fact, a substantial part of the decline in poverty had already happened by the mid-1980s, before the big strides in foreign trade or investment. Of the more than 400 million Chinese lifted above the international poverty line between 1981 and 2001, three fourths got there by 1987.

Similarly, rural poverty reduction in India may be attributable to the spread of the **Green Revolution** in agriculture, government antipoverty programs and social movements--not the **trade liberalisation** of the 1990s. In Indonesia the Green Revolution, macroeconomic policies, stabilisation of rice prices and massive investment in rural infrastructure played a substantial role in the large reduction of rural poverty. Of course, globalisation, by expanding employment in labour-intensive manufacturing, has helped to pull many Chinese and Indonesians out of poverty since the mid-1980s (though not yet as much in India, for various domestic institutional and policy reasons). But it is only one factor among many accounting for the economic advances of the past 25 years.

Those who are dubious of the benefits of globalisation point out that poverty has remained stubbornly high in sub-Saharan Africa. Between 1981 and 2001 the fraction of Africans living below the international poverty line increased from 42 to 47 percent. But this deterioration appears to have less to do with globalisation than with unstable or failed political regimes. If anything, such instability reduced their extent of globalisation, as it scared off many foreign investors and traders. Volatile politics amplifies longer-term factors such as geographic isolation, disease, overdependence on a small number of export products, and the slow spread of the Green Revolution.

Sweatshops

Global market competition in general rewards people with initiative, skills, information and entrepreneurship in all countries. Poor people everywhere are handicapped by their lack of access to capital and opportunities to learn new skills. Workers in some developing countries--say, Mexico--are losing their jobs in labour-intensive manufacturing to their counterparts in Asia. At the same time, **foreign investment** has also brought new jobs. Overall, the effect appears to be a net improvement. In Mexico, low-wage poverty is declining in the regions that are more involved in the international economy than others--even controlling for the fact that skilled and enterprising people migrate to those regions, improving incomes there independently of what globalisation accomplishes. A recent study by Gordon H. Hanson of the University of California, San Diego, which took into account only people born in a particular region (thus leaving out migrants), found that during the 1990s average incomes in the Mexican states most affected by globalisation increased 10 percent more than those least affected.

In poor Asian economies, such as Bangladesh, Vietnam and Cambodia, large numbers of women now have work in garment export factories. Their wages are low by world standards but much higher than they would earn in alternative occupations. Advocates who worry about exploitative sweatshops have to appreciate the relative improvement in these women's conditions and status.

In 2001 Naila Kabeer of the University of Sussex in England and Simeen Mahmud of the Bangladesh Institute of Development Studies did a survey of 1,322 women workers in Dhaka. They discovered that the average monthly income of workers in garment-export factories was 86 percent above that of other wage workers living in the same slum neighborhoods.

Another indication of this relative improvement can be gauged by what happens when such opportunities disappear. In 1993, anticipating a U.S. ban on imports of products made using child labour, the garment industry in Bangladesh dismissed an estimated 50,000 children. UNICEF and local aid groups investigated what happened to them. About 10,000 children went back to school, but the rest ended up in much inferior occupations, including stone breaking and child prostitution. That does not excuse the appalling working conditions in the sweatshops, let alone the cases of forced or unsafe labour, but advocates must recognise the severely limited existing opportunities for the poor and the possible unintended consequences of fair trade policies.

The Local Roots of Poverty

Integration into the international economy brings not only opportunities but also problems. Even when new jobs are better than the old ones, the transition can be wrenching. Most poor countries provide very little effective social protection to help people who have lost their jobs and not yet found new ones. Moreover, vast numbers of the poor work on their own small farms or for household enterprises. The major constraints they usually face are domestic, such as lack of access to credit, poor infrastructure, venal government officials and insecure land rights. Weak states, unaccountable regimes, lopsided wealth distribution, and inept or corrupt politicians and bureaucrats often combine to block out the opportunities for the poor. Opening markets without relieving these domestic constraints forces people to compete with one hand tied behind their back. The result can be deepened poverty.

Conversely, opening the economy to trade and long-term **capital flows** need not make the poor worse off if appropriate domestic policies and institutions are in place--particularly to help shift production to more marketable goods and help workers enter new jobs.

Contrasting case studies of countries make this quite apparent. Although the island economies of Mauritius and Jamaica had similar per capita incomes in the early 1980s, their economic performance since then has diverged dramatically, with the former having better participatory institutions and rule of law and the latter mired in crime and violence. South Korea and the Philippines had similar per capita incomes in the early 1960s, but the Philippines languished in terms of political and economic institutions (especially because power and wealth were concentrated in a few hands), so it remains a developing country, while South Korea has joined the ranks of the developed. Botswana and Angola are two diamond-exporting countries in southern Africa, the former democratic and fast-growing, the latter ravaged by civil war and plunder.

The experiences of these and other countries demonstrate that antipoverty programs need not be blocked by the forces of globalisation. There is no **race to the bottom** in which countries must abandon social programs to keep up economically; in fact, social and economic goals can be mutually supportive. Land reform, expansion of credit and services for small producers, retraining and income support for displaced workers, public-works programs for the unemployed, and provision of basic education and health can enhance the productivity of workers and farmers and thereby contribute to a country's global competitiveness. Such programs may require a rethinking of budget priorities in those nations and a more accountable political and administrative framework, but the obstacles are largely domestic. Conversely, closing the economy to international trade does not reduce the power of the relevant

vested interests: landlords, politicians and bureaucrats, and the rich who enjoy government subsidies. Thus, globalisation is not the main cause of developing countries' problems, contrary to the claim of critics of globalisation--just as globalisation is often not the main solution to these problems, contrary to the claim of overenthusiastic free traders.

What about the environment? Many conservationists argue that international integration encourages the overexploitation of fragile natural resources, such as forests and fisheries, damaging the livelihoods of the poor. A common charge against transnational companies is that they flock to poor countries with lax environmental standards. Anecdotes abound, but researchers have done very few statistical studies. One of the few, published in 2003 by Gunnar Eskeland of the World Bank and Ann Harrison of the University of California, Berkeley, considered Mexico, Morocco, Venezuela and Ivory Coast. It found very little evidence that companies chose to invest in these countries to shirk **pollution-abatement costs** in rich countries; the single most important factor in determining the amount of investment was the size of the local market. Within a given industry, foreign plants tended to pollute less than their local peers.

Like persistent poverty, lax environmental standards are ultimately a domestic policy or institutional failure. A lack of well-defined or well-enforced property rights or regulation of common property resources often leads to their overuse. Responding to pressure from powerful **political lobbies**, governments have deliberately kept down the prices of precious environmental resources: irrigation water in India, energy in Russia, timber concessions in Indonesia and the Philippines. The result, unsurprisingly, is resource depletion. To be sure, if a country opens its markets without dealing with these distortions, it can worsen the environmental problems.

When Talk Gives Way to Action

Fortunately, the two sides of the globalisation debate are – slowly – developing some measure of agreement. In many areas, advocates in both camps see the potential for coordination among transnational companies, multilateral organisations, developing country governments and local aid groups on programs to help the poor. Going beyond the contentious debates and building on the areas of emerging consensus and cooperation, international partnerships may be able to make a dent in the poverty that continues to oppress the lives of billions of people in the world. Here are some measures under discussion.

Capital controls. The flow of international investment consists both of long-term capital (such as equipment) and of speculative short-term capital (such as shares, bonds and currency). The latter, shifted at the click of a mouse, can stampede around the globe in herdlike movements, causing massive damage to fragile economies. The Asian financial crisis of 1997 was an example. Following speculators' run on the Thai currency, the baht, the poverty rate in rural Thailand jumped 50 percent in just one year. In Indonesia, a mass withdrawal of short-term capital caused real wages in manufacturing to drop 44 percent. Many economists (including those who otherwise support free trade) now see a need for some form of control over short-term capital flows, particularly if domestic financial institutions and banking standards are weak. It is widely believed that China, India and Malaysia escaped the brunt of the Asian financial crisis because of their stringent controls on capital flight. Economists still disagree, though, on what form such control should take and what effect it has on the cost of capital.

Reduced protectionism. The major hurdle many poor countries face is not too much globalisation but too little. It is hard for the poor of the world to climb out of poverty when rich countries (as well as the poor ones themselves) restrict imports and subsidise their own farmers and manufacturers. The annual loss to developing countries as a group from agricultural tariffs and subsidies in rich countries is estimated to be 45 billion; their annual loss from trade barriers on textile and clothing is estimated to be 24 billion. The toll exceeds rich countries' foreign aid to poor countries. Of course, the loss is not equally distributed among poor countries. Some would benefit more than others if these import restrictions and subsidies were lifted.

Trust-busting. Small exporters in poor nations often lack the marketing networks and brand names to make inroads into rich-country markets. Although transnational retail companies can help them, the margins and fees they charge are often very high. Restrictive business practices by these international middlemen are difficult to prove, but a great deal of circumstantial evidence exists. The international coffee market, for example, is dominated by four companies. In the early 1990s the coffee earnings of exporting countries were about 12 billion, and retail sales were 30 billion. By 2002 retail sales had more than doubled, yet coffee-producing countries received about half their earnings of a decade earlier. The problem is not global markets but impeded access to those markets or depressed prices received by producers, as a result of the near-monopoly power enjoyed by a few retail firms. In certain industries, companies may actively collude to fix prices. Some economists have proposed an international **antitrust** investigation agency. Even if such an agency did not have much enforcement power, it could mobilise public opinion and strengthen the hands of antitrust agencies in developing countries. In addition, internationally approved quality-certification programs can help poor-country products gain acceptance in global markets.

Social programs. Many economists argue that for trade to make a country better off, the government of that country may have to redistribute wealth and income to some extent, so that the winners from the policy of opening the economy share their gains with the losers. Of course, the phrase to some extent still leaves room for plenty of disagreement. Nevertheless, certain programs stir fairly little controversy, such as assistance programs to help workers cope with job losses and get retrained and redeployed. Scholarships allowing poor parents to send their children to school have proved to be more effective at reducing child labour than banning imports of products.

Research. The Green Revolution played a major role in reducing poverty in Asia. New international private-public partnerships could help develop other products suitable for the poor (such as medicines, vaccines and crops). Under the current international patent regime, global pharmaceutical companies do not have much incentive to do costly research on diseases such as malaria and tuberculosis that kill millions of people in poor countries every year. But research collaborations are emerging among donor agencies, the World Health Organization, groups such as Doctors Without Borders and private foundations such as the Bill & Melinda Gates Foundation.

Immigration reform in rich countries. A program to permit larger numbers of unskilled workers into rich countries as guest workers would do more to reduce world poverty than other forms of international integration, such as trade liberalisation, can. The current climate, however, is not very hospitable to this idea.

Simplistic antiglobalisation slogans or sermons on the unqualified benefits of free trade do not serve the cause of alleviating world poverty. An appreciation of the complexity of the issues and an active interweaving of domestic and international policies would be decidedly more fruitful.

For discussion/reflection:

- Based on lines 32-35, what concerns do critics have of free trade??
- Summarise the main reasons why benefits of globalisation on the poor have not been 'convincingly demonstrated' (lines 48-49).
- What might be the 'possible unintended consequences of fair trade policies' (line 98) of attempts by advocates (line 97) to target 'sweatshops' (line 96) in poor, developing countries?
- Explain why the author argues that the 'transition [into new jobs from old ones] can be wrenching' (lines 100-101).
- What are some reasons why economic globalisation may have reduced or heightened global poverty?
- In your opinion, what contributes more to global poverty - domestic policies and institutions or international flows of economic capital? Why?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. 'No country should sacrifice its economic development in favour of preserving the environment.' Discuss. (Cambridge 2025)
2. How far can prosperity and uncontrolled population growth go hand in hand? (Cambridge 2020)
3. Is globalisation to be welcomed or feared today? (Cambridge 2019)
4. To what extent are young people in your society prepared for a world that is constantly changing? (RI Y6 Prelim 2019)
5. 'International cooperation has not solved the global problems of today.' Do you agree? (RI Y6 CT2 2014)
6. 'Make poverty history.' Is this a realistic goal? (RI Y5 CT 2013)

Supplementary Reading:

1. Latin America, Nov 2025, Sociology.Institution

Globalisation's Impact on Poverty: A Double-Edged Sword

Latin America case study shows globalisation as a rising tide that lifts all boats, driving growth and investment, but displacing low-skilled workers, expanding informal employment, and worsening urban inequality and poverty.

SECTION D: WORLD POVERTY AND INEQUALITY

Reading 13: Globalisation, Technology and Inequality

EU 5

Zia Qureshi | The Brookings Institution | 16 Feb 2018

This reading will help you to:

- Understand how globalisation and technology have led to the rise in inequality.
- Consider the potential of policy as a plausible solution.

We are living in a time of mounting societal discontent and political divisiveness—a “fractured world,” as captured in the theme of the recent World Economic Forum meeting in Davos. In many countries, social disaffection with economic outcomes is up sharply, roiling the political landscape and stoking populist and nationalist sentiment. Brexit and the outcome of the 2016 United States presidential election are but the more dramatic examples of these socio-political dynamics that hold wider sway.

What explains the rising tide of socio-economic unhappiness? The world has not become less prosperous. It is true that the global financial crisis caused major setbacks, but economic growth has recovered. The economic pie is growing—although not as fast as before, as economic growth is being held down by a longer-term decline in productivity growth. The increasingly unequal sharing of the economic pie lies at the heart of the rising social discontent.

Income and wealth inequalities have risen practically in all major economies, and sharply in several of them. In the U.S., for example, the income share of the richest 1 percent has more than doubled since the early 1980s to around 22 percent, with the wealth share rising to almost 40 percent. Those with middle-class incomes have been squeezed and the typical worker has seen largely stagnant real wages. In the “land of opportunity,” social mobility has been stalling. Even as economic growth gathered steam in 2017, economic disparities continued to mount. According to a report released on the eve of

the Davos meeting, 4 out of 5 dollars of the increase in global wealth in 2017 accrued to the top 1 percent.

20 In the cauldron of political debate, much of the blame for the rise in inequality is heaped on globalisation—often from both ends of the political spectrum. The popular backlash against globalisation has been fed by a negative political crescendo. Another factor blamed is technological change—digitisation, the rise of robots, artificial intelligence—that is seen to favor capital and higher-level skills at the expense of ordinary workers. More and more, we hear calls to throw sand in the wheels of technological change, reflecting an ascendant neo-Luddism.

25 Most dynamic economic change inevitably creates winners and losers. Globalisation and technology are no exceptions. They are key forces that drive innovation, productivity, and economic growth. But they also have been important factors behind the rise in inequalities we have witnessed—with technological change playing a stronger role. The distributional consequences of these forces, however, are not pre-ordained. Outcomes that are more inclusive are certainly possible. Much
30 depends on policies. Sadly, policies for the most part have not risen to the new challenges. Indeed, they have often exacerbated rather than ameliorated the outcomes.

Attempting to inhibit globalisation or technological change would be the wrong response to the rising popular discontent with their distributional outcomes. Instead, policies must do better to ensure that the economic gains are more widely shared. This means improving the enabling environment for firms
35 and workers—to broaden access to opportunities that come with globalisation and technological change and to enhance capabilities to adjust to the new challenges. Fresh, out-of-the box thinking is needed to bring policies in step with today's economic transformations.

Competition must be strengthened in industry and finance to check the growth of monopolistic structures and abuse of market power. Competition policies must be revamped for the digital age
40 marked by the rise of winner-take-all technology giants. Technology policies must be reformed so that they promote innovation and wide diffusion rather than serve primarily to lock in incumbents' advantages as under the current patent systems.

Access to quality education and training must be greatly improved, including putting in place stronger and smarter programs for worker upskilling and reskilling and lifelong learning to respond to the
45 shifting demand for skills. New models of public-private partnerships and technology-enabled solutions must be explored. Labour market policies and social protection systems must be adapted to the realities of a dynamic job market with more frequent shifts between jobs and more diverse work arrangements.

Governments must reorient expenditure priorities and find the fiscal space to restore public
50 investment programs in infrastructure and research and development that have been allowed to run down. They must also review tax and transfer systems that have seen erosion of their redistributive role.

Reforms are needed at the international level as well, so that rules of engagement between countries in trade and other areas are fair. But the dominant part of the agenda to make globalisation work
55 better and for all rests with policies at the national level. A few years ago, Richard Haass wrote a book entitled "Foreign Policy Begins at Home." In the same vein, globalisation begins at home. Rather than decry globalisation, politicians should exert more to put national policy houses in order.

The political debate needs to shift from frenzied rhetoric to take up the cudgels against primal forces to a calmer and more serious focus on policies that matter. The aphorism “it’s the economy, stupid” captured the political zeitgeist of the not too distant past. “It’s the policies, stupid” would be an apt renewal of that exhortation for our time.

[See end of Reading 14 for discussion/reflection questions.]

SECTION D: WORLD POVERTY AND INEQUALITY

Reading 14: How AI Exclusion Impacts Humankind

EU 3 & 5

Cornelia C. Walther | Knowledge at Wharton | 8 Jan 2025

This reading will help you understand:

- The world’s current economic and social climate and how AI has affected us positively and negatively
- Possible solutions and difficulties in being able to balance out inequalities associated with the use of AI
- The precautionary steps we can take in an era of dramatic change

Artificial Intelligence (AI) has the potential to radically reshape how societies operate, from optimizing resource distribution to enhancing education, health care, and economic opportunities. Done right, AI can serve as a powerful lever for inclusion—amplifying the voices of the marginalized, widening access to essential services, and closing development gaps. Done poorly, it can embed and even exacerbate the inequalities it was meant to address. The key difference lies in intentional design, implementation, and governance centered on inclusivity and equity rather than profit or efficiency alone.

Inclusion is not just a moral or social issue; it’s a strategic necessity in the age of AI. Companies that ignore exclusion risk reputational harm, potential regulatory backlash, and lost opportunities in emerging markets. Conversely, those embracing inclusive principles gain a competitive edge, foster innovation, and earn community trust.

AI Has the Potential to Help and Harm Humankind

Global development stands at a crossroads, with the World Bank warning that 2020-2030 could become a “lost decade.”

About 700 million people — 8.5% of the global population — survive on under \$2.15 a day, over twice the population of the United States. Even more starkly, 3.5 billion people (half of humanity) live on less than \$7 daily, showing that population growth has eroded many income gains since 1990. Inequality remains entrenched, with one in five living in highly unequal societies — predominantly in Latin America and sub-Saharan Africa. Meanwhile, to reach just \$25 a day (a modest benchmark for high-income nations), global incomes would need a fivefold increase amid sluggish growth and COVID-19 setbacks. Compounding this crisis, nearly 20% of the world’s population will face severe climate shocks, disproportionately harming poorer regions and perpetuating entrenched vulnerability.

Amid these overlapping crises — stagnating poverty reduction, persistent inequality, and climate vulnerability — AI arises both as a promise and a peril. On one hand, AI is powering disease diagnostics, enhancing agricultural productivity, and expanding educational resources. Conversely, it threatens to become a new fault line, dividing those who can harness it from those left behind while at the same time consuming gigantic amounts of energy and hereby, worsening the climate conundrum.

One part of the crux of that challenge is that AI thrives on data, which reflects our world. When training sets contain historical biases, discriminatory practices, or imbalances in representation, AI models risk perpetuating and amplifying those inequities. Studies have repeatedly shown that biased facial recognition algorithms misidentify people with darker skin at far higher rates than white individuals — errors that have led to wrongful arrests and deepened distrust in technology. Similarly, hiring algorithms trained on historically imbalanced datasets may favor certain demographics, effectively shutting out qualified candidates from underrepresented communities.

How AI Can Impact Digital Poverty

These issues are not simply “technical bugs” but structural problems that further enshrine social divides. Data poverty mirrors digital poverty. Marginalized groups lack digital infrastructure and are often absent or misrepresented in the datasets fueling AI applications. AI will replicate and reinforce the world’s systemic inequities if we fail to address these underlying disparities.

Bridging the digital divide is imperative, but focusing on digital access alone is insufficient. We must look toward a vision of “analog abundance,” where the tangible benefits of AI — improved water distribution, better health care outreach, more resilient agriculture — directly serve communities, especially those that lack personal digital devices or solid online connectivity. Recent initiatives by the World Economic Forum’s Centre for the Fourth Industrial Revolution and the Stanford Institute for Human-Centered AI emphasize that inclusive AI solutions must consider local contexts, cultural nuances, and analog infrastructures. AI can optimize irrigation in drought-prone regions, enhance the distribution of essential medicines, or improve early warning systems for climate disasters without requiring every individual to be digitally connected. However, these types of prosocial AI applications require human aspirations and political priorities behind the scenes.

Key Elements to Building an Inclusive AI Ecosystem

To move from exclusion to inclusion, businesses and policymakers need a deliberate framework. This begins with the design phase. Diverse teams and inclusive datasets reduce blind spots. At the same time, transparent governance structures — such as model cards for model reporting and adherence to ethical guidelines — ensure that our AI systems serve equitable ends.

Investing in accessibility also matters. Partnerships between academia, businesses, governments, and NGOs can expand internet connectivity, strengthen digital literacy programs, and provide training in AI readiness. Making the next generation future-proof requires “double literacy,” a holistic understanding of both our brains and algorithms. Both must be combined with critical thinking, problem-solving skills, and oversight competencies within communities that stand to benefit most.

Meanwhile, AI should complement, not displace, analog systems. In agricultural regions without stable internet, AI-driven insights can still guide farmers on optimal planting times or pest management strategies through radio broadcasts, printed materials, or local extension officers. This hybrid approach ensures that the benefits of AI reach communities regardless of their baseline technological infrastructure.

The ABCD framework below offers a roadmap to ensure business leaders and policymakers can effectively identify AI exclusion and improve AI inclusion. It can serve to frame the four principal challenges at stake — and offer four practical approaches for turning them into opportunities.

The ABCD Framework of Identifying AI Exclusion

Agency - Who controls AI? Empower individuals and communities to shape AI tools that impact their lives. Transparency, explainability, and community input can prevent AI from becoming an instrument of subjugation.

Bonding - How does AI foster connection? AI should bring people together, facilitating collaboration rather than deepening isolation. For instance, tools that bridge language barriers can amplify voices typically left unheard.

- 70 **Climate** - What is the environmental cost of AI? As AI's computational demands grow, it is vital to develop sustainable practices. Responsible deployment means balancing the energy needs of model training with renewable energy investments and more efficient algorithms.

- Dilemmas** - How do we mitigate unintended consequences? From biased recommendations to exclusionary hiring tools, careful attention must be paid to governance, accountability, and correcting harmful outcomes. Global standards, like the ones championed by UNESCO and the OECD, can guide practitioners toward more ethical and inclusive AI.
- 75

- Leaders may want to focus on the D, or "Dilemmas," because these highlight the tension between AI's promise as a democratizing force and its peril as a mechanism of injustice; it also illustrates the tension of AI as a commercial determinant of society and its potential to become a social driver of shared quality of life.
- 80

The ABCD Framework of Improving AI Inclusion

Audit and Improve Data Practices - Scrutinize data sources to identify biases and representation gaps. Adopt robust data governance frameworks to ensure that the insights fueling AI systems are as inclusive and fair as possible.

- Build with Inclusive Design** - Involve stakeholders from underrepresented communities in the ideation, design, and testing phases of AI deployment. These perspectives can help developers uncover blind spots and craft solutions that resonate globally.
- 85

Champion Ethical and Sustainable Policies - Advocate for regulations and industry guidelines prioritizing transparency, accountability, and environmental responsibility. Align corporate AI strategies with global ethical frameworks to build trust and credibility.

- 90 **Drive Measurable Digital Equity** - Invest in initiatives that broaden access to digital tools, skills training, and supporting infrastructure, especially in underserved regions. Consider metrics for social impact alongside traditional KPIs — companies that demonstrate tangible societal benefits will gain long-term trust and loyalty.

Moving Beyond Boxes to Common Ground

- The societal rifts we face today will not be "fixed" by AI alone. In fact, without careful stewardship, AI may simply magnify existing divisions and biases. The power to shape AI's trajectory remains — for the time being — in human hands. As we enter this new era, the question is not whether we could or if we should leverage AI for social good, but how.
- 95

- AI can help us transcend digital divides and foster analog abundance, where its benefits uplift the many rather than the few. To make that happen, inclusion must be systematically embedded from the start through diverse teams, transparent governance, ethical data practices, and a willingness to learn from traditionally overlooked communities. We have choices, and the future depends on them — and us.
- 100

For discussion/reflection:

- How can AI help and at the same time hinder us?
- Of the ABCD of AI inclusion/exclusion (see lines 64-93), which do you think is of greater impact and why?

- Walther proposes “partnerships between academia, businesses, governments, and NGOs” (lines 51-52) to improve “accessibility” (line 51). Which sector should take primary responsibility for this and why?
- Of the four types of AI exclusion given in the ABCD framework (lines 64-76), which is the most difficult to overcome? Justify your answer.
- Why does Walther say that “the question is not whether we could or if we should leverage AI for social good, but how” (lines 96-97)?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. Assess the view that poor nations are more vulnerable than ever in today’s world. (RI Y6 CT 2023)
2. ‘The solution to global hunger is simply about providing more food.’ How far do you agree? (RI Y6 Timed Practice 2022)
3. ‘Science is the only answer to global hunger.’ Discuss. (Cambridge 2019)
4. Consider the impact of technology on world hunger today. (RI Y6 CT2 2019)

Supplementary Readings:

- [How big data can alleviate poverty](#) (Jan 2019, Stanford, USA) - By using machine learning and big data, Stanford researchers identify specific drivers of hardship to replace one-size-fits-all policies with tailored, data-driven interventions and psychological tools that address unique individual needs.

SECTION D: WORLD POVERTY AND INEQUALITY

Reading 15: From the Great Resignation to Lying Flat, Workers Are Opting Out **EU 1, 5-6**

Allen Wan et al. | Bloomberg Businessweek | 8 December 2021

This reading will help you:

- Understand the global trend of workers leaving their jobs due to wage stagnation and overworking.
- Consider the economic, political, and social implications of the change in mindset towards work.

The Great Resignation has U.S. workers quitting their jobs in record numbers—more than 24 million did so from April to September this year—and many are staying out of the labour force. Germany, Japan, and other wealthy nations are seeing shades of the same trend. The pandemic has taken a toll, with surveys showing an increase in feelings of burnout and a deterioration in mental health in many nations. But the pressure has been building in developed countries for decades. Incomes have stagnated, job security has become precarious, and the costs of housing and education have soared, leaving fewer young people able to build a financially stable life.

Although the Great Resignation is a phenomenon among those who are younger than 40, it’s also reverberating across the economy and forcing a broader conversation about work. Millennials (born between 1980 and the late 1990s) and Generation Z (the demographic cohort after them) tend to marry, buy houses, and have children later than their forebears—if at all.

China’s “lie flat” movement, jump-started by a social media post from which it got its name, is also about opting out. It’s a reaction against a system in which a grueling “996” work schedule—9 a.m. to

15 9 p.m., six days a week—is common in industries like technology. So is unrelenting pressure from family, society, and even the government to keep climbing the ladder.

The country's economy has doubled in size over the past decade, but not everybody is reaping the benefits: In many big cities the rising cost of living is outstripping wage growth. As a result, some see the lie flat phenomenon as a warning of impending Japan-style stagnation—one that's arrived
20 unexpectedly early in the economy's development. Others argue it's more of the 1960s-style counterculture movements that cropped up in the U.S. and parts of Western Europe, with ordinary people seeking a lower-pressure society that's more focused on personal development. "It's basically a coincidence that these two discourses emerged at the same time," says Xiang Biao, director of the Max Planck Institute for Social Anthropology in Germany. "But we can make a connection. It's about
25 how the economy has become overheated and unsustainable, both in an environmental sense and in a mental sense."

Almost half of the world's workers are considering quitting, according to a Microsoft Corp. survey. About 4 in 10 millennial and Gen Z respondents say they'd leave their job if asked to come back to the office full time, a global survey by advisory company Qualtrics International Inc. found—more than
30 any other generation. Some among older generations have criticised these attitudes as privileged and lazy. But the reality is that working hours have been dropping in richer countries for decades across all age brackets.

In the face of existential threats such as the pandemic and climate change, the Great Resignation and 'Lie Flat' movement have the potential to spark a deeper discussion about the relentless pursuit of
35 wealth, at the individual level and for nations as a whole. "When confronted with the prospect of mortality, people definitely behave differently," says Benjamin Granger, head of employee experience advisory services at Qualtrics. "People are looking at work through a very different lens. The lens is things like, 'I am not working for a paycheck. That's not what this is about. I need to be fulfilled.'"

Lying Flat in China

40 What started as a witty expression of Chinese youthful rebellion has become a movement that even Xi Jinping has acknowledged. In a speech in August, the president urged the country to "avoid involution and lying flat" and instead "open channels for upward mobility."

"I haven't been working for two years, and I don't see anything wrong with this," read the April post
45 on the Baidu Tieba platform that sent lie flat viral. "Pressure mainly comes from comparisons with your peers and the values of the older generations. But we don't have to follow them."

The poster, who went by the name Kind-Hearted Traveler, drew a comparison with the ancient Greek philosopher Diogenes, an ascetic who lived in a barrel. "Lying flat is my philosophical movement."

The movement's spiritual home may be Shenzhen, in southeastern China. The booming technology
50 hub is home to giant electronics factories and companies such as Huawei Technologies Co. and Tencent Holdings Ltd.—as well as 18 million people, many of whom have moved there from other parts of China to chase their dreams of affluence. Now, as the economy slows, some are wondering if those dreams are worth the effort.

Jack, a 32-year-old tech worker who gave only one name for fear of reprisal from his employer, was
55 full of ambition when a telecommunications company hired him five years ago. But a punishing workload failed to translate into the success he'd hoped for, and over time his enthusiasm drained away. He's still working, but not as hard.

Rethinking Work After the Pandemic

60 “Many internet industries have reached a stage where there is no explosive growth,” Jack says. “But all the heavy work is still here. All the stress is still here. You lose hope.”

That Shenzhen is among the world’s least affordable cities adds to his woes. “Even for well-paid professionals like me and my girlfriend, it’s still crazy,” he says. “The down payment for a flat in Shenzhen is 2, 3 million yuan [about \$314,000 to \$471,000]. That’s like both our savings, plus very huge help from our parents.”

65 In October thousands of employees at companies including Alibaba Group Holding Ltd. and TikTok owner ByteDance Ltd. participated in an online campaign branded “Worker Lives Matter” by posting information on when they start and end their workdays on a public spreadsheet. ByteDance has since mandated a shorter workweek.

70 In memes and online posts, younger Chinese people call their generation “mouse people” and “salted fish.” (In Cantonese a salted fish is a metaphor for a corpse, but it can also mean people lacking ambition or drive.) If such attitudes become pervasive, they could accelerate population decline: China’s birthrate dropped to a record low in 2020, a major concern because the labour force is already shrinking.

75 At the Sanhe employment exchange in the north of Shenzhen, dozens of recent arrivals from other parts of China gather to browse job postings. While the country’s migrant workers were once celebrated for their industriousness, these men and women have developed a reputation for whiling away their time playing online games or streaming TV, picking up day jobs only when they need money to pay their phone bill or rent. Shunning longer-term work and factory jobs in favor of less demanding service roles, they sum up their lifestyle in a simple mantra: “Work for a day, have fun for three.”

80 On a recent morning, Mr. Li, a 32-year-old from Shaanxi province who declined to give his full name, surveyed the market’s bulletin board with little enthusiasm. When a recruiter approached with a smartphone video from a factory seeking workers, Li rejected the job as soon as he saw it involved operating heavy machinery.

85 Li’s attitude suggests the lie flat movement may be a symptom of a new stage in China’s economic development: As a nation gets richer, its workers can afford to be more choosy. In the U.S. and Europe, the formation of a large middle class was key to the rise of 1960s counterculture and, later, the so-called slacker generation of the ’90s.

90 In an echo of those Western movements, middle-class young Chinese people—with prospects beyond anything their parents could ever have hoped for—say their society is too conformist and materialistic. “There is a rather limited definition of success,” says Chen Ziyang, 25, who’s living in Shenzhen while studying online for a master’s degree from the University of Chicago.

“We all know Jack Ma and those CEOs. But if everyone pursued that kind of career, of course there will be more competition and depression,” she says over drinks at an upscale teahouse. “Some people give up and lie flat.”

95 American Resignation

In the U.S. the financial anxieties of millennials long predate Covid-19. Because of the combination of an explosion in student debt and the plodding recovery from the Great Recession, this generation is likely to be the first in U.S. history to be less wealthy than their parents.

The pandemic appears to have brought these concerns to a head. Two-thirds of millennials who left their jobs in 2021 cited mental health reasons, according to a Mind Share Partners survey, and the proportion for Gen Z was even higher, at 81%.

The human and economic carnage caused by Covid has also left many young people questioning their priorities. In July 2020 the federal agency in Washington, D.C., where Ben Anderson worked summoned its staff back to the office without supplying safety equipment or making accommodations for social distancing. After a colleague became a Covid long-hauler, Anderson began to wonder whether a steady job was the key to security and a good life after all. “As the world collapsed, I don’t think they gave a shit about me,” the 29-year-old says.

Quitting had been on his mind for a few years already. He’d earned top grades in college, relocated to a big city for work, and spent seven years in a full-time, white-collar job. Yet he still couldn’t save enough to buy a home. “Work was crazy stressful, and I was far from my family,” he says. “And at a certain point it was like, ‘For what?’ I was working in a gigantic bureaucracy in which you don’t effect change. It’s not built for that. I just got jaded.” He’s now living in Los Angeles and acting in television shows and commercials. “I have as much chance in something as insane as Hollywood as running the gauntlet at a government job,” he says.

Although the Great Resignation is often thought of as a youth movement, at least one study shows employees from age 30 to 45 are also quitting at high rates. Nate Mann, who at 40 is among the oldest millennials, spent almost half his life as a bartender in Washington, D.C. He put up with late nights and high stress in return for about \$80,000 a year. But when Covid closed the bar at which he worked in March 2020, he decided to focus on something he’d been doing on the side for a while: painting.

“I all of a sudden had all this time, so I just hunkered down and focused on the art,” he says. Many of his friends are also shifting out of poorly paid or unfulfilling jobs. “People have felt their power now,” he says. “They won’t be embarrassed to advocate for themselves or tell the people: ‘No. I’m not going to do that. That’s not fair or right.’”

Mann was one of the many who used money he’d saved over the years to facilitate his reinvention. The U.S. personal savings rate skyrocketed during the pandemic thanks to enhanced unemployment benefits and stimulus checks.

Global Burnout

In Japan the conversations taking place in China and the U.S. about how to balance work and other pursuits sound familiar. In the 1990s the media painted an unflattering portrait of youthful “freeters” who rejected Japan’s demanding office culture, with its rigid hierarchies and 15-hour workdays, in favour of working odd jobs.

Young people said their lifestyle had been forced on them by a stagnant economy and a deregulation of the labour market that resulted in fewer salaried positions and more job insecurity. By 2010 freeters had acquired a less disparaging label as part of a bigger phenomenon—the “satori generation”—referring to a state of enlightenment in Japanese Buddhism achieved by giving up material desires.

Kairu Taira, 22, works for a consumer-goods company in Kobe and runs a satori generation blog. While not a freeter, he considers himself a minimalist, with a limited wardrobe that includes only four T-shirts and four long-sleeved shirts. He says the satori generation gets blamed for “not helping the economy enough,” because they spend so little. “But I think each of us is more able to see what’s really important in life,” he says. “In that sense, I like the term.”

The growing acceptance of the satori generation may reflect that lower growth rates and less stable employment are here to stay. The number of newborns in the country, already in decline for decades, fell to a record low in 2020. “With freeters there was a lot more shame, fear, and anger being expressed,” says Robin O’Day, a professor at the University of North Georgia who studies Japanese youth culture. “Now it seems that there’s nothing that can be done.”

Young people’s prospects took a similar hit from Taiwan’s economic slowdown in the early 2000s. At the time, A-Gui was a video editor in Taipei. Burned out by a job that once had him spend three days straight in the office finishing a project, he quit in 2006 and became a freelancer. “As long as I had enough to live, it was enough,” he says. “There were times when my money almost ran out, but something would always come along.” Eventually, A-Gui got married, and in 2016 he went back to work full time. But he sees frustrated younger people today following the same path. “No matter how hard you work, you won’t be able to buy a house,” he says. “The threshold is always rising, so it’s becoming more unobtainable. What’s the point?”

Even in more welfare-minded Europe, where employment retention programs prevented pandemic layoffs on the scale seen in the U.S., many people are rethinking their careers. Across the euro area about 2 million fewer people are in employment than before the coronavirus struck. Milena Kula, 26, says she was “relieved” when her contract at a Berlin nonprofit organisation focused on politics expired in April 2020. “I hated working a desk job,” she says. “The best part of my day was my 45-minute cycle to work.” She now lives in the Brandenburg countryside, where she plans to set up a communal space for people who, like her, want to live in a more environmentally sustainable way. The idea is not to drop out of society, but to help create one they believe in, she says. “I needed a different approach to how I was doing things, and to be free from manipulation to create the life I want.”

Working, Reworked

Often what’s portrayed as a change in young people’s attitudes is simply a manifestation of longer-term trends, says Bobby Duffy, director of the Policy Institute at King’s College London, whose book *The Generation Myth* challenges stereotypes around generational shifts.

Many people in their 20s and 30s seek different things from work than their older peers, such as prioritizing learning new skills over stability, Duffy says, but older cohorts held broadly similar views when they were young.

The vast number of people quitting their jobs in the U.S. and Europe is a sign of a structural, psychological shift, according to Qualtrics’s Granger. He says people are being driven to “work on something that’s going to be meaningful, have a higher purpose. We’ve seen a lot of evidence for that.”

In China the shift may prove to be even more fundamental. The Communist Party is trying to defuse the lie flat phenomenon by promising continued upward mobility, with plans to double the size of the middle-income segment of the population by 2035. But slowing economic growth is leading the party to focus more on how those gains are distributed. Recent policies aimed at improving conditions for gig workers and moderating housing and education costs aim to support a better quality of life.

If these preoccupations about the value of work persist, they may—in time—influence the course of economies. “Lying flat and the Great Resignation are raising difficult questions, without making specific demands for change. This is good momentum,” says Xiang of the Max Planck Institute. “This can be energy to push for new growth paradigms.”

For discussion/reflection:

- Explain why the 'Great Resignation and 'Lie Flat' movement' (lines 33-34) arose out of a 'relentless pursuit of wealth' (lines 34-35).
- The President of China, Xi Jinping, was quoted as telling the nation to 'avoid involution and lying flat' (line 40) and to 'open channels for upward mobility' (line 41). What might have given rise to these remarks? Cite examples to support your response.
- Based on lines 99 to 128, what are the different reasons why different groups of Americans are carrying out the Great Resignation?
- How might perspectives concerning work – specifically the value of work and what kind of work is deemed meaningful – held by different groups of Singaporeans differ from each other?
- Explain why the label "freeters", given to young Japanese workers who prefer to have 'odd jobs' (line 136) is 'unflattering' (line 134).
- What similarities and differences do you see in the case studies offered in China and America? What are some reasons for such differences, based on differing cultural values and beliefs, and the nature of the social compact between the government and the people?
- What are some new insights gained in your understanding of inequality here?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. How far should firms be allowed to limit their workers' rights when profits are at stake? (Cambridge 2014)
2. Why should we be concerned with current affairs when most of them will soon be forgotten? (Cambridge 2013)
3. 'Workers today have never had it better.' Is this an accurate view? (RI Y6 Prelims 2022)
4. 'We have paid too high a price for globalisation.' Do you agree? (RI Y6 CT 2021)
5. With reference to the developments in the world today, to what extent would you agree that the future holds much promise for young people? (RI Y6 CT1 2013)
6. Consider the importance of global trends in your society. (RI Y5 CT 2012)

SECTION D: WORLD POVERTY AND INEQUALITY

Reading 16: Foreign Aid in Decline as Realism Shapes Global Assistance

EU 3 & 5

Teresa Nogueira Pinto | Geopolitical Intelligence Services | 9 May 2025

This reading will help you understand:

- Aid as a foreign policy tool and how the current shift is driven by nations re-evaluating their obligations to other countries and prioritising national interests
- How this shift has significant effects on aid-receiving countries

United States President Donald Trump's February executive order instructing all department and agency directors to pause new obligations and disbursements of development assistance funds sent shockwaves across the international aid system. The move reflects a belief that the U.S. foreign aid sector, and the enormous bureaucracy that sustains it, are detached from, and in many cases opposed to, American interests.

Under the new directive, development assistance programs must meet two cumulative criteria to be eligible for funding: programmatic efficiency and consistency with U.S. foreign policy. In March, Secretary of State Marco Rubio announced the cancellation of 5,200 foreign aid contracts at the U.S.

10 Agency for International Development (USAID), and that the remaining 1,000 contracts would be administered by the Department of State, which absorbed USAID as part of this major restructuring.

The American policy shift was mirrored across the Atlantic by the United Kingdom. Shortly after Washington announced cuts to aid, London followed suit and said it would slash foreign funding to the UK's lowest levels since the 1990s. The British government says the reduction will allow for an increase in defense spending.

An Outdated Foreign Policy Tool

15 Foreign aid, the transfer of money, goods or services from one nation to another, is facing resistance. While donors have traditionally used the threat or temporary suspension of aid as a punitive tool, what we are now witnessing is a substantial and potentially definitive withdrawal of aid flows by the central actors in the global aid system.

20 The Trump administration's radical shift in U.S. aid policy mirrors other sweeping changes, such as the American withdrawal from multilateral institutions, in one key aspect: These developments are not root causes but rather symptoms or consequences of deeper transformations in the international system. Just as President Trump's decision to exit some multilateral forums is a consequence of a previous and deeper crisis of multilateralism, the collapse of the aid system as we knew it had been in the making for some time.

25 The rationale behind this move is rooted in a realist approach to international relations. This perspective holds that states act primarily to maximize their power within the international system, guided by strategies that serve their national interests. In this context, foreign aid may be considered as one of many tools that states can deploy in pursuit of their foreign policy objectives.

30 In less dramatic ways, in addition to the UK, key donors like Germany, France and Norway have also been reducing aid as they adapt to new demands. Chief among current priorities is addressing the rising number of immigrants and refugees and the pressure to increase defense budgets.

In 2024, the European Union was already planning a 2.2 billion euro aid cut, to be implemented until 2027. In fact, since 2016, the EU has strategically used development assistance to foster cooperation with countries of origin and transit along key migration routes. Turkey, which remains one of the
35 largest recipients of EU aid, exemplifies this approach.

Views on Handouts Versus Development

In the face of recent events, some observers have claimed that the removal of aid would have devastating consequences and that, despite its limitations, aid effectively contributes to development and growth in the long term. Others, however, claim that not only is aid ineffective, but it may actually be counterproductive to the extent that it fuels corruption, prevents the development of competitive
40 industries and reduces accountability, leading to the perpetuation of authoritarian regimes.

In practice, foreign aid has been losing both its appeal and volume in recent years. After reaching a peak in 1990, aid flows to Africa have decreased. In 2008-2009, the volume of remittances surpassed international aid, becoming the primary source of international funding for the region.

45 The decline in aid stems from a combination of factors, including a lack of success stories, the crisis of multilateralism and a shifting geopolitical landscape. The failure of high-profile initiatives like the Millennium Villages Project – an ambitious effort launched in 2005 to eradicate extreme poverty through health, education, agriculture, infrastructure and business development – further contributed to the momentum to slash global aid outlays.

Impact of Aid Cuts Varies But is Centred in Africa

From a global perspective, almost a quarter of total aid assistance was, until now, provided by the U.S.
50 In the 2023 fiscal year, foreign assistance provided by the U.S. Congress totaled \$66.1 billion. In Africa,

the U.S. accounted for 26 per cent of aid flows, including through the financing of flagship initiatives launched by different administrations such as the President's Emergency Plan for AIDS Relief (PEPFAR), Feed the Future, Power Africa and Prosper Africa.

55 The main component of U.S. aid to Africa has been assistance in the health sector, including the funding of tuberculosis and malaria control programs, AIDS prevention and treatment (in 2023 alone, the U.S. channeled \$10.6 billion to combat HIV/AIDS), health emergency responses (in the case of Ebola outbreaks, for example) and family planning. The latter has been a contentious issue since the first Trump Administration, which banned funding to organisations providing abortions overseas. Along with the health sector, significant development aid was also channeled to education and
60 agricultural programs throughout the continent.

However, aid cuts will not affect all countries in the same way. Low- and lower-middle-income countries, in particular those where a large portion of aid was provided by the U.S. or where aid is mostly in the form of emergency or humanitarian assistance, are more exposed to the negative effects of this decision.

65 According to the Center for Global Development, eight of the world's 26 poorest countries have received more than a fifth of their aid assistance from USAID. Excluding Afghanistan, the remaining seven countries are in Africa: South Sudan, Somalia, Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC), Liberia, Sudan, Uganda and Ethiopia. In some cases, like Somalia, the Central African Republic and South Sudan, aid represents more than one-fifth of the gross national income.

70 Other countries, although less dependent on aid, are also feeling the effects of the U.S. decision. In Nigeria, the U.S. provided \$600 million for health assistance programs in 2023, representing 21 percent of the overall health budget. In Zimbabwe, the government – led by the Zimbabwe African National Union-Patriotic Front, which has been ruling since independence in 1980 – has relied on U.S. aid to fund a significant part of the health system, through HIV response programs and infrastructure
75 development.

Gatekeepers and Partners

The aid system is now at a critical juncture, mirroring dynamics shaping the international trade framework, and the global order itself. It seems quite certain that the days of an aid system anchored in the liberal internationalism of the post-Cold War period are over. Just like the World Trade Organization faces growing irrelevance, the institutions and frameworks of the international aid
80 system seem unfit to navigate the challenges posed by the emergence of a post-liberal international order.

In addition to those countries more dependent on aid in general and U.S. support in particular, the gatekeepers of the international aid system, including international nongovernmental organizations, United Nations agencies and other implementing partners, are also facing the consequences of these
85 shifts.

It is important to note that, according to official data, between 2013 and 2022, while 67 per cent of nonmilitary foreign aid approved by the U.S. Congress was delivered through project-based assistance, 19 per cent was in the form of core contributions – those going to public international organizations such as the World Bank, United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees or the Green Climate Fund. UN agencies such as the World Health Organization, which the U.S. has again withdrawn from, or the United Nations Population Fund, will be forced to adapt to new circumstances, and rethink their
90 ambitious agendas.

Aid for Trade?

As enthusiasm for aid assistance has declined over recent years, the idea that trade not aid is the pathway to prosperity has gained traction (as evidenced, for example, by the Prosper Africa Initiative).
95 However, Africa's share of international trade has remained low over the past decade, at around 3 per

cent of global exports and imports. From a continental perspective, wide disparities remain, with countries in North Africa, Southern Africa and Angola accounting for more than 50 percent of Africa's total trade.

100 While intra-African trade has increased, regional market integration is still low. Despite the momentum generated by the launch of the African Continental Free Trade Area, major obstacles persist, including low levels of industrialization, lack of diversification, infrastructure gaps and informal barriers.

105 African countries now face the dual challenge of adapting to what appears to be the collapse of an already waning global aid system, alongside growing uncertainty regarding the future of free trade amid a rising tide of protectionism. The fate of initiatives like the African Growth and Opportunity Act (AGOA), which for over two decades granted duty-free access to U.S. markets for a range of African exports, remains unclear. While AGOA was already on life support, it offered more favorable conditions for African economies engaged in trade with the U.S. than the current environment.

110 As President Trump completed the first 100 days of his second administration, one thing became clear: Tariffs are again a key instrument of economic and foreign policy as the golden decades of free trade seem to be over, giving way to a period of protectionism. While countries like China and Canada, with which the U.S. has a trade deficit, are more exposed, African countries are also being impacted.

115 Now, regional economic heavyweights such as South Africa and Nigeria, both dubbed by Mr. Trump as among the "worst offenders" due to his belief that they use unfair trade practices, are expected to be hit particularly hard. Tariffs ranging from 11 to 104 percent now apply to imports from around 60 such trade partners. It is worth noting, however, that oil and gas remain exempt from these new tariffs.

Scenarios

The dismantling of the foreign aid system is another symptom of a changing world order. But as always happens in periods of structural change, new dynamics, actors and institutions are expected to emerge in the medium term. Considering this, two main scenarios present themselves.

More likely: Aids cuts to sharpen focus on business, investment climates

120 Under a first, more likely scenario, the aid system developed and consolidated in the post-Cold War period is definitively finished. Mirroring the transition from a period of hyper-globalization to one of competition and tension between blocs, the global aid system will be replaced by more localized strategies.

125 Donor countries will continue to reduce and reorient aid assistance, as the principles of international liberalism are replaced by realist approaches and geoeconomic imperatives. Under this scenario, aid will not necessarily disappear, but it will undergo a process of 'near-shoring¹⁰', as evidenced, for example, by Italy's Mattei Plan. Aid-dependent countries, especially those more isolated from international markets, are expected to struggle and face additional hardship in the short to medium term.

130 However, the effects of cuts may accelerate efforts to improve business environments to attract foreign investment, increase local entrepreneurship and unleash processes of economic transformation. As a result, African governments facing lower aid inflows will increasingly prioritize public-private partnerships as they shape their development agendas.

135 Another outcome of reduced dependence on traditional donors will likely be the emergence of more diverse and results-oriented approaches to development, tailored to the specificities of local contexts and less constrained by donor-driven, one-size-fits-all agendas.

¹⁰ This is a specific form of offshoring, whereby business processes, services, or production are located in a nearby foreign country rather than a distant offshore location.

Less likely: Global Majority countries entirely replace Western aid

Under a second, less likely scenario, traditional donors would be replaced by other actors from the Global Majority, such as China, Turkey or Gulf countries. This outcome is less probable because these countries are already deeply engaged with Africa's top aid recipients, including Ethiopia, Kenya, Angola and DRC, through a mix of investments, loans, trade partnerships and security agreements. This involvement is expected to continue and potentially expand.

Beijing, in particular, is expected to step up its presence across the continent through the Forum on China-Africa Cooperation. But this does not mean a full retreat by the U.S. In fact, American investments in strategic sectors, like energy, infrastructure or defense are likely to increase in countries like Angola and the DRC, or Mozambique, where the U.S. Export-Import Bank recently approved a \$4.7 billion loan for a liquefied natural gas project. Alternative donors may, however, increase their leverage over aid-dependent countries with weaker economies and less strategic relevance.

For discussion/reflection:

- How does the “realist” (line 25) approach to foreign aid differ from the framework based on “liberal internationalism” (line 78) that dominated previous decades?
- According to the article, which specific regions or sectors are expected to be most negatively affected by the decline in Western foreign aid, and what are the potential consequences for those areas?
- The author identifies an emphasis on “trade not aid” (line 93) and “foreign investment” (line 131) as key shifts. What are the potential advantages and disadvantages of this market-driven approach for countries in need of aid?
- How ethically justifiable is it for a wealthy nation to prioritise its own domestic fiscal health over global humanitarian commitments?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. Is it right for a leader to place national interests above global responsibilities? (RI 2025 Y6 Prelim)
2. Is foreign aid ultimately more damaging than beneficial to the countries it aims to support? (RI 2025 Y6 Prelim)
3. ‘Only powerful nations have a significant voice in global affairs.’ Discuss. (RI 2024 Y6 Prelim)
4. ‘Foreign aid does not solve long-term problems.’ To what extent is this a fair viewpoint? (Cambridge 2018)
5. Discuss the claim that in the modern world, people should care more about international than national issues. (Cambridge 2013)

SECTION D: WORLD POVERTY AND INEQUALITY

Reading 17: The Case for Aid

EU 5

Jeffrey Sachs | *Foreign Policy* | 21 January 2014

This reading will help you to:

- Understand the compelling case for aid and why how it brings about benefits to developing countries.

I have long believed in foreign aid as one tool of economic development. This is not an easy position to maintain, especially in the United States, where public misunderstanding, politics, and ideology all tend to keep aid an object of contempt for many people. Yet the recent evidence shows that development aid, when properly designed and delivered, works, saving the lives of the poor and helping to promote economic growth. Indeed, based on this evidence, Bill and Melinda Gates released a powerful letter to the public today also underscoring the importance and efficacy of foreign aid.

As experience demonstrates, it is possible to use our reason, management know-how, technology, and learning by doing to design highly effective aid programs that save lives and promote development. This should be done in global collaboration with national and local communities, taking local circumstances into account. The evidence bears out this approach.

Of course, I do not believe that aid is the sole or main driver of economic development. I do not believe that aid is automatically effective. Nor should we condone bad governance in Africa -- or in Washington, for that matter. Aid is one development tool among several; it works best in conjunction with sound economic policies, transparency, good governance, and the effective deployment of new technologies.

Professor William Easterly of New York University has long been a vocal opponent of aid, and recently declared that the aid debate was "over," claiming victory for his theory that large-scale aid projects are doomed to fail. This blanket claim flies in the face of recent experience. Prof. Easterly has been proven wrong in both diagnosis and prescription.

During the past 13 years, the greatest breakthroughs in aid quantity and quality came from the field of public health (unlike other social sectors, such as education and sanitation, where aid increases were far less notable). As a result, the outcomes in public health in poor countries have also advanced markedly. Not only did aid quantities for public health improve; new public health institutions, such as the Global Fund to Fight AIDS, Tuberculosis, and Malaria and the Global Alliance for Vaccines and Immunisation, were created to promote the effective delivery of the increased aid.

The approach of increased aid that is well-targeted through innovative institutions has been enormously successful in improving public health in low-income countries. One could cite many examples ranging from the scale-up of vaccine coverage (largely through GAVI and UNICEF) to increased treatment coverage for HIV/AIDS and expanded tuberculosis control (through the Global Fund and the U.S. PEPFAR program), but I will focus specifically on malaria control, since Prof. Easterly was particularly pointed in his opposition to the mass scale-up of malaria control that has proved to be so successful. Fortunately, the global community did not heed Easterly's erroneous advice, and followed a path that the public health community strongly advocated.

At the turn of the new century, malaria was front and center of the global aid debate. Research by myself and others, and evidence garnered in the report of the World Health Organization

(WHO) Commission on Macroeconomics and Health that I had the honor to chair, showed that in addition to being a health catastrophe, malaria imposes a significant economic burden, particularly in sub-Saharan Africa. Luckily, though, the world was starting to take notice. In 2000, the U.N. Millennium Declaration, The African Summit on Malaria, and the G8 Declaration all addressed the burden of malaria and committed the world to action. The debate soon turned to the issue of policy: how could the malaria burden be reduced?

Here we must look at some key details in order to keep aid in careful perspective. Starting in the late 1990s, malariologists at WHO, in academia, and in various government agencies around the world, described how malaria control could be made highly effective. The malariologists emphasised the ability of insecticide-treated bed nets to reduce the transmission of the disease. They also emphasised the urgency of shifting to a new generation of first-line medicines, notably those using artemisinin (a powerful anti-malaria drug developed by Chinese scientists) in combination with other medicines, because the old-line medicines (mainly chloroquine) were losing efficacy to growing drug resistance. The combination of bed nets and effective medicines (known in the jargon as "vector control" and "case management" respectively), supported by rapid diagnosis of infections, makes for a powerful one-two punch in saving lives and reducing malaria transmission.

Indeed, epidemiological theory and practical experience strongly suggested that if bed net coverage could be raised to a sufficiently high rate (typically around three-quarters, depending on local conditions), the transmission of malaria would be sharply reduced even for those not directly protected by their own bed nets. The "spillover" of protection to the non-users is called a mass-action effect, similar to the way that high vaccine coverage protects even unvaccinated people because the disease stops spreading when fewer people are susceptible to infection. This mass-action phenomenon of course strongly argued for a malaria control strategy that would lead to a high level of bed net coverage.

There was one more detail of great policy significance: Not all bed nets are equal. The high-quality bed nets work not only mechanically (by covering the body) but also chemically, by a treatment with insecticide that repels or kills mosquitoes that land on the bed net. A bed net without insecticide treatment is far less effective than a treated net. Until the early 2000s, bed nets required frequent retreatment with insecticide (e.g. by bathing the nets in tubs filled with insecticide) in order to remain effective. Then, Sumitomo Chemical developed long-lasting insecticide-treated nets (LLINs) that were specially engineered to keep the insecticide intact even when the nets were repeatedly washed. The new nets could therefore remain effective for around five years or even more. Other companies, such as Vestergaard and BASF, also developed their own varieties of LLINs. This was a great breakthrough, but the new nets were more expensive to manufacture than the preceding generation of simpler nets.

All of these developments -- new nets, new medicines, improved diagnostics, and a surging epidemic -- were crucial to developing a successful malaria control policy after the year 2000. Taken together, they motivated the case for increased donor aid to support the mass free-distribution of LLINs and free access to the new generation of artemisinin-based medicines and rapid diagnostic tools. Without financial support, poor people could not afford either the LLINs or the new medicines. Attempts to sell the nets at a discount, known as social marketing, had very little take up, since many poor families simply lacked any cash income at all. The prospect of achieving "mass action" protection through social marketing was very small. Moreover, impoverished households would often scrape together the needed money only to buy the cheaper but ineffective nets, rather than the more expensive but more effective LLINs.

Governments of low-income African countries needed donor support for the scale-up effort since their own domestic tax revenues, even when amply allocated to public health, could not cover the costs of

a basic primary health system including scaled-up malaria control. The financial calculations, laid out by the Commission on Macroeconomics and Health, showed that an impoverished country with a GDP of around \$500 per capita, typical for a poor country in Africa, may be able to muster around \$15 per person per year out of domestic revenues for primary health (directing 15 percent of domestic revenues to health, as the Abuja target for health spending recommends), while the costs of a basic public health system (measured in 2014 dollars) would be around \$50-\$60 per person per year.

Prof. Easterly would have none of it. He took special and early aim at these recommendations in his 2006 book *The White Man's Burden*, claiming that free nets "are often diverted to the black market, become out of stock in health clinics, or wind up being used as fishing nets or wedding veils." After this specious claim, he then went on to write that "a study of a program to hand out free [malaria bed] nets in Zambia to people ... found that 70 percent of the recipients didn't use the nets." Yet this particular study, which was conducted by the American Red Cross and CORE, actually showed the program was a success, with high rates of net adoption. Prof. Easterly's claim misconstrued this and other evidence being developed by the ARC and others about the mass distribution of nets, which had found that the free distribution of malaria bed nets was achieving high coverage and adoption rates.

Prof. Easterly's arguments added to a highly visible narrative against the needed global action on malaria control. Yet despite this anti-aid narrative, a global turning point finally came in 2007-08. This turning point was helped by the early success of Kenya. Kenya's Minister of Health at the time, Charity Ngilu, led a government effort during 2006-7 to scale up mass bed net distribution based, in part, on the example of free LLIN distribution in the Sauri Millennium Village. Kenya's policies led to a sharp drop of malaria nationwide.

Next, WHO swung its powerful weight behind the mass free distributions of bed nets throughout sub-Saharan Africa. Soon after, U.N. Secretary-General Ban Ki-moon established the mass free distribution of bed nets as policy for all U.N. agencies, and called on the world's governments and NGOs to support the scale-up effort. Ban's leadership tipped the global scales decisively. Close to 300 million bed nets were freely distributed from 2008-2010, with the Global Fund to Fight AIDS, Tuberculosis and Malaria and the U.S. President's Malaria Initiative program paying for a substantial share of the scale-up.

The evidence is overwhelming that malaria declined precipitously as a result of these bold measures. WHO's latest report finds a stunning 51 percent drop in malaria deaths of African children under the age of five between the years 2000 and 2012. These results are historic. Roughly a half-million children, if not more, are being saved each year that otherwise would have succumbed to malaria. Even more success is possible, but only if development aid continues to back the effective control of malaria. The Global Fund is struggling to fill its request for \$5 billion per year of funding, essential to supplement the health budgets of poor countries. Prof. Easterly's continued denunciations of aid, and his declarations that large-scale aid has failed, are injurious to the public support needed for the replenishment.

Across the board, the post-2000 improvements in public health in sub-Saharan Africa have been dramatic, strongly supported by scaled-up aid. Up to 10 million HIV-infected individuals are now receiving life-saving, anti-retroviral medicines thanks at least in part to aid programs. Tuberculosis (TB) patients are being treated and cured, with a global TB mortality rate drop of 45 percent since 1990, and an estimated 22 million people alive due to TB care and control from 1995-2012, thanks to Global Fund support, which provides the lion's share of donor financing to fight TB. With increased donor support, antenatal health visits, institutional deliveries, and access to emergency obstetrical care are all on the increase, contributing to a decline in sub-Saharan Africa's maternal mortality rate (the annual number of female deaths per 100,000 live births) from 850 in 1990

to 740 in 2000 to 500 in 2010. Deaths of children under five worldwide have declined from 12.6 million a year in 1990 and 10.8 million in 2000 to 6.5 million in 2012.

130 These successes demonstrate a key lesson: that well-designed aid programs with sound operating principles, including clear goals, metrics, milestones, deliverables, and financing streams, can make an enormous difference, and that such programs should be devised and applied on a large scale in order to benefit as many people as possible. Such quality design needs to be based on the details of best practices, such as the combination of medicines, bed nets, and diagnostics used in cutting-edge, community-based malaria control. The economics profession needs to do a much better job working
135 with experts in other fields, such as public health, in order to design effective aid interventions that reflect the nitty-gritty of high-quality systems delivery. While Prof. Easterly begrudgingly admits that some health aid programs have worked, for him this contradiction seems to make no difference to his overarching claim that aid is doomed to fail, for reasons that are hard to explain. All the evidence and all the exceptions have not mattered to his rhetoric, or for that matter, to his harsh attacks on me
140 personally.

The aid successes of the past decade have saved millions of lives, a worthy use of money (which has totalled just a tiny fraction of rich world income) on its own. Yet aid has delivered more than lives saved and improved. Various kinds of aid, including public health outlays, debt cancellation under the IMF and World Bank's Heavily Indebted Poor Countries initiative (providing debt relief and cancellation
145 for the poorest countries), and other programmatic and budget support, have helped to put sub-Saharan Africa on a path of much higher economic growth and development. For the first time in decades, Africa's poverty rate has come down notably (from 58 percent in 1999 to 48.4 percent in 2010) and the region's economic growth is now around 5 percent per year, making it the region with the second fastest growth (following Asia).

150 Of course, aid didn't cause this success by itself, as there are many factors in play. But aid has helped. Research distinguishing the types and timing of aid has shown that development aid raises economic growth, though the effects will differ across countries and depend on the quality of aid. The malaria example is one of the clearest and most dramatic examples, but across the continent, aid has helped with improvements in education, agriculture, sanitation, infrastructure, and more.

155 In *The White Man's Burden*, Prof. Easterly declared, "You just have to do whatever you discover works with your modest resources to make a difference in the lives of poor people." Prof. Easterly's emphasis on "modest resources" mischaracterises our real global situation. We are living in a world of great wealth. We need not accept the fallacy perpetuated by the rich that global resources available are quite so "modest," when total aid to sub-Saharan Africa in 2012 amounted to roughly 0.1 percent of
160 the GDP of the donor countries (around \$45 billion per year). We can and should mobilise more support. Just fractions of 1 percent of GDP of the rich countries can make a profound difference to ending extreme poverty throughout the world. Of course, we should also certainly agree to focus on what works, and take effective programs to large scale. The positive evidence since 2000 shows that well-designed aid has made a tremendous impact.

165 The issue is not "yes" or "no" to aid. Aid is needed, and can be highly successful. The issue is how to deliver high-quality aid to the world's poorest and most vulnerable people.

For discussion/reflection:

- According to Sachs, what are the key factors to create “highly effective aid programs” (line 8)?
- What does Sachs mean when he writes that Prof. Easterly’s argument that aid can never succeed is “wrong in both diagnosis and prescription” (line 19)?
- In what way was aid crucial in enabling a “‘mass action’ protection’ (line 76) for Africa on the issue of malaria control?
- Why are aid’s benefits in terms of “education, agriculture, sanitation, infrastructure” (line 154) in Africa as significant as its impact in terms of “lives saved and improved” (lines 142-143)?
- Based on your understanding of the impact of aid on Africa, what kinds of aid would benefit poor countries? To start you off, consider some novel strategies adopted by the UN’s World Food Programme. In what ways are these strategies more promising in delivering aid?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. ‘Foreign aid does not solve long-term problems.’ To what extent is this a fair viewpoint? (Cambridge 2018)
2. In times of economic hardship, should a country still be expected to provide financial or material aid to others? (Cambridge 2014)
3. Is foreign aid ultimately more damaging than beneficial to the countries it aims to support? (RI Y6 Prelim 2025)
4. ‘The solution to global hunger is simply about providing more food.’ How far do you agree? (RI Y6 Timed Practice 2022)
5. ‘The problem of global food shortage can never be resolved.’ Do you agree? (RI Y6 Prelim 2013)
6. ‘Foreign intervention in a developing nation does more harm than good.’ Comment. (RI Y6 Prelim 2013)
7. ‘Make poverty history.’ Is this a realistic goal? (RI Y5 CT 2013)

SECTION E: GLOBALISATION AND THE MOVEMENT OF PEOPLE

Reading 18a: The Story of Migration Is More Positive Than We’ve Been Led to Believe **EU 1-3, 6**

Mo Ibrahim | TIME | 4 Apr 2019

This reading will help you to understand:

- The complexities involved in the issue of migration in the African continent as well as globally
- The often overlooked benefits of migration
- How migration has been mismanaged, and how to remediate the situation

The story of migration from Africa is typically told as a mass exodus from conflict or climate change. Images of vulnerable families crossing oceans on precarious boats and enduring winters in makeshift refugee camps have become ingrained parts of this narrative. There are human lives behind each image, and their experiences must never be dismissed. But this is not the full picture. The reality of this phenomenon and its root causes are very different. The story of African migrations needs to be reset.

This is not just an African concern: we must urgently push back against the corrosive global discourse that has perpetuated a distorted and harmful picture that betrays the reality. Because without a doubt, distorted narratives lead to distorted policies.

10 Despite popular belief, in almost 30 years, the scale of the global migrant population has increased only marginally, from 2.9% of the global population in 1990 to 3.4% in 2017. Migration patterns may have changed, but they have not significantly increased.

African migrants account for only 14% of the global migrant population: significantly less than migrants from Asia, which account for 41%, or Europe, which account for 24%. In fact, in 2017, the top
15 ten migration flows from Africa accounted for less than the single migration flow from Mexico to the U.S. Most African migrations *begin and end* on the continent.

Yet migration evokes strong emotions: it gets tangled up with suspicion of difference, hostility to anyone outside the “we” group. In an age of fake news and deliberate misinformation, migration is perhaps most susceptible to this distortion. In recent years, we’ve seen the issue exploited for political
20 ends across the globe.

We can do better than this. Migration is not an inherently negative phenomenon. For centuries, migration has fostered global trade links, shaped nations, fueled human endeavors and enabled skills and cultures to be shared across the globe. As world leaders recognised in the first-ever United Nations Global Compact on Migration in December 2018, migration, “is a source of prosperity,
25 innovation and sustainable development in our globalised world.”

Data shows that migrants support GDP growth in destination countries and are valuable, often indispensable parts of the workforce. Their economic contribution is considerable. Migrants’ contribution to GDP is estimated at 19% in Côte d’Ivoire, 13% in Rwanda and 9% in South Africa.

Migration can invigorate growth, plug labour market gaps and offer constructive opportunities for energetic and growing youth populations. Today, 60% of Africa’s population is under the age of 25 and
30 by 2100, Africa’s youth could be equivalent to twice Europe’s entire population. However, the match between education and the skills needed by employers is worse than in any other world region. Technological progress in recent years has created new jobs and business models, but opportunities for young African’s to master this innovation are still lacking across the continent.

35 This is a huge challenge we must take on. If we do not manage and foster mobility, we run the risk of losing our greatest asset: our young people.

Refusal to create legal migration routes, insufficient policies and weak mobility frameworks mean criminal networks often profit from migration more than governments. When migration is poorly managed, we all lose out. In 2016, illegal smuggling generated \$7 billion in income, equivalent to the
40 amount spent by the United States or European Union countries on global humanitarian aid in the same year. These are sobering numbers.

Humanity has always been on the move. Migrations are the fabric of our shared existence and have strengthened continents, countries and communities for millennia. Supporting migration, rather than thwarting it, is essential if we wish to meet the 2030 Sustainable Development Goals and end poverty.

45 The political challenge for Africa — and, indeed, the world — is to incentivise migration in the right way, be it geographical, educational or professional.

The African Union’s recent protocol on free movement, adopted a year ago, is a key step. This commitment to removing some of the barriers to migration will allow employers to recruit the skills they need, supporting economic development across Africa. But in Africa as elsewhere, the popular
50 political will needs to press ahead. Attitudes in Africa towards migration are more positive than anywhere else in the world. African citizens are ready.

55

Movement within and across continents is one of the great drivers of human history. Economic uplift is not a zero-sum game — in which one country's loss is another's gain. Progress cannot be achieved by trapping ambitious young people in jobless markets. The answer must be not to forbid migration but to better manage it — and to overturn the corrosive global discourse on migration in the process.

For discussion/reflection:

- Ibrahim asserts that “we must urgently push back against the corrosive global discourse that has perpetuated a distorted and harmful picture that betrays the reality. Because without a doubt, distorted narratives lead to distorted policies”. (lines 7-8)
 - Based on the source: How media, politicians, and civil society shapes public conversation on irregular migration, give examples of such “corrosive global discourse” on migration
 - What are some “distorted policies” on migration that you observe in the world today?
- In line 16, why does Ibrahim use italics for the verbs “*begin*” and “*end*”? What point is he trying to make here?
- Do you agree with Ibrahim that we should “incentivise migration” (line 45)? Why or why not?
- What justifications can you think of to support why the world has a global obligation¹¹ when it comes to the issue of migration?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. ‘In the global village we inhabit, there is no justification for national boundaries.’ How far do you agree? (Cambridge 2018)
2. Should a country still be concerned with national boundaries in today’s interconnected world? (RI Y6 CT2 2020)
3. Should refugees be viewed as a burden in modern society? (RI Y5 Promo 2018)
4. ‘Migration should be encouraged in today’s world.’ How true is this? (RI Y5 CT 2017)
5. To what extent should the movement of people across borders be restricted in the modern world? (RI Y6 Prelim 2016)
6. ‘Migration is a necessity, not an option.’ What do you think? (RI Y5 Promo 2015)

SECTION E: GLOBALISATION AND THE MOVEMENT OF PEOPLE

Reading 18b: Migrant crisis: How Europe went from Merkel's 'We can do it' to pulling up the drawbridge

EU 1-3, 6

Fergal Keane | BBC | 4 September 2025

This reading will help you understand:

- The causes for the shift towards a more intolerant attitude towards migrants in Europe
- The rise of social and political forces in different European states arises from this anti-migrant wave

¹¹ The concept of global or international obligations is based on the understanding that all countries face global challenges such as climate change, poverty, and health crises, and thus as a global community, also bears a shared responsibility to try to work together to address these challenges.

The day they appeared he could hardly believe his eyes. Small boat after small boat bearing in from the Turkish side. "I have so many memories that are coming back to me now," says Paris Laoumis, 50, a hotelier on the Greek island of Lesbos. "There were people from Syria, Afghanistan, many countries."

This was August 2015 and Europe was witnessing the greatest movement in population since the end of the Second World War. More than a million people would arrive in the EU over the next few months driven by violence in Syria, as well as Afghanistan and Iraq and elsewhere. I witnessed the arrivals on Lesbos and met Paris Laoumis as he was busy helping exhausted asylum seekers near his hotel. "I am proud of what we did back then," he tells me. Along with international volunteers he provided food and clothing to those arriving.

Today the beach is quiet. There are no asylum seekers. But Paris is worried. He believes another crisis is possible. With the number of arrivals rising over the summer months, his country's migration minister has warned of the risk of an "invasion", with thousands arriving from countries such as Sudan, Egypt, Bangladesh and Yemen. "Of course I worry. I can see the suffering of the people. They are not coming here but we see it on Crete (Greece's largest island) where people have come. So it is possible that with the wars more people will come here."

In 2015 I followed as the asylum seekers boarded ferries, trudged in the heat along railway lines, through cornfields, down country lanes and along highways, making their way up through the Balkans and onwards to Germany and Scandinavia. The numbers entering Germany jumped from 76,000 in July to 170,000 the following month. On the last day of August the Chancellor Angela Merkel declared 'wir schaffen das' - we can do it - interpreted by many as extending open arms to the asylum seekers.

"Germany is a strong country," she said. "The motive with which we approach these things must be: we have achieved so much – we can do it! We can do it, and where something stands in our way, it has to be overcome, it has to be worked on." But the high emotions of that summer, when crowds welcomed asylum seekers along the roads north, seem to belong to a very different time.

That optimistic proclamation soon became a political liability for Mrs Merkel. Political opponents and some European leaders felt the words acted as a magnet for asylum seekers to the EU. Within a fortnight the Chancellor was forced to impose controls on Germany's borders due to the influx of asylum seekers.

And a decade on, concerns over migration have become a major political issue in many European countries. The causes are complex and vary from country to country, but concerns around security, struggling economies and disillusionment with governing parties have all had a major role in shaping attitudes towards those who arrive who are fleeing war, hunger and economic desperation. It has fuelled the rise of far-right parties and seen centre and even left-wing parties scramble to impose controls on migration, fearing electoral defeat by populist right-wingers. Data from the Atlas Institute of International Affairs shows how support for far-right parties in Europe nearly doubled over the term of two electoral cycles to 27.6%.

Since 2015, when the UNHCR says over a million people entered Europe on asylum routes, there has been a dramatic drop in arrivals. But since 2016, the average number of people entering Europe has still been around 200,000 people a year. So far this year a total of 96,200 asylum seekers have been recorded arriving. So can tough new controls further bring down the numbers trying to come to Europe? Or does global conflict and economic desperation make their continuing flow inevitable, with ebbs and flows in the numbers?

Hungary's tough stance

In Hungary, the far-right government of Prime Minister Viktor Orban, has taken one of the toughest approaches to migration. Back in September 2015, I was present when Hungary's first fence was erected

45 along the border with Serbia and witnessed hundreds of people scrambling to cross into the EU before they could be shut out. In Budapest, this week I met the country's minister for the EU, János Bóka, who said Hungary's approach has been vindicated by the restrictive measures now being put forward in the UK - where the government plan to make it harder for refugees to bring family members to the UK - as well as countries like Ireland, Denmark and Sweden.

50 "We feel vindicated not only because of what's going on in other countries in Europe. This is of course also a sign that we took the right path 10 years ago, that now we see most of the countries are doing what we have been doing for the past 10 years." Hungary immediately returns people who arrive at the border without permission to enter. They can only apply for asylum in the Serbian capital Belgrade, or in Kyiv in war battered Ukraine. Human rights lawyer Timea Kovács says this effectively makes it impossible to enter
55 the EU via Hungary. "Basically there is no legal way to enter the Hungarian territory as a refugee," she asserts.

As a result, Hungary is being fined one million Euros per day for breaching its responsibilities to asylum seekers under EU law. EU minister Bóka says the country is not about to change its policy. "If it is the price that we pay for the protection of our borders and maintaining peace and stability in Hungary, this is a
60 price worth paying."

But even such restrictive measures haven't managed to entirely halt the entry of asylum seekers. Austrian police told the BBC that there were between 20 to 50 people detected every day trying to enter their country illegally from Hungary. This is just the figure for those detected.

On a trip to the border with Serbia I heard the frustration of one group of Hungarian guards. We left the
65 tar road and followed a patrol onto a dirt track into the forest. The trees closed over forming a natural tunnel. Bright sunlight gave way to shadows. The men in the vehicle ahead of us carried shotguns.

'Just one big circus'

Dressed in military camouflage Sándor Nagy and Eric Molner are citizen volunteers, paid by the state to patrol the Hungarian side of the border with Serbia. "I feel sad and angry, and most of all, worried about
70 what is coming," says Sandor. He believes Europe is failing to stop people from coming across its borders. "To be honest, what we experience here is basically just one big circus. What we see is that border defense here is mostly a show, a political performance."

We emerge into a clearing where a 12ft high border fence appears, topped with barbed wire, equipped with sensors and cameras to detect illegal crossings. "They simply cut through it, and groups rush in at
75 several points at once—this has been the same for years." The problem, he argues, is with organised crime, which is constantly one step ahead of the authorities. "This fence does not stop anyone in the long run ... It delays the flow, but cannot stop it."

A deluge of abuses

With the growth of criminal trafficking has come a deluge of human rights abuses, according to the United
80 Nations. People traffickers dump people in the Sahara desert; others crowd them onto unsafe boats. Some of those who get through find themselves being forced back into the desert by local security forces. More than 32,000 people have died trying to reach Europe in the past 10 years - including 1,300 dead or missing this year. According to the UN's International Organisation of Migration "much of this is happening in a situation of near complete impunity".

85 The summer of 2015 was not only a summer of welcome. It prompted immediate changes in the approaches of several European states. Not just with the erection of the fence in Hungary but, among several examples, the deployment of riot police in Croatia, and migrants being detained in Slovenia. By

March 2016 - six months after Mrs Merkel's statement - the EU had reached agreement with Turkey to keep migrants from crossing into Greece and Bulgaria.

90 Since then, the EU has done deals with countries including Morocco, Tunisia, Libya and Egypt to prevent their countries being used as launch points to Europe. Now, there are numerous well documented cases of asylum seekers being pushed back across EU borders by police and coast guards. Last January the European Court of Human Rights found Greece guilty of illegal and "systematic" pushbacks of asylum seekers to Turkey.

95 Gerasimos Tsourapas, a professor of international relations at the University of Birmingham, describes the policy of outsourcing the asylum issue as a dramatic change for Europe. "The idea that migration can be leveraged for money or aid or other concessions, which was fairly exceptional for Europe in 2016, has now become a pattern. "Migration diplomacy is contagious. Once the deal is struck then the logic spreads."

100 There is also a paradox here, he says. "We are restricting asylum, we're keeping borders closed, but we also need to find labour migrants to fill shortages and help our national economy."

A Changing Sweden

Persistent public concern has seen a rise in support for far-right parties across the EU, even in places like Sweden, which historically prided itself as a welcoming nation for those fleeing persecution. The far-right
105 Sweden Democrats won 20.5 percent of the vote in the 2022 general election - making them the country's second largest party. In return for supporting a minority coalition government they have seen much of their anti-migration platform shape government policy.

Family re-unification for migrants has been made more difficult, as have conditions for permanent residency, and asylum quotas have been substantially reduced.

110 For the final leg of my journey I went to the western Swedish city of Karlstad, a picture postcard place on the banks of the River Klarälven, the longest waterway in Scandinavia. Syrian refugee, Abdulmenem Alsatouf, 44, remembered the welcome he received here in 2015.

That has changed, he says. "At the beginning people treated us very well. But after a few years — and after the government changed — things shifted. They became more racist." He cites incidents of racist
115 abuse, including one neighbour leaving a toy pig outside this devoutly Muslim family's home.

I first met Abdulmenem and his family ten years ago as they were trying to reach Europe from Turkey. I remember their hope for a new life. Now his wife Nour says she would prefer to be in Syria. "They look at us as if we only came here to take their money or live off their aid. But that's not true. When I first arrived, I studied Swedish for two years, I learned the language, I finished school. Then I went to work — cleaning,
120 kitchens, childcare. I pay taxes here, just like anyone else. I'm part of this society."

Why has Swedish public opinion shifted to the right on migration? One of the more frequently cited reasons in local media and by politicians is crime, specifically the rise of organised crime, with young perpetrators used to commit extreme violence. Since 2013 the rate of gun crime in the country has more than doubled. People born abroad, and their children born in Sweden, are over-represented in crime
125 statistics. But Sweden's foreign ministry warns against a simplistic analysis of figures. It says low levels of education, unemployment, social segregation and refugee's war trauma are all causes - not the fact of being a migrant.

Outside the local cultural museum, where he and his apprentice were busy painting the walls, I met Daniel Hessarp, 46, who is among the 60% of Swedes that opinion polls record as being concerned about crime.

130 "We see the statistics of the crimes, who does it and such. So, there you have the answer. We didn't have this before in Sweden.

The apprentice, Theo Bergsten, 20, said he wasn't opposed to immigration because "you learn from, they learn from you...so it's really nice also." But he said the growth in crime was a "sad part" of the story.

135 Maria Moberg Stephenson, Senior Lecturer in Social Work, Karlstad University, says social media has allowed the far right's message to thrive and find new support among those who feel excluded from society. "Sweden Democrats are very open with [us] - they don't want any asylum seekers. They actually want people to leave Sweden. And the whole government is sort of setting the agenda for being a hostile country. It's more acceptable now to not be welcoming."

Graves marked 'Unknown'

140 Back on Lesbos, I went to visit a place I have come to know over many years of reporting migration issues there. About 30 minutes' drive from the Mytilene airport, in the middle of some olive groves, are the graves of asylum seekers who have died trying to reach here, or in the refugee camps set up after 2015. Numerous graves are simply marked 'Unknown', the last resting place of those who believed Europe would offer them a better life.

145 When I visited there were three fresh graves, and a fourth open waiting for a burial to take place. It is a sobering reminder that desperate people will keep trying to reach Europe, despite the enormous risks. So far this year the numbers of asylum seekers detected trying to reach Europe is down by 20 percent. The numbers may surge and fall, but the global crises that drive migration are not going to disappear. That is the fundamental challenge for politicians, whatever party is in power.

Reflection questions can be found after Reading 18c.

SECTION E: GLOBALISATION AND THE MOVEMENT OF PEOPLE

Reading 18c: Migration issue undergoes major transformation in 2025

EU 1-3, 5

Dr. Majid Rafizadeh | Arab News | 18 December 2025

This reading will:

- Provide a brief of key issues affecting migration patterns across the world
- Examine the phenomenon of long term non-episodic causes for the migration issues affecting the world

The year 2025 has witnessed a significant shift in the way migration is viewed and politicized across the world. The convergence of several factors, such as large-scale armed conflicts, accelerating climate impacts and economic pressures, has made migration one of the key issues on the global agenda.

In the past, migration was mostly analyzed from a humanitarian perspective. But in 2025, migration debates heavily entered geopolitics, the racial and religious demographic and even the US' national security strategy. So, migration is no longer just an episodic crisis that needs to be managed for a short time; instead, it will impact global governance and shape the political and economic landscape well into 2026 and beyond.

Armed conflict played a significant role in migration in 2025. The wars in Gaza, Sudan, Yemen and Ukraine collectively displaced tens of millions of people, destabilized regional markets and amplified the strategic calculations of neighboring states. Prolonged bombardment, infrastructure collapse and restrictions on humanitarian access created some of the most severe internal displacement crises of the decade, forcing families to move repeatedly in search of safety, temporary shelter or caloric survival.

Sudan is experiencing the fastest-growing displacement crisis in the world, with mass violence and famine conditions forcing populations out of their homes. Yemen's protracted conflict has eroded essential services. Meanwhile, Ukraine continues to sit at the center of Europe's largest displacement crisis since the Second World War, with millions of refugees dispersed across the continent and millions more displaced internally. These conflicts have together reshaped the humanitarian, economic and political systems on a global scale. It will impact global governance and shape the political and economic landscape well into 2026 and beyond

The second issue that was a major driver of migration in 2025 was climate change. Across South Asia, sub-Saharan Africa and parts of Latin America, climate-linked floods, rising temperatures and unpredictable rainfall patterns uprooted communities that were already vulnerable to insecurity and poverty. What has made this year distinct from preceding years is not only the magnitude of climate-related displacement but the frequency of repeated internal movements.

In many cases, people were not simply fleeing from one point to another, they were moving repeatedly within short time frames. This cyclical movement introduced a new challenge to humanitarian systems, which were designed to deal with discrete emergencies rather than recurring climate shocks. It also created a new challenge to legal systems, which are not adequately equipped to protect people who have been displaced by environmental issues rather than conflicts.

This is partially why the international community this year confronted severe funding shortfalls that limited their capacity to respond effectively. As humanitarian budgets shrank, essential services such as food assistance, shelter provision, medical care and sanitation support have had to be reduced. This increases the likelihood of secondary displacement and deepens the protracted nature of crises. Instead of being proactive, humanitarian organizations are now mostly in a reactive position, unable to keep pace with global displacement.

This year has also witnessed sweeping policy transformations in Europe that have redefined the meaning of migration governance. A series of national and regional measures have reshaped border regimes, asylum procedures and return policies. Several European states have tightened asylum rules, expanded the list of designated "safe countries of origin," accelerated border procedures and adopted new frameworks intended to increase deportations and discourage irregular arrivals.

Nevertheless, at the same time, many of these same countries introduced reforms to attract skilled labor and regularize long-term residents in order to address domestic labor shortages in aging economies. This dual strategy seems to prioritize economic and security issues rather than humanitarian obligations. Humanitarian organizations are now mostly in a reactive position, unable to keep pace with global displacement.

The shifting policy environment in Europe also appears to frame migration not as a social or humanitarian issue but as a security concern intertwined with border protection, counterterrorism and regional stability. In addition, migration control has become a bargaining tool in domestic politics and international relations.

From an economic perspective, migration in 2025 produced complex effects. In many host countries, refugees and labor migrants contributed to key sectors experiencing workforce shortages, such as healthcare, eldercare, agriculture and logistics. Yet, at the same time, rapid and large-scale arrivals strained some public services, fueled political tensions and strengthened far-right narratives around identity and security.

Demographically, this year has also reaffirmed the significance of migration for countries facing aging populations, declining fertility and shrinking workforces. Looking to the future, the transformation and structural forces that defined 2025 when it comes to global migration are unlikely to change. The issue of migration will continue to influence diplomatic relationships, national security strategies, labor market planning and demographic futures. This is why countries that develop coherent, effective and forward-looking policies that respect rights will be better positioned to navigate the next year and even the coming decade.

This year should be considered a major one when it comes to global migration, as it has revealed that this issue is not peripheral but that it shapes economic systems, political identities and international relations. As we enter 2026, policymakers, scholars and global institutions must recognize that the era of viewing migration as a temporary emergency has passed. Migration is now a major and structural driver of global change amid a rapidly shifting international landscape.

For discussion/reflection:

Article 18b considers the internal issues that raised the anti-migrant sentiments in 3 major European states while 18c examines major global shifts of causes for migration:

- What principles should guide how societies manage immigration, and how should these be balanced in practice?
- What trade-offs are important for your society to consider when limiting the flow of migrants to your country?
- Singapore uses a slew of foreigner worker regulations primarily restricting the type and duration of employment for these migrant workers. Consider the applicability of such a range of policies in bigger and more complex societies with an entrenched population migrant population

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. 'No country should sacrifice its economic development in favour of preserving the environment.' Discuss. (Cambridge 2025)
2. 'Is foreign aid ultimately more damaging than beneficial to the countries it aims to support?' (RI 2025 Prelim)
3. 'In the global village we inhabit, there is no justification for national boundaries.' How far do you agree? (Cambridge 2018)
4. Is it right for a leader to place national interests above global responsibilities? (RI2025 Y6 Prelim)
5. Is conflict inevitable in today's volatile world? (RI Y6 Prelims 2022)
6. 'We have paid too high a price for globalisation.' Do you agree? (RI Y6 CT 2021)
7. Should a country still be concerned with national boundaries in today's interconnected world? (RI Y6 CT2 2020)

Supplementary video references:

- a.  **Why does SWEDEN NO LONGER WANT IMMIGRANTS? VisualPolitik:** This is a specific documentary examining the Swedish immigrant crisis and its future implications for Sweden in particular and Europe in general.
- b.  **Why does FRANCE NO LONGER WANT IMMIGRANTS? VisualPolitik:** This documentary examining France's current shift of policy on immigration and its future implication for France in particular and Europe in general.

SECTION E: GLOBALISATION AND THE MOVEMENT OF PEOPLE

Reading 19: The Other Pandemic: Human Trafficking

EU 1-3, 5

Mark Oprea | Ozy | 13 June 2021

This reading will help you to:

- Gain a broad understanding of how the global pandemic has affected other societies already dealing with hidden social problems
- Understand the contexts and limitations in addressing this global issue and how human trafficking has a wider impact on vulnerable communities around the world

After a year of COVID-19-fueled lockdowns, one might have expected cases of human trafficking — defined as enslavement to sex or labour via force or coercion — to plummet. After all, we've all been traveling and interacting less. But, surprisingly, COVID-19 created an environment of greater risk for increased trafficking. With government funds prioritised elsewhere, many victims of slavery in the U.S. and globally have gone under the radar. Today's Daily Dose shines a light on this hidden pandemic.

Viral Strain of Slavery

A 15-year-old Congolese girl trafficked after fleeing a forced marriage. Children exploited in a plastics factory in Sudan. Seventeen Malawians rescued from a Chinese factory in South Africa, where they were forced to work inhumane hours, starved and physically abused. These are just some of the heartbreaking stories to emerge from Interpol raids earlier this year in a massive operation nicknamed Weka, Swahili for "stop." The effort freed nearly 500 people and saw 151 arrests on charges of human trafficking and people smuggling — proof that human trafficking has been flourishing despite COVID-19. "Operation Weka once again demonstrated how closely linked migrant smuggling and human trafficking are, particularly in a global health crisis when the most vulnerable are desperate to escape hardship, and the criminal networks are just keen to turn a profit," the agency said.

Progress Reversed

"Global suffering has vastly increased vulnerabilities to trafficking," the U.N. warned in its recent Global Report on Trafficking in Persons. The body says that despite lockdowns and travel restrictions, there have been international surges in places, and while convictions have tripled since 2003, the report says: "We cannot allow the pandemic recession to reverse this progress, or put more women, men and children in danger of being trafficked." Yet human trafficking is happening all the time, sometimes even in the most unlikely of places.

Surely Not Here

Findlay, Ohio, is about as far from the brothels of Bangladesh as you can get. Residents of this manufacturing hub once known as "Flag City, USA" couldn't believe it when local Catholic priest Michael Zacharias was charged with sex trafficking last year. It was "a reminder that trafficking can happen anywhere," Teresa Merriweather, a licensed trafficking awareness coordinator based in the

25 Buckeye State, tells OZY. It is not a foreign problem, she stresses, but one “in and around the interstates, truck stops and hair salons of our Midwestern states.” In January, Ohio expanded the state’s Human Trafficking Task Force, following a nationwide trend that’s seen similar measures taken in Colorado and Virginia, and some progress made in other Midwestern states such as Iowa and Minnesota.

Online Abuse Rises

30 But law enforcement needs to go further than policing truck stops, because like everything else during the pandemic, abuse has moved increasingly online. Reports made to the National Center for Missing & Exploited Children reached 4.2 million in April 2020, up from 2 million the previous month. Several factors account for the surge, one being that children are spending more time online at home and are therefore more at risk of being “groomed.” “We’ve seen child traffickers who have started to evolve their business model,” said John Shehan, the organisation’s vice president. “With COVID, the customers aren’t necessarily trying to do face-to-face interactions as much.”

Facts vs. Myths: Why Now?

40 Total isolation during the pandemic has made more people vulnerable to trafficking. Polaris Project, a U.S.-based anti-trafficking institute, found that roughly 3 out of 5 victims are recruited by an “intimate partner” or family member — which is obviously still possible during a lockdown. Joblessness, desperate financial straits and potential eviction create the perfect storm. “When we talk about trafficking in times of crisis, usually we’re thinking about a conflict situation or a natural disaster,” Samantha McCormack, a trafficking legal specialist, told Foreign Policy. But experts were not prepared for a pandemic.

Long Trek

45 Thousands of Central Americans, including Salvadorans, were walking toward the U.S.-Mexico border in March, fleeing violence, including sex trafficking. They hoped to start a new life in the U.S., buoyed by the promise of a new president in the White House. Back in El Salvador, lawmakers finally moved to act on trafficking — increasing law enforcement efforts and prosecuting more cases than in the previous year. The Northern Triangle of Guatemala, Honduras and El Salvador is one of the worst regions in Central America for trafficking, where experts say COVID-19 is amplifying existing holes in laws designed to combat it. President Joe Biden’s administration just launched a new task force to combat human trafficking from the region.

Fighting Falsehoods

55 Republicans and former President Donald Trump constantly warned that such “caravans” from Latin America were a threat to the U.S. and needed to be stopped. But oddly enough, fighting human trafficking has become somewhat of a cause celebre¹² among those on the right, with Fox News pundits regularly raising the alarm about its dangers. Followers of the baseless QAnon conspiracy theory are also obsessing over the topic. QAnon claims that elite Democrats are trafficking children, and sometimes recruit new followers through the misleading hashtag #SaveTheChildren. Remember Pizzagate? Experts fear such fake news detracts from how trafficking really happens.

The Biggest Case

60 While QAnon folks spuriously believe the Dems are behind the trafficking of minors, one of the biggest human trafficking cases in recent times involved not a street pimp or Russian gang but a member of the elite: wealthy financier Jeffrey Epstein. Even a British royal, Prince Andrew, has had his name tarnished due to his friendship with Epstein, who committed suicide while awaiting trial in 2019.

¹² A cause celebre is an issue that attracts a lot of attention and is supported by a lot of people (Oxford Dictionary)

Epstein's associate Ghislaine Maxwell is also facing charges — she has pleaded not guilty — that she procured teenage girls for Epstein and his friends to sexually abuse.

New Tactics Against Trafficking: Salon Survival School

65 A tattoo of a man's name across a woman's chest, a makeover in a small-town salon, an overly nervous patient at a doctor's office. There are many ways to tell if someone is in trouble. (Before COVID-19, Super Bowl weekend was a big alert weekend for trafficking, with airlines giving tips to staff on how to identify passengers who were traveling with potential victims.) Since 2012, Ohio has made it a requirement that cosmetologists undergo anti-trafficking training, which recently became law in Texas
70 as well. Merriweather, the Ohio-based trafficking awareness trainer, has worked with more than 70 salons and 150 cosmetologists, as well as with real estate agents, nurses, Subway restaurant employees and others. She teaches her students how to spot signs of possible victims by having them act out trafficking scenarios.

Tattoo Tells

75 Dozens of grassroots organisations across the U.S. are getting around COVID-era financial deficits by funding programs independently. In Stevens Point, Wisconsin, trafficking survivor Ally Burke runs Tattoos for Triumph, an ink-themed non-profit that raises cash and awareness while dishing out hundreds of discounted tats. Sometimes, traffickers brand their victims with tattoos to identify them as the property of a pimp or a gang, and Burke provides free cover-ups to victims who want to get rid of them. "Anyone can look for the signs of trafficking or someone who might be a victim," she told
80 OZY. "If you know what to look for, it just might save a life."

Financial Trap

The horrors of human trafficking are intimately tied to poverty. Nowhere is that more evident than in India, where young children in some regions are forced to work at factories for just 70 cents an hour. Founded in the East Khasi Hills of Meghalaya in the '90s, the Impulse NGO Network works with more than 160 humanitarian organisations around the world to fight trafficking in the world's largest
85 democracy. It is led by former lawyer Hasina Kharbhih and incorporates a 12-step model to reintegrate everyone from enslaved maids to tea stall workers back into society.

What's Working and What's Not?

Last year, the U.S. National Human Trafficking Hotline reported that contact from victims shot up nearly 20% between 2018 and 2019. More calls, texts and emails were received than ever before — a trend Polaris noted was continuing even at the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic. But one key finding
90 in the 2020 report was that texting was the most prominent form of communication received by the hotline. So why are anti-trafficking apps failing globally? In February, Wired reported on an authority-alert app called Be My Protector, created by Malaysian Kelvin Lim. Though Lim's endeavor was noble, it failed to help victims as intended. An analysis of his app and hundreds of similar initiatives found that the main problem was that victims were unaware of their existence, and that the majority of the
95 tools were only available in English.

No Room of One's Own

"I spent 37 years of my life a homeless drug addict, a victim of human trafficking on the streets . . . I truly knew it was my destiny to die out there," says sex-trafficking survivor Barb Davis. Homelessness is a common cause, and result, of trafficking, and is a problem being tackled by legal housing advocates. But the COVID-19 recession has caused shelters across the U.S. to shut down. Los Angeles-based NGO
100 the Coalition to Abolish Slavery and Trafficking said it has seen a considerable uptick in homeless trafficking victims requesting assistance since the start of the pandemic.

Stigma Without Borders

105 When “Trishna” was rescued from a trafficking network outside of West Bengal state in India and returned to live with her family, it was not the homecoming she might have hoped for. The police harassed her, townsfolk urged her to commit suicide, her classmates called her “dirty” and her family was ostracised. The stigma faced by survivors like Trishna is a global problem. “Families are not willing to take back trafficked victims. So there are a lot more cases of re-trafficking,” Ajailiu Niumai, a professor of sociology at the University of Hyderabad, told OZY.

Diversity Is Key

110 As the world reopens, so too will the offices of therapists, either in halfway homes or at inner-city nonprofits like SAFE in Maryland or Impulse. Experts say it’s time to ramp up the effectiveness of post-trafficking therapy — namely “by hiring more therapists who look like the victims,” Merriweather says. In major urban centers, many victims are Black, Hispanic or LGBTQ youth. “We’re more at risk, more vulnerable,” Merriweather, who is African American, told OZY. “When it comes down to rescuing a victim, I don’t care what colour you are. Yet, I want to make sure you don’t end up back because of the wrong care.”

For discussion/reflection:

- In a time when ‘lockdowns and travel restrictions’ (line 16) are the norm, why does the global problem of human trafficking persist during Covid-19?
- What was Merriweather’s intention in listing ‘interstates, truck stops and hair salons’ (line 26) as examples of places where human trafficking might be taking place?
- What are possible reasons why human trafficking has become a ‘cause celebre’ (line 54) for the political right in America? Is this a positive or negative phenomenon? Justify your response.
- Explain why the ‘horrors of human trafficking are intimately tied to poverty’. (line 81)
- According to Oprea, what is the main limitation of ‘anti-trafficking apps’ (line 91) to address human trafficking as a global issue?
- Apart from triggering the ‘COVID-19 recession [that] has caused shelters ... to shut down’ (line 99), in what other ways might the ongoing pandemic exacerbate the problem of human trafficking?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. Discuss the claim that in the modern world people should care more about international than national issues. (Cambridge 2013)
2. ‘Disease is the greatest threat facing mankind today.’ To what extent do you agree with this statement? (RI Y6 Prelim 2015)
3. ‘Human trafficking can never be abolished’ Discuss. (RI Y6 CT1 2014)
4. With reference to the developments in the world today, to what extent would you agree that the future holds much promise for young people? (RI Y6 CT1 2013)

SECTION F: WAR AND THE CHANGING FACE OF CONFLICT

Where will the next war occur? Who will fight? Why and how will it be fought? The following readings are meant for you to examine these questions from multiple perspectives, keeping in mind the geopolitical, military, economic, environmental, legal, and informational trends that will shape the future of warfare through 2030.

Reading 20: Neither War nor Peace

EU 7

Special Report | The Economist | 25 Jan 2018

This reading will help you to understand:

- The complex, multifaceted nature of interstate conflict in the world today.
- The geopolitical, economic and technological reasons that collectively contribute to the changing dynamics of conflict involving major global powers today.
- The concept of 'grey zone' conflict highlighted in this article, and the attendant issues and implications involved in such a model of interstate conflict.

A key element of Chinese strategy is to “know your enemy”. The generals who worked at the Academy of Military Science in Beijing studied every aspect of America’s “revolution in military affairs” in the 1980s, driven by advances in microprocessors, sensors and communications. They concluded that although China was well placed to exploit the new technologies to create its own version of “informationised” warfare, it would not be in a position to challenge American military might directly until the middle of the 21st century. To do so sooner would be suicidal. H.R. McMaster, Donald Trump’s national security adviser, once observed: “There are two ways to fight the United States: asymmetrically and stupid.”

Accordingly, the Chinese generals and their Russian counterparts, who had been equally impressed by the precision-strike capabilities that America demonstrated in the first Gulf war, sought ways to reap some of the political and territorial gains of military victory without crossing the threshold of overt warfare. They came up with the concept of a “grey zone” in which powers such as Russia, China and Iran can exercise aggression and coercion without exposing themselves to the risks of escalation and severe retribution. Mark Galeotti of the Institute of International Relations in Prague describes this approach as “guerrilla geopolitics”.

A key aspect of grey-zone challenges is that they should be sufficiently ambiguous to leave targets unsure how to respond. If they do too little, they will face a series of small but cumulatively significant defeats. If they do too much, they risk being held responsible for reckless escalation. As Hal Brands of the Philadelphia-based Foreign Policy Research Institute argues, grey-zone tactics are “frequently shrouded in misinformation and deception, and are often conducted in ways that are meant to make proper attribution of the responsible party difficult to nail down”. They are drawn from a comprehensive toolset that ranges from cyber-attacks to propaganda and subversion, economic blackmail and sabotage, sponsorship of proxy forces and creeping military expansionism.

The clearest recent cases of grey-zone challenges are Russia’s intervention in Ukraine, China’s assertive behaviour in the South and East China Seas and Iran’s use of proxy militias to establish an arc of influence from Iraq through Syria into Lebanon. All three countries recognise and to some extent fear superior Western military power. But all of them also see vulnerabilities that they can exploit.

A Russian grey-zone strategy is to undermine faith in Western institutions and encourage populist movements by meddling in elections and using bots and trolls on social media to fan grievances and

30 prejudice. The result, the Kremlin hopes, will sap the West's capacity to respond resolutely to acts that defy international norms. If Russian cyber-attacks did help to get Donald Trump elected, they have been astonishingly successful in their broader aim, if not in the narrower one of relieving Ukraine-related sanctions.

35 There is no evidence of Chinese complicity in Russian-style hacker attacks on the West, but officially sanctioned trolls send out hundreds of millions of social-media posts every year attacking Western values and pumping up nationalist sentiment. The advent of Mr Trump serves Chinese aims too. His repudiation of the Trans-Pacific Partnership removed a challenge to China's regional economic hegemony, a key objective of its grey-zone strategy. And the American president's hostility to free trade and his decision to withdraw from the Paris climate accord has allowed Xi Jinping to cast himself, 40 improbably, as a defender of the international order.

As for Iran, America's inconsistency and lack of a long-term strategy in the Middle East has offered boundless opportunities for grey-zone advantage-seeking. Both George W. Bush and Barack Obama in their different ways allowed Iran to use a combination of soft religious and hard power through well-trained and equipped Shia militias to turn first Iraq and then most of Syria into something 45 resembling Iranian satrapies.

Grey-zone success depends on patience and an ability to blend together all the instruments of state power in ways that pluralistic, democratic societies find harder to achieve. Hybrid warfare may be as old as warfare itself, but in Ukraine, Russia provided a near-textbook example of it in its modern form, using a variety of techniques: sophisticated propaganda that stirred up local grievances and legitimised military action; cyber-attacks on power grids and disruption of gas supplies; covert or 50 deniable operations, such as sending "little green men" (soldiers in unmarked green army uniforms) into Crimea and providing weapons and military support to separatist irregular forces; the threat of "escalating to de-escalate", even including limited use of nuclear weapons. All this dissuaded the West from even contemplating a military response of any kind. Whenever the sale of defensive weapons to 55 Ukraine was mooted in Washington, Mr Putin threatened to expand and intensify a war in which he claimed not to be a participant.

Russia's objective is not to "win" a war in Ukraine but to reverse the country's attempt to move out of Russia's orbit; to discourage other countries, such as Belarus, from trying anything similar; and to stoke nationalist and anti-Western sentiment at home. The effort has not been without cost. Sanctions 60 have hurt. Making Crimea a viable entity will take time and lots of money. Most important of all, NATO has rediscovered some of its sense of purpose. But neither Mr Putin nor any likely successor would hesitate to apply the same hybrid-warfare techniques in the future should the need arise.

China's grey-zone campaign to assert uncontested control over the South China Sea and jurisdiction over disputed islands in the East China Sea has been going on for much longer, and has turned a darker 65 shade of grey over time as the country's confidence and power has grown. Since 2009, when China submitted a map to the United Nations showing a "nine-dash line" that supported its claim to "indisputable sovereignty" over 90% of the South China Sea (see map), it has applied what James Holmes of the US Naval War College has described as "small-stick diplomacy" (as opposed to the big stick of conventional naval power), using its highly capable coastguard and militiamen embedded in 70 its fishing fleet to push other littoral states out of waters to which it claims ancestral rights.

It has been able to cow most of its neighbours into sulky acquiescence while avoiding a direct confrontation with American naval ships, which did not want to risk a major incident over what China portrayed as maritime policing. When in 2013 China took its provocations a step further by sending civil engineers to the Spratly and Paracel archipelagoes to construct artificial islands, Xi Jinping said 75 China had no intention of militarising them. But in 2017, satellite images released by the Centre for

Strategic and International Studies showed shelters for missile batteries and military radar installations being constructed on the Fiery Cross, Mischief and Subi Reefs in the Spratly Islands. Fighter jets will be on their way next. Mr Holmes suggests that such strategic gains cannot now be reversed short of open warfare, which means they will almost certainly not be. Unlike traditional warfare, grey-zone strategies will not produce decisive results within a defined time frame. But both China and Russia have demonstrated that hybrid warfare, if not pushed too far, can achieve lasting, if not costless, results.

Hybrid warfare is hard to deter unless the target state itself resorts to hybrid strategies. Mr Brands sees no reason why America and its allies cannot play that game too. America has potent economic and financial tools at its disposal, along with an arsenal of cyber weapons, expert special forces, a network of alliances and unmatched soft power. But the West tends to think about conflict in a binary way: you are either at war or at peace; you win or you lose. Its adversaries are more attuned to conflict somewhere between war and peace, and to blurring distinctions between civil and military assets in pursuit of their goals. So for opponents of the rules-based system, the grey zone will remain fertile territory.

For discussion/reflection:

- Explain what the concept of 'grey zone' (line 12) conflict encompasses. Why is the label of 'guerrilla geopolitics' (line 15) particularly apt? How might such conflicts shape the nature of wars and warfare in the future?
- The author avers that the utility of acts of grey zone conflict lie in how they are 'sufficiently ambiguous to leave targets unsure how to respond' (lines 16-17). Explain why this aspect might be useful to state actors. Conversely, why would this characteristic be concerning?
- In your view, which aspects of 'grey zone' conflicts do you think would prove most challenging for the international community to tackle, and why? Justify your opinions, with additional reading and research on your own.
- What are some characteristics of the world that could make 'grey zone conflicts' more common?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. Given greater levels of international cooperation, how necessary is it for countries to engage in the arms trade? (Cambridge 2020)
2. 'Countries experiencing conflict should be left to sort out their own problems.' How far do you agree? (Cambridge 2016)
3. How far is it possible for one country to forgive another for its past actions? (Cambridge 2015)
4. In the light of increasing security threats, should countries still embrace the notion of a borderless world? (RI Y6 CT2 2019)
5. Is harmony possible in a diverse world? (RI Y6 CT2 2017)
6. Examine the extent to which one country's intervention in another country's problems is justified. (RI Y6 Prelim 2016)

SECTION F: WAR AND THE CHANGING FACE OF CONFLICT

Reading 21: Seven ways Russia's war on Ukraine has changed the world

EU 1, 3, 7

Chatham House Experts | 20 February 2023

This reading will help you:

- The shifts in geopolitical alliances, security, energy, and supply chains since the war between Ukraine and Russia started
- Understand the repercussions that are affecting the world
- Consider whether these changes are likely to be long-lasting

President Vladimir Putin's decision to launch a full-scale re-invasion of Ukraine one year ago was a global shock which 'marked an abrupt end to 30 years of globalization and all the international co-operation that made that possible' with serious implications for countries around the world, outlined Chatham House director Bronwen Maddox in her inaugural lecture. Not only has the war threatened the stability of Europe but it has also impacted food and energy security globally including in the Middle East and Africa, creating shock waves in a world barely recovering from the COVID-19 pandemic.

1. Realignment – shifting alliances

The realization of a major war breaking out in Europe after almost eight years of a simmering conflict created a political constellation of three different groups of nations: those who sided with Putin's Russia, those who pledged support to Ukraine, and a group of non-aligned nations resisting involvement and/or hedging their bets.

European Union (EU) states were quick to respond with major sanctions and action against Russia. Despite some fragmentation – for example, on the oil price cap, and Germany's reluctance to send tanks and other weaponry, the bloc has mainly remained together, against Russian expectations and hopes. 'The EU has shown resolve and, at times surprising, unity in its response to the war,' says Pepijn Bergsen, research fellow in the Chatham House Europe programme. The UK has been keen to stress its 'special relationship' with Kyiv with a desire especially by former prime minister Boris Johnson to lead the pack with strong rhetoric and military support. The opportunist move, says Chatham House UK in the World Initiative director John Kampfner, is an obvious promotion of its post-Brexit 'Global Britain' credentials. Elsewhere, there was less solidarity with Ukraine. Putin predictably called in favours of old allies, such as Syria's Bashar al-Assad and Belarus's Aliaksandr Lukashenka and entered a closer strategic relationship with Iran.

A week after the invasion, the UN General Assembly resolution condemning Russia's aggression was passed by an overwhelming majority. However, there were 35 abstentions, among them three Commonwealth states – South Africa, Pakistan, and India. In Asia, only a handful of governments stood strongly with Ukraine – Singapore, South Korea, and Japan. The region's largest rising powers – China, India, and Indonesia – have all refused to take a side. 'While many in the West hoped that Russia's invasion would rally nations in the developing world behind the rules-based order, Asia has largely rejected Western framings of the conflict as a battle between might and right,' says Ben Bland, Chatham House Asia-Pacific programme director. 'Although they might find Russia an increasingly awkward partner, most Asian nations pragmatically choose to maintain their relationships for a combination of economic, military, and diplomatic reasons.'

Asia has largely rejected Western framings of the conflict as a battle between might and right.

The shift has been mirrored across much of Africa too says Chatham House Africa programme director Dr Alex Vines, highlighting that most abstentions (51 per cent) condemning Russia's invasion at the UN came from African countries, marking a partial resurgence of what was many African nations' default position in the Cold War. Dr Vines says: 'Non-alignment is much more comfortable than being pigeonholed as part of a Western position – or indeed an Eastern position.' But, he says, a position of 'multipolarity' rather than being forced to choose between democratic or autocratic super-powers would then give them more agency.

Iran has taken advantage of both tactical and strategic deals, says Chatham House Middle East and North Africa deputy director Dr Sanam Vakil – providing Russia with sanctions busting support and hundreds of attack drones while, in return, Moscow provided surveillance to help Tehran suppress recent domestic protests. Gap-bridging Turkey has also emerged as a major new diplomatic player – helping broker the grain blockade deal, acting as a humanitarian base for hostage swaps, and hosting (to date, failed) peace talks while simultaneously blocking Finland's, and particularly Sweden's, NATO accession for its own security reasons.

2. Security – redrawing the lines

'For many of Russia's neighbours, the Russian invasion of Ukraine confirmed that they had been correct in their analysis of the threat posed by Moscow's regional ambitions,' says Alice Billon-Galland, research fellow in the Europe programme. Before Russia's invasion, European states, such as France and Germany, had failed to adapt to new geopolitical realities in the region and Russia's actions would lead to a dramatic reappraisal of European security posture.

Indeed, European countries responded with significant increases in their defence budgets, most notably Germany committing to two per cent of its GDP in Chancellor Olaf Scholz's recalibrating 'Zeitenwende' speech. The fundamental decision by Germany is something Jamie Shea, associate fellow in the Chatham House International Security programme, says 'I thought I would never see in my lifetime', bringing security policy alongside foreign policy for the first time in decades. However, Germany has remained slow to act on key decisions, such as Leopard tanks, often communicating good intent but failing to follow up with real action.

Although central, eastern and Baltic states have been more hawkish on Russia compared to states like Germany and France, they haven't stopped the EU's overall response. In fact, the war has accelerated actions which were 'unthinkable' before the war says Kataryna Wolczuk, associate fellow in the Chatham House Russia and Eurasia programme, such as the fast-tracking of Ukraine's EU candidate status within three months. Similarly, the budget from the European Peace Facility, little used before the war in Ukraine, has been employed five times, providing €2.5 billion of cash and hardware for Ukraine's defences.

Russia's invasion has also strengthened NATO's deterrence posture and increased its forward presence in Eastern Europe. Putin has 'managed the trick of pulling NATO closer than ever before' says Jamie Shea, with larger exercises, more readiness, and reinforcement strategies. Finland and Sweden, two countries which have until now shunned NATO membership to avoid antagonizing Russia, are also set to join the alliance in a historic shift.

Crucially, US support for NATO and security in Europe also appears cemented with bipartisan support at home, although this is something Chatham House US and the Americas programme director Dr Leslie Vinjamuri says should not be taken for granted following four years of a US president who 'courted' Putin. She says: 'Neglecting European security would not only undermine the security order

but would also undermine the broader effort to manage China's role in the Indo-Pacific, in Europe, and in multilateral institutions.'

China's intentions in the Indo-Pacific remain a concern for Western allies, especially the US. Although many observers doubt an invasion is imminent, the CIA recently warned China has plans to take Taiwan by 2027 and the world is now watching closely. It is speculated that President Xi had been led to believe the Ukraine invasion would be swift and has now distanced himself from Putin in the wake of a protracted war that has attracted a harsh Western backlash. For a Chinese economy struggling to rebuild post COVID-19, isolation from the West is not something it wants to risk, according to Dr Yu Jie, senior research fellow for China in the Asia-Pacific programme, who says: 'President Xi and his colleagues have begun to realize that cooperation with Russia comes with substantial limits to avoid undermining China's own political priorities and longer-term economic interests.'

She says Ukraine's resilience and the sanctions faced by Russia have provided a 'live simulation' of the reaction an invasion of Taiwan could face, and is causing pause in Beijing. 'Nor is its population willing to give up their reasonable living standard and economic liberty for a conflict that brings long term pain and generational division across the Strait.'

Drone wars

One conundrum has been that, despite anticipating a full cyber war, major Russian attacks upon Ukraine infrastructure have largely failed to materialize. Although attacks are still relentless and numerous, Ukraine's security has been backed with strengthened NATO cyber security coupled with a motivated Ukraine vigilante 'cyber army'. Alongside the changes to Europe's security architecture, Russia's illegal invasion has ushered in a new type of information warfare says Magdalene Karalis, Chatham House Stavros Niarchos academy fellow, especially the widespread use of open-source intelligence (OSINT). She says that by harnessing the capabilities of satellite imagery, smartphones and social media, Ukrainian forces have 'altered' the traditional kill chain, and outsourced parts of it to civilians reporting Russian movements, thereby building a more 'extensive and resilient network'.

The war could also be seen as the first long-term, sustained conflict where all the currently available uses for drones are integrated into combined operations on both sides, according to Keir Giles, senior consulting fellow in the Russia and Eurasia programme, who says: 'That's also true for cyber – and in fact the nexus of cyber and drone operations. It's clear an unpublicized cyber contest between Russian and Ukrainian drone operators is playing out – a kind of cat-and-mouse game of operators and their adversaries struggling for control.'

3. Nuclear weapons – risks return

Since the end of the Cold War and the advent of US-Russian arms control, the threat of nuclear weapons has become less salient. However, the past year has seen regular nuclear weapons threats from Russia, some veiled, some on 'escalation', and some directly aimed at NATO countries such as the UK. Warnings have also emerged from the West, with US president Joe Biden declaring the risk of a nuclear armageddon to be at its highest level for 60 years, bringing the nuclear issue firmly back to the forefront of discussion. While the threats are not new, there is still a question over their credibility and how the West responds. They must be taken seriously, says Dr Patricia Lewis, director of the International Security programme, but she adds they are also 'scare tactics' designed to 'beat the chest' of Russian people and bully the West.

Nonetheless, Keir Giles points out, the scare tactics have been highly effective. He says: 'Russian statements like placing Russia's nuclear forces on a 'special regime of combat duty' in February 2022 may be meaningless, but still generate a fearful reaction across the West.' 'Both the US and Germany have explicitly linked restraint in supporting Ukraine to Russia's nuclear threats. But instead, the West

should pay attention to Moscow's real nuclear posture, rather than fixating on the rhetorical frothing on TV.'

125 Putin placed his country's strategic nuclear weapons on 'high alert' at the start of the war – perhaps, says Dr Lewis, to give him combat readiness status domestically, enabling other senior Russian personnel to order their use. But as the phrase had not been used before, what it exactly means is still, perhaps deliberately, unclear. Many of the threats have been directed at use within Ukraine. Dr Lewis says another new disturbing development in Russia's wider intimidation strategy has been
130 'playing fast and loose' with the safety of nuclear energy in Ukraine, such as the shelling and attacks around the Zaporizhya plant and fears of a dirty bomb detonated as a 'false flag' attack. Putin will be all too aware of the fears this would cause, particularly in Ukraine as the site of the world's worst nuclear power accident – Chernobyl in 1986.

Dr Lewis argues that if the war is truly about Putin's 'imperial legacy project' and an attempt to bring Ukrainian territory back under his control, then creating an uninhabitable post-nuclear wasteland,
135 would make 'little strategic sense'. She says the war has also seen a departure in NATO and western allies' indulging in any 'tit for tat' moves that might escalate the conflict. But, warns Jamie Shea, 'the risk of escalation is ever present with a Russian regime on the back foot and willing to lash out.'

4. Energy and food – fuelling the crisis

As two major suppliers of both energy, food and fertilizer commodities, Russia's conflict with Ukraine has caused disruption in supply for both developing and developed countries. The most fundamental
140 change has been Europe's shift away from reliance on Russian gas. 'Europe will never return to meaningful dependency on Russian fossil fuels,' says Antony Froggatt, deputy director of the Chatham House Environment and Society programme. 'Even if the war finished tomorrow, trust has been broken between European consumers and what has been their primary supplier.'

Europe reacted to the supply disruption in two ways; looking for its gas elsewhere and accelerating
145 the move to renewable energy. Pre-2022, the EU pledged to reduce emissions by 40 per cent and attain 32 per cent renewables. The war has seen those targets raised to 57 per cent and 45 per cent respectively. If met, it would see an almost fully decarbonized power sector across the bloc (with the odd nuclear plant still online) by 2030/35. 'The war has probably brought forward decarbonization by five to ten years,' says Froggatt although huge and unparalleled expansion in capacity of offshore wind,
150 solar, and other sources will be needed to meet targets.

The collapse of the supply of piped gas from Russia has forced Germany and many of its neighbours to source energy elsewhere including from Asia, the Middle East, and potentially Africa. 'These two things – Europe buying up everyone else's energy and the concern of being over-reliant on China for supply of renewable energy materials – have had knock-on geopolitical implications,' says Froggatt.
155 Suddenly, a number of African states such as Mozambique and Nigeria have found themselves being 'wooed' by both West and East, says Dr Alex Vines. 'This is a game-changer in the way that Europe in particular is looking at African energy to help in the energy transition.' With China currently producing around 70 per cent of all the world's solar panels, some nations have already started to restructure their industries to be more self-reliant in renewables production. The US has its protectionist Inflation
160 Reduction Act (IRA) offering large subsidies for domestic production of electrical vehicles and other 'green' sectors, and the EU recently announced a revised 'Green Deal Industrial Plan' it hopes will rival it.

With a history of 'keeping the gas flowing' throughout even the Cold War, Soviet invasion of Afghanistan, and nuclear crisis of the 1980s, Russia banked on Europe losing its nerve, says John Lough,

165 associate fellow in the Russia and Eurasia programme. 'Putin's efforts to use gas as a weapon have so far failed despite the huge costs of subsidizing expensive alternatives to Gazprom's supplies,' he says. It has made short-term gains through high prices of gas and oil, taking 28 per cent more revenue than before the war. But with Europe's vast pipelines now standing idle, Russia has to look further afield for new customers to avoid stranded assets and further economic disaster.

170 It has found some success. Alongside India, China is now the equal largest importer of Russian oil and has signed a new 30-year gas deal. But the markets have fundamentally changed with new deals, renewables on the rise, and both governments and consumers alike all too aware of the dynamics and fragility of the global supply network. With both Russia and Ukraine being major exporters of agricultural fertilizers, the disruption to global food chains drove up prices to all-time highs, fuelling a
175 cost-of-living crisis in both developed and developing nations.

Additionally, disruption of both harvests and a Russian grain blockade threatened to create a humanitarian catastrophe in developing countries as many – such as 85 per cent of Africa – depend on imported wheat. The World Food Programme (WFP) says the crisis remains at 'unprecedented proportions' with ten times the number of people facing famine compared to five years ago. 'It's
180 impossible to separate the food crisis from the continuing energy crisis. High fuel prices drive up fertilizer prices and transport costs, which in turn squeeze farmers' profits while increasing the price of food for consumers,' says Laura Wellesley, senior research fellow in the Environment and Society programme.

Global stocks are 'worryingly low' adds Environment and Society programme director Professor Tim
185 Benton, with an escalation in the war, further trade restrictions, plus climate change creating future threats. He says: 'There are significant potentials for disruptive weather ahead, and whilst the cost-of-living squeeze remains, the global situation remains very fragile.'

5. Russia the pariah state

Putin's decision for a full, illegal re-invasion of Ukraine was a huge gamble which many Russia analysts say he has already likely lost by pushing the nation back out into the cold and putting the regime under
190 threat. James Nixey, director of the Russia and Eurasia programme, says: 'There is no going back after this. The war now is as much about Russia's regime survival as it is about the survival of Ukraine.' He adds that the strength and breadth of 'unprecedented' economic sanctions imposed by the West were more than Moscow had expected, putting the idea of a robust 'Fortress Russia' economy to the test.

John Lough adds: 'While Russia has made short-term gains on inflated gas and energy prices, the
195 sanctions have successfully targeted the heart of the Russian financial system.' As Putin has not made any real concessions since the sanctions hit, there is an argument they are not working says Nixey. 'However, the reality is that sanctions have dealt Russia a chronic blow, limiting its room to manoeuvre in the future.'

In addition, self-sanctioning by thousands of companies, from Apple to McDonald's, who either ceased
200 or curtailed operating in Russia has effectively added to pressure. This exodus, coupled with a national 'mobilization' conscription drive in 2022, has also led to hundreds of thousands of Russian citizens fleeing the country, according to estimates. Observers say it adds to the 'brain drain' upon an already ailing economy.

The war also cast a spotlight into some hitherto dark corners of the Russian – and Western economies,
205 waking the world up to the issue of Russian and regional kleptocracy. An estimated one trillion US dollars has left Russia in 'capital flight' according to author Oliver Bullough, with a significant amount ending up in the UK and London as a 'capital haven for dirty money'. Chatham House research found

210 money and reputation laundering in the UK was rife. Forced to crack down on such activities of oligarchs and their associates, UK and other states have realised they cannot keep letting this cash flow in while trying to leverage sanctions and take the moral high ground.

215 Perhaps one of the biggest surprises of the war has been the exposure of Russia's military weakness. The narrative of a swift targeted 'special military operation' run by an effective army has collapsed in the face of major defeats, huge casualties, loss of equipment, munitions shortages, and military blunders. Seemingly underestimating a well-organized, uber-motivated Ukraine resistance – armed and trained in using the latest Western-supplied military hardware – has also been key. But the swift elimination of the most modern and capable elements of Russia's land forces isn't the same as the destruction of Russia's military overall, warns Keir Giles. 'Even after the end of the current fighting in Ukraine, Russia's neighbours will still need to be wary of Moscow's air and naval power, and its willingness to throw less capable men and material into combat,' he says.

220 Reports of mounting casualties have sparked rare demonstrations of dissent across Russia. Some experts predict a consequence of the war will be a collapse of Russia within a year or two. Timothy Ash, associate fellow in the Russia and Eurasia programme, says that while there is a small possibility of positive change with reforming forces emerging, more likely is the disintegration of the Russian federation into many new states.

225 Others are less confident about any imminent regime collapse. Dr Joanna Szostek, associate fellow in the Russia and Eurasia programme, says Russian authorities excel at suppressing protest and have stepped up a regime of repression. 'Experience shows mass public protest generally only poses a real threat to an entrenched authoritarian regime if there is division within the elite as well,' she says. 'The problem is that the Russian imperial itch is deeply embedded within the elite and popular imagination,' says James Nixey. 'This must be removed if there is to be any meaningful change in Russia's behaviour in the future.'

6. A new Ukraine – new hopes

235 Russia's brutal assault on Ukraine has taken a heavy toll on its citizens but has also united the country in a way not seen before. Observers have been surprised by the strength of Ukraine's resistance, resilience, and national cohesion. Despite an estimated 14 million people displaced and with its infrastructure, energy, and transport networks under constant attack, Ukraine has remarkably remained functioning. 'Since the start of the war, Ukrainians have emerged and shattered the country's inferiority complex of being Russia's 'little brother'. They will never again live in shadow of the Russian empire and are confident it will collapse,' says Orysia Lutsevych, head of the Ukraine Forum at Chatham House.

240 One man who has come to personify this unity and defiance is Ukraine's president Volodymyr Zelenskyy. One year into the largest military assault on Europe since World War Two, his journey from TV comedian to 'Churchillian' wartime leader and the 'revered face of European liberal democracy is extraordinary' says John Kampfner. Zelenskyy's refusal of the airlift offered by President Biden early in the war represented a 'rebirth moment' for him and for Ukrainian politics, says Lutsevych. 'His decision to stand firm and face the horrors of war with his people, despite being headhunted by mercenaries, was hugely significant,' she says.

250 Before Zelenskyy, Ukrainian domestic politics was highly contentious, with low public trust in political figures many of whom faced corruption allegations. The power of Zelenskyy, despite being from a Russian-speaking part of Ukraine, is that in 2019 he garnered support across different regions and generations around change, fighting corruption and bringing peace, says Lutsevych. 'This marked a change from the ethnic identity divides which had previously defined Ukrainian elections and saw

Zelenskyy become the manifestation of a new modern Ukraine where values and a turn towards Europe mattered more than language and local identity.'

255 Zelenskyy was an outsider in Ukrainian politics, emerging from the creative economy rather than the oligarchical class, giving him credibility and popularity, she adds. In his trademark khaki T-shirt and with canny social media lobbying, Zelenskyy has campaigned tirelessly to build a global coalition in support of Ukraine, zooming, quite literally, onto parliamentary screens across the world. Even at times of war, he stresses commitment to tackling corruption and strengthening the rule of law in Ukraine. 'This is so vital' says Lutsevych as impunity 'undermines effective resistance in the war and
260 derails Ukraine's ambitions for closer ties with Europe'.

Playing to Putin's fears, Ukraine's heroic resistance anchors it with the EU and NATO. Although the issue of future NATO membership for Ukraine is often diplomatically kicked down the road, Europe reached out in a gesture of solidarity with a decision to grant Kyiv EU candidate status, making full membership a possibility (with conditions) within a few years. 'Even with a long road ahead, still the
265 membership perspective is essential. It would be a vote of confidence the Ukrainians desperately need,' says Kataryna Wolczuk. Any future president would be expected to deliver a new Ukraine which is a member of both NATO and the EU, and strive to build a safe and successful country, says Orysia Lutsevych.

So how would that be reached? Most agree that any ceasefire without Russia's agreement to pull out
270 of occupied territories will simply not be tolerated by Ukraine, which aims to militarily defeat Russian forces on its territory. Restoring territorial integrity, delivering justice for war crimes, and making the Kremlin pay for destruction, all constitute key elements of a Ukraine victory and are the foundation for renewed European security architecture, says Lutsevych. 'The future is hard to predict but, whatever the next few months may bring, it is clear we are living in a true historic moment where we
275 will see the reshaping of the Eurasian continent and the process of ending the Russian imperial ambition, and that is a legacy worth fighting for,' she says.

7. International law – ripping up the rulebook

Russia's re-invasion of Ukraine breached the UN Charter and fundamental international law, says Chatham House International Law programme director Rashmin Sagoo. 'As a UN Security Council member entrusted to maintain international peace and security, there was a sense of déjà vu with the
280 US-led invasion of Iraq, and Russia's annexation of Crimea in 2014.'

But as observers have pointed out, the rule of law quickly swung into action. The dizzying speed of coordinated global sanctions on an unprecedented scale catalysed a domino effect of mass corporate exits from Russia. In February 2022, the UN Security Council tabled a resolution, deploring Russia's actions in Ukraine and calling for withdrawal of its troops – only to be blocked by a Russian veto. Any
285 Security Council attempt to refer Russia to the International Criminal Court (ICC) would likely face a similar fate. So, within days of the invasion, discussions to establish a new crime of aggression tribunal began. 'Regardless of the legal merits and demerits and whether it goes ahead, there is huge political appetite for this ad hoc tribunal,' says Sagoo.

Even in times of war, rules apply, including international humanitarian law or the law of war. Potential
290 war crimes were reported. The ICC received the largest ever state party referral to open an investigation. The International Court of Justice demanded Russia 'immediately suspend the military operations' in Ukraine. Avenues via the European Court of Human Rights and domestic courts were primed, and the UN Human Rights Council started its own investigation using mounting evidence of Russian attacks on civilians and civilian infrastructure.

295 Russia's expulsion from the Council of Europe after 26 years of membership was unprecedented. But the move by Europe's largest and oldest intergovernmental organisation, established to protect human rights, democracy and law, could have other serious ramifications says Sagoo.

It means Russia is no longer bound by the standards in the European Convention on Human Rights. Russian citizens will no longer be able to rely on their Convention rights nor have redress to the
300 European Convention on Human Rights for new cases. Russia is also reported to be starting the process of withdrawing from other Council of Europe treaties. 'Irrespective of the strong political rationale, the move is likely to steer the country further away from accountability for human rights violations,' says Sagoo.

Talk of war crimes, reparations, and punishment may seem premature, and some may doubt the efficacy of law to ever bring perpetrators to court. But Ukraine foreign affairs minister Dmytro Kuleba told a Chatham House event: 'This is the only tool of civilization that is available to us to make sure that in the end all those who made this war possible will be brought to justice and the Russian Federation ... will also be held accountable for its deeds.' Peace negotiations, by nature, invariably involve some compromise but there is a real risk in leaving Ukraine's sovereignty insecure and Russia
305 'sitting on the edge and threatening to regroup' says Bronwen Maddox.

In a more positive vein, others point out that despite the colossal tests of multilateralism and the rule of law, nations are still demonstrating they can come together. International negotiations are underway to reach agreement on crucial global issues such as plastics and biodiversity. The UN Security Council (by and large) continues to operate and the General Assembly has found innovative
315 ways to tackle Security Council vetoes. 'Despite the challenges, there is international resolve. It's pretty remarkable that states have agreed to get around the table on these issues because there's been so much trust and good will lacking, an increase of nationalism and so on. The question to ask is what if we didn't have these systems?' says Rashmin Sagoo. Dr Leslie Vinjamuri adds: 'The Western liberal order was designed to do exactly what it is presently doing, working collectively to deter the use of force to violate territorial integrity and national sovereignty.' As Russia's war on Ukraine rages on, only time will tell whether that will be enough.
320

For discussion/reflection:

- What are some possible reasons why 'Singapore, South Korea, and Japan' (line 28) supported the UN resolution to censure Russia for its aggression, while countries like 'China, India, and Indonesia' (line 29) chose to abstain from voting on the resolution?
- The authors observe that new 'tactical and strategic deals' (line 44) were struck between Iran and Russia upon the onset of the Russia-Ukraine conflict. Explain how this illustrates how conflicts can provide the basis for new alliances to be formed.
- Suggest reasons why 'European countries [that were not directly affected by the conflict between Russia and Ukraine] responded with significant increases in their defence budgets' (line 56).
- In what ways have Russia's actions in the conflict directly and indirectly caused the 'escalation' (line 112) of the nuclear threat?
- What are some unexpected benefits of the Russia-Ukraine war for Europe in terms of the energy and food supply?
- How has President Volodymyr Zelenskyy's leadership impacted Ukraine's response to the invasion, and what has been his role in unifying the country?
- What can be done to resolve the conflict between Ukraine and Russia, and how can the international community help?
- How has the conflict impacted the relationship between Ukraine and its neighboring countries?

- The authors outline various actions to hold Russia accountable for invading Ukraine, which include the setting up of a 'new crime of aggression tribunal' (lines 289-290); the initiating of investigations against Russia for committing war crimes by the 'UN Human Rights Council' (line 296); and the possible 'expulsion [of Russia] from the Council of Europe' (line 298). In what ways might such actions do more harm than good? Why?
- What lessons can the world learn from the conflict between Ukraine and Russia, especially regarding the dangers of aggression and the importance of international cooperation?
- Contrast the effects of a unipolar¹³ world order against that of a multipolar¹⁴ one in the context of armed conflict.

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. Given greater levels of international cooperation, how necessary is it for countries to engage in the arms trade? (Cambridge 2020)
2. Is conflict inevitable in today's volatile world? (RI Y6 Prelims 2022)
3. 'International organisations are ineffective at resolving conflicts.' To what extent do you agree? (RI Y6 Timed Practice 2021)
4. 'Countries experiencing conflict should be left to sort out their own problems.' How far do you agree? (Cambridge 2016)
5. Why is it that, in spite of international efforts, world peace remains unattainable? (RI Y6 CT1 2020)

SECTION F: WAR AND THE CHANGING FACE OF CONFLICT

Reading 22: The world is facing an upsurge of nuclear proliferation

EU 7

The Economist | 30 Jan 2021

This reading will examine how:

- Nuclear proliferation is still a major issue that our world needs to face with.
- It has never been more important for the U.S. and other superpowers to agree on more binding treaties to control the spread of nuclear weapons.

Thirty-one countries from Brazil to Sweden, have flirted with nuclear weapons at one time or another. Seventeen launched a formal weapons programme. Just ten produced a deliverable bomb. Today nine states possess nuclear arms, no more than a quarter-century ago. Yet the long struggle to stop the world's deadliest weapons from spreading is about to get harder.

- 5 In the past 20 years most countries with nuclear ambitions have been geopolitical minnows, like Libya and Syria. In the next decade the threat is likely to include economic and diplomatic heavyweights whose ambitions would be harder to restrain. China's rapidly increasing regional dominance and North Korea's growing nuclear arsenal haunt South Korea and Japan, two of Asia's largest powers. Iran's belligerence and its nuclear programme loom over the likes of Saudi Arabia and Turkey.
- 10 Proliferation is not a chain reaction, but it is contagious. Once the restraints start to weaken they can fail rapidly.

¹³ This refers to a world order whereby there is a single dominant state shaping globalisation and imposing its policies and agenda on the international community.

¹⁴ This is a world order where multiple major powers compete and potentially collaborate in addressing global issues

15 The nuclear omens are bad. Arms control between America and Russia, which saw cuts of 38,000 warheads—a 79% fall—in 1991-2010, has dwindled. On January 26th Presidents Joe Biden and Vladimir Putin agreed to extend the last remaining pact, the New start treaty, for five years. That is welcome, but prospects for a follow-on are dim. China, India, North Korea and Pakistan are all expanding and modernising their nuclear forces. There is dismal progress towards global disarmament, the ultimate aim of the Non-Proliferation Treaty (npt), the cornerstone of the nuclear order. A new treaty banning the bomb, which was signed by 86 countries and came into force on January 22nd, channels the frustration among nuclear have-nots. It accomplishes little else.

20 If nuclear weapons are not going away, and security threats are worsening, some states will be tempted to pursue a bomb of their own. In decades past America kept nuclear aspirants in line, threatening to withdraw security guarantees from errant friends, like Taiwan, and using sanctions and military force to dissuade enemies, such as Iraq. Yet the currency of American power is weaker today. Donald Trump's tempestuous term has sown doubts about America's appetite to defend allies and enforce rules. They will linger, however much Mr Biden seeks to restore an orthodox foreign policy.

30 Consider the nuclear umbrella that America extends over Asian allies. It amounts to a promise that, should North Korea or China strike Seoul or Tokyo, America would retaliate against Pyongyang or Beijing. For decades, America could issue that threat confident that its own cities were out of range of North Korean missiles. Now they are not. An American strike on Pyongyang would put San Francisco at risk. That may make Mr Biden reluctant to act—a calculation that could embolden Kim Jong Un to attack Seoul. No wonder that, particularly in times of crisis, most South Koreans say that they would like to see a return of the American tactical nuclear weapons withdrawn from their soil in 1991 or, failing that, an indigenous South Korean bomb.

35 In democracies like South Korea, Japan and Taiwan, nuclear ambitions are tempered by political reality. The Middle East is different. The nuclear deal curtailing Iran's nuclear programme is collapsing. Even if Mr Biden revives it, many of its provisions expire in a decade. Should Iran at any time look as if it is contemplating going nuclear, Saudi Arabia will not want to fall behind. Muhammad bin Salman, the Saudi crown prince, has few domestic checks on his authority and ambitious plans for nuclear technology. Turkey could well follow.

40 If the nuclear order starts to unravel, it will be almost impossible to stop. Hence the importance of acting today. America, China, Europe and Russia share an interest in stopping proliferation. Russia does not want a nuclear Iran any more than America does. The prospect of a nuclear-armed Japan would be among China's worst nightmares. The Iranian nuclear deal in 2015 showed that rivals can muster a response to proliferation.

45 The nuclear states should start with the basics. America and Russia still have 90% of the world's nuclear warheads, so any effort begins with them. Now that New start will be extended, they should begin work on a successor that would include other weapons, such as hypersonic gliders and lower-yield warheads, which Russia has in abundance. More radical ideas should also be discussed. America operates a triad of nuclear forces: silos on land, submarines at sea and bombers in the air. Retiring the land-based missiles would demonstrate genuine progress towards disarmament, without eroding deterrence.

50 Arms control between America and Russia might persuade China that its existing arsenal could survive an attack, helping avoid a destabilising surge in its forces. Chinese restraint would, in turn, reassure India and Pakistan.

55 America's most important role in calming nerves over North Korea and Iran remains its value as an ally, and here Mr Biden has already promised to repair ties. Even if one presidency is not enough to

restore confidence completely, Mr Biden should make a start by reaffirming and strengthening America's nuclear umbrella over Japan and South Korea. That includes the role of American troops on the ground, who serve not only as a line of defence but also as an assurance to allies and a warning to enemies that America could not sit out a conflict.

Stopping proliferation also requires spotting it. Intelligence agencies have understandably focused on the familiar gallery of rogues, like Iran. Their gaze should widen to include early warning of shifts in nuclear technology, public opinion and political intentions in such places as South Korea or Turkey. The International Atomic Energy Agency, the world's nuclear watchdog, does a commendable job of monitoring civilian nuclear sites and policing Iran's programme with the strongest inspections regime ever instituted. Yet the agency is overburdened and underfunded, and needs to keep up with technological change.

Heed the doomsday alarm clock

The world has plenty on its mind. Even so, it cannot afford to downplay the dangers of nuclear proliferation. Today's nuclear diplomacy may seem a slog, but it is as nothing compared with the lethal instabilities that arise whenever regional nuclear-armed rivals confront each other. There is no time to lose.

Explainer:

What is the Doomsday Clock?

- The Doomsday Clock is a symbolic tool created by the Bulletin of the Atomic Scientists to represent how close humanity is to global catastrophe.
- The Chicago-based nonprofit created the clock in 1947 during the Cold War tensions that followed World War Two to warn the public about how close humankind was to destroying the world.
- "Midnight" represents global disaster (e.g. nuclear war, climate collapse). The closer the clock is to midnight, the greater the perceived global risk.
- It is not a scientific measurement, but an expert judgement based on current global trends.

Who decides the time?

- The clock is set by a group of scientists and policy experts, including Nobel laureates like including Albert Einstein and renowned scientists like J. Robert Oppenheimer.
- Each year, the Bulletin's Science and Security Board, in consultation with Nobel laureates, determines the clock's time after assessing global threats, similar to how experts evaluate risk in science and policy.

What threats does it consider?

The clock originally focused on nuclear weapons, but now includes multiple global risks:

- Nuclear threats → arms races, geopolitical tensions (e.g. US–China, Russia)
- Climate change → rising temperatures, extreme weather
- Emerging technologies → AI misuse, bioengineering risks
- Misinformation → undermining trust and decision-making

What purpose does it serve?

- While the clock's setting serves as a dire warning, its creators maintain that it is not absolute.
- It is a means in which scientists and policy experts (The Bulletin of the Atomic Scientists) call on world leaders to collaborate on addressing existential risks.

For discussion/reflection:

- It is suggested that “[o]nce the restraints start to weaken they can fail rapidly”. (lines 10-11). Suggest reasons why is this so, based on ideas from the reading, and on what you understand about global conflict.
- Based on lines 5-54, summarise the key reasons for greater concern about the state of nuclear proliferation today.
- What does “political reality” (line 34) refer to, and why would that curb the ambition of South Korea, Japan, and Taiwan to acquire nuclear weapons?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. Given greater levels of international cooperation, how necessary is it for countries to engage in the arms trade? (Cambridge 2020)
2. To what extent is diplomacy effective in dealing with conflicts today? (RI Y6 Timed Practice 2023)
3. Why is it that, in spite of international efforts, world peace remains unattainable? (RI Y6 CT1 2020)

Supplementary Reading:

1.  **Atomic scientists set ‘Doomsday Clock’ closer to midnight than ever before:** In January 2026, the Doomsday Clock was moved to 85 seconds to midnight, marking the closest point to global catastrophe in its history. The Bulletin of the Atomic Scientists cited escalating nuclear threats, rapid AI advancements, and climate inaction as driving factors.

SECTION F: WAR AND THE CHANGING FACE OF CONFLICT

Reading 23: Taiwan’s Reliance on the Semiconductor Industry- A Geopolitical Achilles’ Heel?

Report / RSIS / 8 April 2024

EU 1, 3, 7

This reading will examine how:

- The competition for semiconductor supply chains between various parties in one country can exacerbate existing political and geopolitical tensions across the world.
- The race for technological dominance can be potentially destabilising for the international community with ripple effects on technological innovation and the global economy

The semiconductor industry was one of the most highly contested topics during the 2024 Taiwanese presidential election. Particularly, vice-presidential nominees like Jaw Shaw-kong and Hsiao Bi-khim debated the issue of chipmaker Taiwan Semiconductor Manufacturing Company Limited (TSMC)'s investments abroad and questioned whether escalating tensions with China rendered Taiwan an overly risky destination for foreign investments.

Following his victory in the presidential race, the Democratic Progressive Party (DPP)'s Lai Ching-te pledged to advance Taiwan's crucial chips sector. As an export-oriented island, Taiwan's trading activities contribute to a huge portion of its economy, with the total amounting to 114% of its Gross Domestic Product (GDP). Notably, 40% of its exports are semiconductors. Yet, this over-reliance on the chip industry could heighten Taiwan's political vulnerability as the island is already prone to external shocks and disruptions.

The rise of artificial intelligence (AI) chips poses significant risks to the semiconductor industry. While demand for more sophisticated semiconductors driven by AI chips grows, it may disrupt markets for companies focusing on traditional chips. The evolving AI technology requires quick adaptation by semiconductor firms, posing challenges to development timelines and resource allocation. Smaller (domestic) chip companies may be at a greater disadvantage compared to larger corporations due to limited capacities, making it challenging to adapt.

Another risk that the semiconductor industry faces is that of cyber threats. Being increasingly important for multiple devices and industries, semiconductors constitute unique assets that make them valuable targets for cyberattacks. In January, Foxsemicon, a major manufacturer in Taiwan, was targeted by the Russia-based LockBit ransomware group. Although the ransom details were not disclosed and minimal operational disruptions were reported, the incident underscored the sector's vulnerabilities and the risk of compromised security.

While the semiconductor industry may well be Taiwan's selling point, over-emphasis on a single sector could jeopardise its economy in situations of huge supply chain disruptions. Examining the implications of narrowly focusing on the chip sector could provide an understanding of why Taiwan must further diversify its economy while managing external relations to maintain its relevance in global supply chains.

While the semiconductor industry continues to be one of Taiwan's strongest selling points, the over-reliance on the chip sector amid strained cross-strait relations could jeopardise the island's economy in situations of huge supply chain disruptions.

Fierce Competition amid Strained Cross-Strait Relations

In 2022, China was ranked among the five leading destinations for Taiwan's integrated circuit exports. With the island's economy being tied closely to Beijing, it is difficult to separate the political challenges (due to strained cross-strait relations) from Taiwan's economic health. This is notwithstanding the fact that trade with Beijing is already at a historically low level, with exports making up 35.25% of the overall total in 2023, compared with 42% back in 2010.

In 2023, Taiwan accounted for around 46% of the world's semiconductor foundry capacity, with Beijing following at 26%. Earlier, in 2015, Chinese President Xi Jinping introduced a "Made in China 2025" plan targeting Chinese supremacy in 20 key sectors while pushing for self-sufficiency in semiconductor manufacturing to achieve technological independence. Although there was a decline in Taiwan's chip exports to China, China has remained Taiwan's largest buyer, accounting for nearly 54% of Taiwan's exports in May 2023.

While Beijing still needs Taiwanese technology and is unlikely to boycott Taiwan's advanced chips in the near term, the mainland seems determined to focus on domestic production to gradually move
45 towards self-reliance amid the ongoing trade war with the United States. As such, competition in the chip industry is significant as key players attempt to up their game to have a larger share of the pie.

Scholarly discussions have highlighted how Taiwan's chip sector was referred to as huguo shenshan (guardian mountain of the nation) and a critical strategic asset. Leveraging semiconductors for economic reliance has potentially enhanced Taiwan's influence in a form of asymmetrical warfare
50 between itself and Beijing. Nevertheless, Taiwan aims for inclusivity in global supply chains even as it enjoys a critical role in the development of advanced information-processing technologies like AI-specific chips.

Yet, cross-strait tensions may prompt other countries to explore alternative import routes for semiconductor chips to avert possible supply disruptions. This year, European CEOs are increasingly
55 shifting their focus to other (new) markets such as Southeast Asia to strengthen supply chain resilience. Such measures could be intentional to avoid appearing aligned with Taiwan's assertions of independence. The over-reliance on the semiconductor sector thus magnifies Taiwan's political vulnerability as the island's alliances drive the chip industry's prosperity.

Depending on the Chinese market as its main buyer for semiconductors poses risks for Taiwan. This is especially so considering that China may be losing its appeal to foreign investors, given the primacy that Beijing has begun to accord to national security over economic growth and development, manifested through its crackdowns on alleged foreign espionage activities and its data localisation laws. During the first quarter of 2023, China's balance of payments showed a decline in direct investment liabilities for the first time. Such a trend could further weaken the Chinese economy, which
60 could in turn affect China's demand for semiconductors.

A Potential Sacrificial Lamb in US-China Tech War?

As Washington and Beijing jostle for power in a tech war, there is a high risk of Taiwan becoming the proverbial sacrificial lamb. When the United States adopted the CHIPS and Science Act of 2022 to promote domestic semiconductor production, companies that received subsidies such as TSMC were restricted from producing chips more advanced than 28 nanometres in China and "other countries of
70 concern" for the next decade. It must be noted that Beijing managed to manufacture the Huawei Mate 60 in 2023 using a 7-nanometre process through Semiconductor Manufacturing International Corporation (SMIC), a Chinese company blacklisted by the United States in 2020.

The US CHIPS Act is a strategic retaliation by proxy to contain Beijing. Washington has offered Taiwan a carrot by including it in the "Chip 4 Alliance" to promote interconnectivity in the semiconductor supply chain network even as it implements the CHIPS Act, which could further alienate Taiwanese chipmakers from the mainland. The United States' actions may exacerbate Taiwan's challenges as they have the potential to affect the profitability of some of Taiwan's semiconductor manufacturers and could also further strain cross-strait relations.
75

While the semiconductor industry might be called Taiwan's "silicon shield", there is a shift of production away from the island towards countries like the United States (Arizona) and Japan (Kumamoto). Although TSMC stressed that the company would remain "rooted in Taiwan", its setting up of new manufacturing plants in other countries suggests it has back-up solutions for replacement and continuity if domestic stability in Taiwan is affected owing to cross-strait tensions.
80

No Longer Putting Most Eggs in One Basket

85 As a leading player in semiconductor manufacturing and technological innovation, Taiwan plays a crucial role in the global supply chain, producing important components for many countries worldwide. While investment in the industry is essential for boosting research and development, heavy reliance on the sector can heighten the risk of the island becoming a target for cyberattacks and a pawn in the major powers' battle for their own geopolitical agendas.

90 Although the Taiwanese government does promote investment projects in Central and Eastern Europe to diversify risks, it should consider redistributing more resources to other sectors that do contribute to its growth such as pharmaceuticals, petrochemicals, and agriculture, rather than allocating most of its capital to the chips industry. Government sources reported that in January, Taiwanese exports comprised 36.8% electronic components and 25.3% information and communication technology (ICT) and audio-visual products. These items are closely related to the semiconductor industry, 95 underscoring its substantial presence in Taiwan's export profile and emphasise the island's continued reliance on chips.

100 Diversifying the economy away from dependence on semiconductor production could provide the island with more opportunities for cooperation with other countries. This is particularly critical after the COVID-19 pandemic, which clearly highlighted the importance of timely deliveries of medicine and food. While diversification may seem ambitious in the short run, the redistribution of resources to other crucial industries would encourage Taiwan to prioritise security and economic growth simultaneously in the long term. Rather than putting most eggs in one basket, i.e., the semiconductor sector, practising economic resilience would lower Taiwan's political vulnerability and its susceptibility to external threats.

For discussion/reflection:

- Why do you think semiconductors have become such a vital resource and source of competition and rivalry and interdependence between global superpowers?
- Explain how the semiconductor industry represents "a form of asymmetrical warfare" (line 49) between Taiwan and China.
- China is becoming a major player in the global semiconductor industry. To what extent does it represent further collaboration, increased competition or a serious existential threat for other global superpowers and intermediaries like Taiwan?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

- Should a country still be concerned with national boundaries in today's interconnected world? (RI Y6 CT2 2020)
- 'International cooperation has not solved the global problems of today.' Do you agree? (RI Y6 CT2 2014)

SECTION F: CHANGING FACE OF CONFLICT

Reading 24: Don't Forget About Water in 2023

EU 4 & 7

Antonia Colibasanu | *Geopolitical Futures* | 18 Jan 2023

This reading will examine how:

- Water will have plenty of countries on edge in the coming year.
- The constraints countries are facing to secure their fresh water supply and how it may lead to conflict across nations.

On Jan. 16, the Chinese Ministry of Water Resources announced that Beijing invested more than 1 trillion yuan (\$148 billion) on water resource management in 2022, a whopping 44 percent increase from the previous year. Elsewhere, Pakistan suggested that water resource management projects need to become a priority for the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor because by 2025 Pakistan is expected to be a water-scarce country. Weeks earlier, an Iranian official confirmed that 270 cities and towns were suffering from acute water shortage as water levels at dams dropped to critically low levels.

Factories in southwest China had to suspend their work last summer after a record-breaking drought caused some rivers in the country – including parts of the Yangtze – to dry up. Hydropower and shipping were also affected; Sichuan province was deemed to be in a “grave situation” because it generates more than 80 percent of its energy from hydropower.

Pakistan is in a similar situation. The Indus River is a source of more than 17 gigawatts of hydropower, and it provides water to the Indus basin irrigation system, which supports more than 90 percent of the country’s agricultural output. Poor water management, rapid population growth, and drought and floods have created a truly dire situation.

In Iran, a semi-arid climate and declining precipitation over the past decade have played their part in the crisis, but perennial inefficient water management since the 1990s is perhaps the larger problem. After the 1979 revolution, the new regime advanced a policy of national food self-sufficiency, which involved producing enough staple crops to meet the country’s own needs instead of relying on imports. To that end, agricultural production became reliant on groundwater extraction, and slow-filling aquifers have not been able to keep up with the growing number of water users and withdrawals.

These issues may not be new, but they are all getting worse. And the fact that these three countries are geographically interconnected has been a wake-up call for other nations around the world that have dealt with, or are soon to deal with, similar water shortages and their associated consequences.

Indeed, water is so fundamental to geopolitics that it is often overlooked. Water supplies play critical roles in sustaining life, agriculture and industry. The supply levels themselves can fluctuate dramatically for reasons outside of a government’s control. However, given the increasing threat of water shortages and the consequences arising from them, governments are increasingly more aggressive in taking what action they can to ensure supply.

Disputes over control of water resources historically end in violence. The historical dispute between Ethiopia and Egypt over water from the Nile River is probably the one that has garnered the most attention. Even today, the water supply in Donbas is carefully managed on both sides, and in Kherson, understanding the way water supplies to Crimea could be cut was key to understanding the fighting on the ground. More, the Russian attack on the Dnipro hydropower plant was meant to sever electricity to the region as part of the Russian strategy to down Ukraine’s critical infrastructure. In war, water is at once a weapon and a casualty.

40 But water is only part of the equation. The droughts of 2022, followed by the warmest winter in years
in the Northern Hemisphere, have many governments on edge this year as the downstream effects of
water shortage take shape. The potential food crisis, initially the result of last year's energy crisis, may
only get worse. The impact will be felt the most in places like Africa and the Middle East, where water
scarcity is a constant concern. Refugee flows from places like Iraq, Syria and Yemen may well increase.
Food insecurity will likely grow in countries like Algeria, Morocco and Tunisia. And because it's unclear
how much food will be available for export from otherwise large producers such as Russia and Ukraine
in 2023, countries with limited domestic production have even more reason for concern, especially as
45 their citizens grow more restive.

But even for major powers like China, Pakistan and Iran, things will likely get worse before they get
better. All three are already dealing with socio-economic distress. It's unknown how much the COVID-
19 pandemic hurt the Chinese economy, but it isn't good, with reports painting a particularly bleak
picture for youth unemployment. (That is to say nothing of the economic problems China faces
50 independent of the pandemic.) Pakistan is seeing its worst socio-political crisis in years. Iran has been
embroiled in high-profile protests for some time. Inflation is high in all three countries, as is economic
unrest from class inequality. Adding water stress could make things even more explosive.

Further instability in any of the three major players will likely have a spillover effect in the Middle East
and beyond. A troubled Pakistan and Iran at the same time will certainly make Turkey and Saudi Arabia
nervous. And what happens in China – one of the world's largest consumers of resources and one of
its biggest economic engines – matters to the rest of the world. Factory shutdowns due to water
shortages in post-pandemic China would trigger new supply chain shocks affecting both Europe and
the U.S. Neither is decoupled enough from the Chinese powerhouse to ignore such shocks.

60 Both have their own water issues to deal with. Lower levels in the Rhine triggered alarms for European
inland shipping last year; further reductions will likely hamper economic activity in Western Europe.
Last year, water scarcity compelled the U.S. government to limit water releases in western states. If
things get worse, U.S. policymakers will be forced to choose between water releases, electricity
generation and industrial and food production on the one hand and water conservation on the other.

Water is finite, so it's clear that concerns over its use and distribution will increase as reserves dwindle.
65 Under higher pressure from citizens, governments will search for quick fixes. If a fix for one country
comes at the expense of another, tensions will inevitably arise – perhaps violently. Each government
will manage, or try to manage, the situation differently. In poorer countries, militias may continue to
fight over water, while in wealthier nations, new policies over water usage and likely new technologies
for keeping and improving water infrastructure will be debated. All in all, water stress highlights
70 another socio-economic challenge that the world needs to tackle before it gets worse.

For discussion/reflection:

- What are some of the challenges that China, Pakistan, and Iran are facing with regards to water resource management?
- How can water scarcity lead to socio-economic instability in countries?
- Based on lines 25-36, why does Colibasanu believe that water “is [fundamental] to geopolitics” (line 25)? Is this relationship between water and geopolitics likely to strengthen or weaken in time to come?
- What are some potential downstream effects of water shortages and how can they impact countries and geopolitics beyond the affected region?
- What steps can governments take to manage their water resources more efficiently?
- What role can international cooperation play in addressing water scarcity issues?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. 'Countries experiencing conflict should be left to sort out their own problems.' How far do you agree? (Cambridge 2016)
2. How far can prosperity and uncontrolled population growth go hand in hand? (Cambridge 2020)
3. Is there any point in trying to predict future trends? (Cambridge 2013)
4. Is conflict inevitable in today's volatile world? (RI Y6 Prelims 2022)
5. How effective have global efforts been in addressing the spread of diseases? (RI Y6 CT1 2020)

SECTION G: THE IMPACT OF GLOBAL HEALTH THREATS

Reading 25: WHO Pandemic Treaty: what is it and how will it save lives in the future?

Emma Farge | World Economic Forum | 26 May 2023

EU 1, 3, 8

This reading will help you understand:

- The tension between national interest and global obligations, particularly in relation to crisis management that is on a global scale
- Why it can be so challenging for countries to come together to collaborate on a global issue
- The history of global collaboration in terms of public health crises

Negotiations on new rules for dealing with pandemics are underway at the World Health Organization (WHO), with a target date of May 2024 for a legally binding agreement to be adopted by the U.N. health agency's 194 member countries.

What is the so-called Pandemic Treaty?

- 5 The WHO already has binding rules known as the International Health Regulations, which in 2005 set out countries' obligations where public health events have the potential to cross borders. These include advising the WHO immediately of a health emergency and measures on trade and travel.

Adopted after the 2002-2003 SARS outbreak, these regulations are still considered appropriate for regional epidemics, such as Ebola but inadequate for a global pandemic. These regulations are also being reviewed in the wake of COVID-19.

- 10 For the new more wide-reaching pandemic accord, member states have agreed that it should be legally binding for those who sign up, overcoming early reservations from the United States.

It would be only the second such health accord after the 2003 Framework Convention on Tobacco Control, a treaty which aims to reduce smoking via taxation and rules on labelling and advertising.

- 15 However, the proposed pandemic treaty has come under fire on social media, mostly from right-wing critics warning it could lead to countries ceding authority to the WHO. The body strongly refutes this, stressing that governments are leading the negotiations and are free to reject the accord.

How do countries view the pact?

The European Union, which proposed the accord, is seen as its biggest backer. Developing countries, especially in Africa, are keen to use the negotiations to secure better access to vaccines, following allegations of "vaccine apartheid" from the WHO's Director-General Tedros.

- 20 After five rounds of formal negotiations, the latest 208-page draft of the treaty still includes thousands of brackets, which mark areas of disagreement or undecided language, including over the definition of the word "pandemic". With so many member countries involved, securing agreement may be tricky.

How would it work?

It is not yet clear how the 2005 regulations and the new pandemic accord might fit together.

- 25 One suggestion is that they should be complementary, so that existing rules apply to local outbreaks with the new rules kicking in if the WHO declares a pandemic - something it does not currently have a mandate to do.

It is also not yet clear what happens if the measures are not followed. A co-chair of the talks said it would be preferable to have a peer-review process, rather than sanction non-compliant states.

What other reforms are in the works?

- 30 Separate talks on reforming the 2005 rules are taking place, with countries proposing some 300 amendments.

Washington's initial proposals aimed to boost transparency and grant the WHO quicker access to outbreak sites.

- 35 China did allow WHO-led expert teams to visit the COVID-19 epicentre in Wuhan, but the WHO says Beijing is still withholding clinical data from early cases that may hold clues about the origins of the SARS-CoV-2 virus. Negotiators privately grumble about overlap between the two sets of talks and a joint meeting to clarify their agendas is planned.

See end of Reading 26 for discussion/reflection questions.

SECTION G: THE IMPACT OF GLOBAL HEALTH THREATS

Reading 26: Why the world's first pandemic treaty may never happen

EU 1, 3, 8

Ashleigh Furlong | Politico | 3 January 2024

This reading will help you understand:

- The practical challenges international organisations like WHO face in devising a global treaty for public health crises
- How forces like science and business have come into play to shape the kind of negotiations taking place for the pandemic treaty
- The underlying forces that govern international politics

A huge global effort to draw up rules around who does what in the event of another pandemic is floundering as memories of COVID-19 fade, raising a real possibility that talks will break down and leave the world as unprepared as it was in 2020.

5 The pandemic treaty, currently being negotiated through the World Health Organization (WHO), aims to prepare for the next global health emergency and prevent a repeat of what South Africa called “vaccine apartheid,” where countries had vastly unequal access to COVID vaccines and drugs.

It's meant to be a legally binding agreement that commits countries to monitor pandemic threats, beefs up their capacity to respond and sets out what nations would receive in return for sharing information on any disease-causing viruses or bacteria that they discover.

10 But two years since countries began brokering the rules, and with less than six months until the deadline for agreement, political attention has shifted to other issues and the usual compromises and concessions of international negotiations are nowhere to be seen, according to diplomats involved in the talks.

15 “If the countries ... really want to have a treaty, they actually need to start really negotiating, not restating their initial positions,” said a diplomat from a developing country, who, like the other diplomats in this article, POLITICO granted anonymity to speak about confidential talks. “Many countries ... just say, ‘we don’t want that,’ but they’re not really engaging with the text.”

20 Negotiators seem to be holding back on any shift in their positions to the last minute, a high-risk tactic which means that WHO member countries may well fail to agree substantial commitments by the deadline of May 2024.

While it's not unusual for negotiators to stall for time, the scale of the text, the lack of agreement on almost every aspect of it, and the fact there are only two official negotiating sessions left mean reaching agreement on the entire text at the eleventh hour would be a substantial undertaking.

25 A second diplomat, who is from a high-income country, told POLITICO that at the most recent talks, it “didn’t feel like we were really negotiating.” “Many state parties want to hold back some of their cards,” they said. “I guess we will need that time pressure for people to become more open about where they could give in ... We’re not yet there.”

30 A recent draft of the agreement, obtained by POLITICO, indicates that countries have shifted little in their initial positions on key provisions in the text, including on intellectual property rights, sharing information around pathogens, and transfer of technology.

Built on equity

A guiding principle for the agreement is the notion of equity, a concept notably lacking during the COVID-19 pandemic. This idea helped to get low- and middle-income countries on board with the idea of a pandemic treaty in the first place — and it’s now proving to be a red line.

35 Ensuring equity is seen as the “minimal acceptable” target, said the first diplomat. “Many developing countries [are] not going sign up to something at the end, that doesn’t actually deliver something concrete for equity,” they said.

A central sticking point is the so-called access and benefit sharing mechanism.

40 The idea is modelled after the WHO’s pandemic influenza preparedness framework, where countries share samples of circulating influenza viruses with pandemic potential, which can then be used by the pharmaceutical industry to produce vaccines. In turn, industry donates cash into a pot that is used to improve countries’ preparedness and response capacity.

For lower income countries, this mechanism is a “very important centerpiece” of the treaty, said the first diplomat. “What happened during the COVID-19 pandemic is that many countries shared both

pathogen samples and also genetic sequence data, and then they didn't get the benefits. That was a lesson that everybody took from that.”

But there are some key differences with the influenza framework, notably the fact that there aren't seasonal pandemic countermeasures, like there are for flu. The pharmaceutical industry fiercely opposes the mechanism, with the international pharma lobby describing it as a “transactional approach” that is “more than likely to delay access to pathogens and the timely development of medical countermeasures in the event of a pandemic.”

The U.S., EU, U.K., Canada, Switzerland and United Arab Emirates have all indicated that they aren't happy with the entire article on the mechanism.

The first diplomat said they believed that industry is the “main pressure” on high-income countries, with countries stating in talks that the private sector doesn't want the mechanism.

While there are also disagreements on provisions around waiving intellectual property rights and financing for pandemic preparedness, a third diplomat, who is from a high-income country, said that the landing ground on access and benefit sharing, “is going to become one of the really biggest issues for the negotiation.”

Broken promises

For civil society, which is closely watching negotiations — and in many cases briefing governments — there's both optimism and despair.

“We were promised that [this treaty] would be a tool to facilitate a more equitable response to pandemics,” said Jaume Vidal, senior policy adviser at access to medicines NGO Health Action International. “Now we're seeing, it's not only business as usual, but also some very dangerous side-slipping in the sense [that] now we're having governments saying, WHO shouldn't be dealing with IP at all,” he said.

Vidal fears that at “five minutes to midnight, developing countries will be forced to accept whatever consensus the EU and the U.S. can live with.”

Meanwhile, James Love, director of intellectual property NGO Knowledge Ecology International is still optimistic that an agreement will be reached. But to get there, he says countries need to actually negotiate.

In Love's mind, what's holding diplomats back is the belief that if they endorse a weaker proposal they will undermine their negotiating power. “It's like a bargaining chip. The problem is, everyone's holding on to the bargaining chips. No one's bargaining.”

For discussion/reflection:

- Based on Readings 26 & 27, summarise some of the challenges international bodies like WHO face when coordinating a global effort in the form of a pandemic treaty. In your opinion, can these challenges be overcome easily?
- Weighing the concept of national interest against global obligation, under what conditions/contexts is one more important than the other? Do relate your answer to the context of the Covid-19 pandemic.
- The guiding principle of achieving '[greater] equity' (line 31) is what drives the proposed pandemic treaty. Should high-income countries that have the resources and means be expected to do more for the global good?
- In Reading 27, a senior policy adviser of an NGO shares his fears that the lack of ongoing and sustained negotiation from countries would result in a fate where 'developing countries will be forced to accept whatever consensus the EU and the U.S. can live with' (lines 66-67). Reflecting on this statement and the previous question on achieving equity, what are your

views on limiting the influence of global powerhouses such as the U.S., China, and the UK?
What are some repercussions from doing so?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. 'A leader's responsibility should always be to his or her own country, not other nations.' Discuss. (Cambridge 2019)
2. How effective have global efforts been in addressing the spread of diseases? (RI Y6 CT1 2020)
3. 'The strong do what they want, the weak suffer what they must.' To what extent is this true of the world today? (RI Y6 CT2 2016)
4. 'We care for the developed world at the expense of the developing world.' Discuss. (RI Y6 CT2 2016)
5. 'International cooperation has not solved the global problems of today.' Do you agree? (RI Y6 CT2 2014)

SECTION G: THE IMPACT OF GLOBAL HEALTH THREATS

Reading 27: Afghanistan's drug trade is booming under Taliban rule

EU 1, 2, 8

Report | Atlantic Council | 24 August 2022

This reading helps you understand:

- Economic challenges and political control in a developing country can fuel a looming health crisis in a region
- The challenges faced by international agencies in curbing the global surge in drug trade and trafficking

Soon after taking power last August, the Taliban vowed to crack down on narcotics. Fast forward to April of this year, and they seemed to make good on that promise, issuing a decree that unequivocally banned the production and sale of illicit drugs.

Unfortunately, that decree has been inadequately enforced, and Afghanistan's drug trade is booming under Taliban rule.

It will be hard, if not impossible, for the regime to stamp out an industry which provides so many poor Afghans with a livelihood, especially amid the extreme economic and humanitarian crisis which has overtaken the country since last August. Afghanistan's drug economy expanded dramatically after the US- and NATO-led invasion in 2001. The amount of land under poppy cultivation almost tripled between 2002 and 2020, and the country also started to produce cheap methamphetamine using an abundant local plant—ephedra. So, how has Afghanistan's drug trade evolved under the Taliban regime?

Skyrocketing poppy production

According to the United Nations, in 2020, Afghanistan accounted for about 85 percent of global opium production. Under the former Republic, the drug trade was Afghanistan's largest economic sector, providing full-time employment to over half a million people. The most infamous component of this drug trade—poppy production—was so prosperous that experts doubted the Taliban's ability to deliver on its promise to ban drugs without immiserating large numbers of Afghans and fomenting resistance against their regime.

To the last point, while the Afghan economy began spiralling shortly after the Taliban takeover due to sanctions, the freezing of central bank assets, and removal of foreign aid deprived farmers of many

alternatives to opium cultivation. The economic crisis also robbed the Taliban regime of resources to fight drugs, exacerbated by the withdrawal of foreign law enforcement agencies which had assisted the previous Republic's efforts.

25 True, the Taliban movement managed to prohibit narcotics in 2000 during their previous spell in power. But it took the regime several attempts to stop opium cultivation. And the ban, when it came, angered rural Afghans, and was already at risk of unravelling by the time of 9/11. In this context of economic collapse and quickly-evaporating state resources, it came as little surprise when reports emerged in late 2021 that the Taliban didn't act against the poppy crop. Drought also made opium more appealing to farmers, as it can produce a yield even in dry conditions when the wheat crop might fail. "Both imagery and reports from the ground indicate there was widespread cultivation, particularly in the southwest, with the potential for a sizable crop in 2022," said David Mansfield, an independent consultant on illicit economies and an expert on the Afghan drugs trade, while speaking to me this month.

35 After the decree in April the Taliban tried to give off the impression that it was engaged in aggressive drug control, posting a photo in May of a tractor that was apparently destroying poppy in Helmand province. There were also reports of eradication in other parts of southwestern Afghanistan, suggesting this was more than a mere publicity stunt. But the poppy being targeted was the second opium crop of the season, which is much smaller than the first. Wiping it out thus makes little difference and throws into doubt the Taliban's intentions to actually ban cultivation.

Methamphetamine: The new drug on the block

40 Though less discussed than the poppy trade, the methamphetamine industry has also intensified in Afghanistan. Recent satellite imagery revealed an expansion of the Abdul Wadood bazaar, southwest Afghanistan's major meth hub, and more than 250 mounds (or an estimated 11,886 cubic meters) of ephedra.

45 Indeed, there was so much supply that, by early November, prices for ephedra had fallen drastically, from \$1.80 per kilogram in 2018 to \$0.63 per kilogram. But then, the Taliban imposed a little-noticed ban on the plant in December, and prices shot up. The decree was limited to a few provinces and came too late to affect the harvest, which had just ended. Most importantly, though, it actually benefited ephedrine and meth producers by boosting their profits, while increasing revenues to the Taliban who fined those transporting ephedra.

50 Yet again, the "bans" appeared to be more talk than walk.

Afghanistan is well connected to regional and global drug markets

Meanwhile, the trafficking of drugs via major highways out of Afghanistan remains high. Along the Balkan Route from Pakistan, Iran, and Turkey to Europe, heroin and meth continue to flow in large quantities, supplying markets throughout and outside Afghanistan's immediate region.

South Asia

55 At Torkham on the Afghanistan-Pakistan border, customs reportedly seized an "unprecedented" amount of drugs in late 2021 and early 2022, including a record 130 kilogram haul of heroin. October also saw one of the biggest meth busts in Peshawar's history. A Pakistani law enforcement official told me in January that trafficking had increased since the Taliban took over, having said in November that a "huge quantity" of narcotics was "reaching the coastal belt of Balochistan and Karachi." Seizures in that area have indeed been sizable. In May alone, Pakistan's Anti-Narcotics Force made a massive bust
60 of more than one ton of opiates and 255 kilograms of meth in the province of Balochistan, while the Pakistani Navy intercepted 4.5 tons of drugs in the northern Arabian Sea.

Furthermore, Pakistan is not only a transit country for methamphetamine leaving Afghanistan, but also a large market for the drug, which is popular in educational institutions. Pakistani drug treatment professionals told me that meth abuse was becoming rampant in the country.

65 Afghanistan-origin drugs also make their way across South Asia. Sri Lanka, where there have been repeated maritime hauls since the Taliban takeover, seized 325 kilograms of heroin and meth in April this year. In July, Nepal recorded an unusually large heroin bust which authorities suspect came from Afghanistan, pointing to a further expansion of the trade.

70 India is perhaps the most concerning part of the regional trafficking picture. With a massive population and a large number of opioid users, the country is highly susceptible to Afghanistan-origin drugs. In January, the Director-General of India's Narcotics Control Bureau S.N. Pradhan told me that the Taliban takeover could lead to a rise in drug-trafficking which already occurs along established smuggling routes via Punjab (sometimes using drones) or by sea to India's west coast.

75 Indeed, there have already been a series of drug seizures at Indian ports, most notably a vast haul of almost three tons of heroin at Mundra in Gujarat last September which allegedly originated in Kandahar, Afghanistan, before being trafficked to Iran and then on to India. In 2021, Gujarat police seized the highest amount of drugs in the history of the state, at least eight-hundred times more than the previous year. And the seizures have continued this year: in April, 260 kilograms of heroin were intercepted at Kandla port, and seventy-five kilograms from a container near Mundra in July.

Iran and Turkey

80 Narcotics trafficked from Afghanistan to Europe often travel through Pakistan and then Iran, where there have been massive busts in the southeast near the Afghan border. More than one hundred tons of drugs were seized in the area in the last eight months of 2021, according to local authorities.

85 Big hauls have continued this year. Only recently, over one ton of opium was grabbed in the southeast and a record-breaking 1.1 tons of meth found hidden in tankers entering from Afghanistan. An Iranian official said that seizures of Afghanistan-origin meth and heroin had increased. From Iran, narcotics enter Turkey. Traffickers are reportedly exploiting unprecedented refugee flows to smuggle drugs across the border. Turkish authorities have also reported large seizures, including more than a ton of liquid and crystal meth intercepted in Istanbul in May and another large bust in July.

90 The results of this are profound. Meth has reached every single Turkish province, the government claims, and was second only to cannabis as the most widely-used substance in Istanbul, according to wastewater analysis. It is therefore no surprise that Ankara is prioritizing meth and increasing its efforts to combat trafficking. In 2021, Turkey intercepted 5.5 tons of the drug, up from 4.1 tons the previous year. Notably, this is double the amount seized in Europe as a whole.

The broader Middle East and Central Asia

95 Afghanistan-origin meth has not only been flowing in large volumes to Iran, but also elsewhere in the region. There was an increase of "seizure events in the Near and Middle East" from 2020-2021, according to the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC). Iraq has also long been a destination for drugs smuggled from Iran, and in December reported a rise in drug-related arrests on its eastern border. Crystal meth accounted for 60 percent of the country's drug trade in 2021, feeding a growing problem of domestic misuse.

100 Then there is the Gulf, where the United Arab Emirates announced in June that crystal meth was one of the most commonly seized drugs, with large hauls such as a mammoth bust of more than one ton in Dubai last April. Oman has also intercepted meth this year.

105 Central Asia has not escaped the narcotics problem, either. According to the Global Initiative Against Transnational Organized Crime, drugs are smuggled through Tajikistan and Kyrgyzstan, and both have reported increased seizures this year. Tajikistan recorded a 52 percent rise in drug seizures during the first half of 2022, with its anti-narcotics chief stating that trafficking had increased since the Taliban took power. In Kyrgyzstan, about six tons of illicit drugs were intercepted in the first six months of 2022, 60 percent more than in the same period last year.

Continued trafficking from Afghanistan has also been noted by Russia—a key destination for drugs smuggled through Central Asia—whose foreign ministry lamented in November that the “drug threat” was still a “pressing problem” and that “the situation has not changed after the Taliban came to power.”

Sub-Saharan Africa

Then there is the Southern Route through Pakistan and Iran to Africa. Recent years have seen heroin and meth from Afghanistan seized in the Arabian Sea and Indian Ocean as it is trafficked to Mozambique or Tanzania and then on to South Africa and other countries. Last November, alone, there were eight separate drug interdictions along this trafficking route by international maritime forces, which in 2021 seized a record amount of heroin and three times more meth than any year since 2016.

At the start of this year, the Britain’s Royal Navy intercepted more than a ton of Afghanistan-origin heroin, hashish, and crystal meth in the Gulf of Oman, followed by another ninety kilograms of heroin in May. Farther afield, in South Africa, police seized seventy-five kilograms of heroin and meth in July and arrested a suspect allegedly connected to an Afghanistan-based drug gang, further evidence that Afghan drugs had penetrated African markets.

The Taliban’s narcotics “ban” is smoke-and-mirrors

The record so far strongly suggests that the Taliban has not enforced its narcotics ban. Drug production and trafficking have remained at high levels or increased since the change of regime in Afghanistan. Furthermore, given that these problems are international in nature, a regional effort is needed to combat them. India, for one, has stepped up its anti-drug diplomacy with Iran, attending three days of meetings in Tehran this summer. But old rivalries undermine a comprehensive approach. India convened a meeting of national security chiefs to discuss drugs and other issues in Delhi last November, but Pakistan and China were absent.

While Afghanistan’s drug trade is indeed a global phenomenon, that should not distract us from the apparently rising levels of substance abuse in the country as desperate and impoverished Afghans try to lose themselves in narcotics. Many addicts are apparently left to die in public. And, on those occasions when the Taliban does try to do something, its approach has been brutal, rounding up drug users, shaving their heads, and beating them or dousing them in water.

The new government does seem to have boosted revenue by rigorously enforcing border controls, according to a new report by David Mansfield. But imports are subject to more stringent checks than exports, Mansfield told me this month. And there is no evidence that the Taliban’s crackdown extends to drug-trafficking, nor sign of a shortage of drugs along the main trafficking routes out of Afghanistan. Far from it: large seizures point to high volumes of smuggled narcotics.

The long-term consequences of these factors remains yet to be seen

The future, however, is uncertain. According to Mansfield, the price of meth, and to a lesser extent opiates, remains elevated, reflecting concerns about prohibition. He also told me this month that the Taliban—facing sanctions and looking to attract development assistance—could potentially move against ephedra (targeting meth production) without causing widespread unemployment.

But it would be much harder for them to rein in the opium industry without plunging hundreds of thousands of Afghans into deeper poverty. For that reason, a sweeping drugs ban would be very difficult to sustain. And, even if the Taliban did stamp out opiates, that could cause additional problems if countries tried to substitute heroin with opioids such as fentanyl, which happened in North America with devastating consequences. There are already signs of synthetic opioid use in Afghanistan, where pills known as “Tablet K” have been found that contain tramadol. In Pakistan, fentanyl seizures increased last year, too. India must also be considered particularly vulnerable to such

a scenario, seeing as it has large numbers of opioid users and a massive, poorly-regulated chemical and pharmaceutical industry to supply them.

Whatever happens, South Asia's drug problems are here to stay.

For discussion/reflection:

- What is one way in which ordinary Afghans may be harmed if the Taliban makes good on "its promise to ban drugs" (line 17)?
- What problems do the drugs reported present for local and global health agencies at present and in the long term?
- Explain the effect of "unprecedented" (line 86) migration flows on the problem of drug trafficking.
- Identify relevant characteristics of Afghanistan – including its state of development and level of political stability – that could be useful in explaining Afghanistan's role in fuelling the drug trade and health crises affecting the region.
- Do developed nations have a global obligation to counter the drug scourge in Afghanistan and the surrounding region? Why or why not?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. 'International organisations are ineffective at resolving conflict.' To what extent do you agree? (RI Y6 Timed Practice 2021)
2. 'Leading healthy lives is increasingly challenging in today's world.' Discuss. (RI Y5 Promo 2019)
3. 'International cooperation has not solved the global problems of today.' Do you agree? (RI Y6 CT2 2014)
4. 'Globalisation has made us more vulnerable.' To what extent is this true? (RI Y6 CT1 2013)